

# THE OBSERVATION CAR



By Ralph M. Butler and Opus 4.6

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## **Acknowledgments**

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## Chapter 1: The Silver Lining and the Slower Lane

My name is Hazel, and I have always found that people will tell you their most embarrassing secrets if you just offer them a second napkin. It's a trick I learned during ten years as a school secretary and another thirty-five as a midwife. People see a woman of a certain age with a sensible cardigan and a tin of homemade shortbread, and they assume your brain is mostly occupied by knitting patterns and the price of eggs.

It is a very useful way to be invisible.

We were currently three hours out of Chicago, hurtling—if you can call it hurtling when the train is already twenty minutes behind schedule—toward the Rockies on the *Starlight Express*. It was a private charter, all brass fittings and mahogany panels, designed to make you feel like you were in a black-and-white movie, provided the movie had Wi-Fi and better plumbing. We'd booked through a luxury travel catalogue — “Rocky Mountain Heritage Experience,” which sounded lovely until we arrived and discovered the whole train belonged to a billionaire who'd sold off the extra suites to strangers. By then we'd paid the deposit, and I wasn't about to cancel Frank's trip over someone else's ego. Through the observation windows the light was doing that late-afternoon thing it does in the flatlands, turning everything gold and long-shadowed, and the grain elevators passing in the distance looked like cathedrals for people who worship corn.

Frank would have loved it. He talked about riding a train through the Rockies for twenty-odd years, and he collected timetables the way other men collect stamps or grudges—dozens of them, stuffed into a shoebox under the bed where a normal person might keep slippers. He never booked the trip. There was always a reason: the kitchen needed doing, or his hip was playing up, or he'd just found a cheaper route that left from Milwaukee and wanted to “compare options” for another six months. Then he died, and the shoebox was still under the bed, and here I am on the train without him, which I think he would find both touching and deeply annoying.

“The structural integrity of this observation car is surprisingly sound for a vintage retrofit,” Bernie remarked, peering over his spectacles at a rivet in the ceiling. Bernie was a retired actuary who viewed the entire world

as a series of probability tables. He was currently calculating the exact likelihood of us reaching Omaha before the pot roast ran out.

“It’s a tin can on wheels, Bernie,” Arthur grumbled from the seat across from us. Arthur was a retired U.S. Marshal whose stillness made people instinctively check if they’d forgotten to pay a parking ticket. He was currently mourning the fact that the train’s “luxury” didn’t include extra legroom for his knees.

I patted Arthur’s hand. “It’s lovely, Arthur. Look at the light on those silos. It’s very ‘Americana.’ Besides, the tea is actually hot, which is more than I can say for that cruise we took last year.”

Bernie looked up from his rivet and out the window for a moment. He didn’t say anything, which is unusual for Bernie, and then he adjusted his spectacles and went back to the specialized GPS and atmospheric tracker he’d brought along specifically to monitor the effects of high-altitude travel. I’ve known him long enough to know that Bernie looks at scenery the way other people look at churches—privately, and only when he thinks no one’s watching.

The Conductor came through our section — a tall man in a uniform pressed to standards that would have satisfied Frank’s mother, which is the highest praise I can offer. He touched his cap.

“Mrs. Finch, Mr. Kaine, Mr. Pollard. Welcome aboard. I’m Raymond.” He’d learned our names from the manifest, and he said them like they mattered. “We’ll start picking up real altitude tomorrow afternoon. The observation car’s the best spot for tomorrow’s sunset — there’s a stretch near the Front Range where the light does something I’ve never been able to describe properly, even after twenty-five years working trains. The last fifteen of them on this route.”

“Twenty-five years,” Bernie said, looking up from his tracker. “You must know every rivet.”

“Every rivet and most of their moods.” He smiled — brief, warm, the smile of a man who liked his work and saw no reason to hide it. “If you need anything, I’m usually somewhere between car three and the engine.”

He moved on, checking a window latch as he went — the kind of small maintenance most people wouldn't notice and that makes the difference between a train that runs and one that runs well.

I didn't mention that I was also watching the man in the far corner — Sterling Vance. I knew his face from the papers, usually positioned above a headline about “streamlining” or “restructuring,” which is billionaire-speak for taking things away from people who earned them. He was currently berating a young waiter because his sparkling water wasn't “effervescent” enough.

“He's a delightful man,” I whispered, loud enough for only my two companions to hear.

“He's a walking cardiac event,” Bernie noted, not looking up from his GPS tracker. “Statistically, men with that neck-to-waist ratio and that level of cortisol shouldn't be traveling at high altitudes.”

Arthur's eyes narrowed as he watched Vance dismiss the waiter with a flick of a diamond-crusted wrist. “He's got a bodyguard down the corridor and a suite that costs more than my first house. Men like that don't just travel; they occupy.”

I took a sip of my Earl Grey. It was a bit over-steeped, but I didn't mind. I was busy noticing that Sterling Vance's private nurse, a girl with tired eyes and very aggressive knitting needles, was watching him with a look that wasn't exactly medical. She had the particular stillness of someone who has been counting down to something for a long time and has gotten very good at waiting.

Across the aisle, a young woman with a camera tripod that looked like a silver spider was filming the observation car from what I believe is called “every possible angle.” She had a tiny microphone clipped to her silk scarf and kept whispering things like “authentic luxury” and “golden hour magic” into it with the intensity of someone dictating a peace treaty. I didn't know her name yet, but I knew the type—the sort of person who photographs their breakfast before they eat it and considers this a profession.

Outside, the wheels kept their rhythm on the track—that low, steady thrum you feel more than hear, the kind of sound that makes you sleepy if you’re the sort of person who can let things go, which I have never been. The dining car was starting its evening prep, and the smell of roasting something drifted through—rosemary, and butter, and the particular warmth of a kitchen where someone is taking their work seriously. The train swayed gently through a long curve, and the light shifted, and for a moment the whole observation car looked like the inside of a jewelry box.

“Well,” I said, smoothing my skirt. “I think it’s going to be a very interesting trip. Would either of you like a biscuit? I brought the ones with the lemon zest.”



## Chapter 2: The Ascent

The *Starlight Express* began its climb into the Front Range as the sun dropped toward the Rockies, and the sky turned the color of an old bruise. Inside the train the change was subtle — a deepening in the rhythm of the wheels, a heavier thrum through the floorboards, the kind of shift you felt in your chest before you heard it in your ears. The golden flatlands of yesterday were a full day behind them, crossed in the night and traded through a long climbing morning for foothills, then for granite. Outside the windows, granite and pine pressed close, and the air had that thin, dry quality that makes everything feel slightly more difficult than it should be.

The train was preparing for dinner — slowly, with friction, everyone moving through the same corridors in different directions for different reasons.

In the galley, Chef Julian adjusted the flame under a copper sauté pan that didn't need adjusting. He checked the clock above the service pass — 4:47. The soufflé for the Welcome Dinner wouldn't go in for another hour, but the mise en place was already arranged across his station with geometric precision — presentation began long before the plate. He wiped his hands on his apron, moved a bowl of shallots two inches to the left, and checked the clock again. Every few minutes his eyes drifted to the service entrance at the rear of the car, and then to the window, where the signal bars on his phone had been dropping steadily since they'd passed the last town.

A car forward, in the Golden Spike suite, Sterling Vance sat at his mahogany desk with a crystal decanter at his elbow and a leather-bound ledger open in front of him. The Banker's lamp threw a warm circle across the pages, and beyond that circle the room was dim — heavy curtains drawn, the Art Deco panels catching the lamplight in thin gold lines. A plastic pill organizer sat near the lamp's base, the kind with days of the week and AM/PM compartments, prosaic and ugly against the mahogany. The PM compartment for today was closed, the pills inside visible through the translucent lid. He'd take them when Elena brought the evening round, or he'd take them himself if she took too long. He wasn't a man who waited for other people to manage things he could manage faster.

He uncapped his fountain pen and began to write, but the pen wandered. His script, usually a sharp, impatient slash across the page, softened and drifted to the right.

At five o'clock, Elena Voss walked the Pullman corridor toward the Golden Spike suite. Her shoes were quiet on the carpet, and she carried her small leather medication case in both hands, held slightly in front of her, not quite offering, not quite withholding. The corridor was empty except for a steward polishing a handrail three doors back and, at the far end near the connecting door, Miller — Vance's bodyguard, dismissed to his own suite at four o'clock like everyone else — stretching his legs, rolling his shoulders against the stiffness of a chair that wasn't built for him.

She slowed as she reached the suite door. She could hear nothing inside — no scratch of pen, no clink of glass, no intercom summons. She raised her hand to knock. Her knuckles hovered an inch from the wood. She stood like that for several seconds, the medication case pressed against her ribs, her eyes on the closed door, and then she lowered her hand and adjusted something inside the case — a clasp, a bottle, a rearrangement that might have been professional habit. She turned and walked back the way she'd come, her pace slightly faster than it had been on the approach. Miller glanced up from his shoulder roll and watched her pass. She didn't look at him. He went back to stretching.

Outside, the grade steepened and the pines thinned to rock and scrub. The late afternoon light caught the granite faces of the mountains and threw long shadows across the track. Raymond's voice came through the speakers — calm, unhurried, the same warmth he'd shown in the observation car the day before: "Good evening, ladies and gentlemen. We'll be gaining altitude through the evening — we're entering the Front Range, which is the stretch I mentioned where the light does its best work. Some passengers may notice mild changes in air pressure. Entirely normal for the route. Dinner service begins at seven, and the dining car has outdone itself tonight."

At five-thirty, Julian wiped his hands, checked the clock, and picked up a small tray from the prep station. On it: seared duck liver on brioche, a fig reduction, a curl of aged Gruyère. A tasting plate — an offering to let the

host know that dinner will be worth the wait. He smoothed his jacket and walked through the service corridor to the Pullman car.

He knocked on the Golden Spike door. A muffled voice inside said something short — permission or dismissal, hard to tell through mahogany. A bolt turned, then a second, and Julian opened the door and stepped in. The door closed behind him.

In the corridor, the silence held. The ventilation hissed in the overhead ducts. The velvet curtains along the walls hung still in the warm air.

Two minutes later, Julian came out. He carried the tray at his side, the tasting plate still on it — the brioche, the Gruyère, the fig reduction untouched, exactly as he'd arranged them. His expression was difficult to read — the tightness around his mouth could have been wounded pride, or embarrassment, or the particular stillness of a man processing something he hadn't expected. He pulled the door shut and walked back toward the galley without hurrying, but his free hand went to his watch. As he passed the service corridor, he paused and looked toward the narrow door that led down to the cargo holds — a quick look, purposeful, not furtive. Then he continued on.

In the galley, he set the tray on the counter, slid the untouched food into the waste, and wiped the tray down — once, twice, the motions tight and repetitive, cleaning a surface that was already clean. He checked the clock. He stepped into the narrow corridor that led to the cargo hold, opened a service locker, looked inside at something he didn't take out, and closed it again. He was back at his station in under a minute, adjusting the flame on a pan that didn't need adjusting.

At a quarter to six, the Conductor came forward on his early round with a cup of chamomile on a saucer, the way he had every evening since Chicago. He was inside the Golden Spike suite for less than a minute — long enough to set the cup on the side table of a man who never drank it and to wish him a good dinner — and on his way back down the corridor he paused at the velvet curtain near the suite, adjusted something behind the fabric, and straightened the curtain. A man checking a fitting. The corridor settled back into its silence.

In the suite, Vance tugged at his silk tie. The room felt close, but rooms on trains always felt close to Vance — he was a man built for boardrooms with thirty-foot ceilings, not Pullman suites, however gilded. Vance reached for the decanter, poured an inch of whiskey, and lifted the glass. He set it down without drinking. Something in his mouth tasted wrong — bitter, metallic, arriving without explanation and sitting on the back of the tongue. He pressed the intercom button. “Hello,” he said. Static, then nothing. He released it.

The pill organizer’s PM compartment was open now. Empty.

On the side table, next to a crystal ashtray he hadn’t used, the orchid was beginning to curl at its edges, the pale petals drawing inward against air that wasn’t what it should be.

The dining car was being set for the Welcome Dinner. Stewards moved between tables laying silver and straightening linen, their reflections ghosting across the dark windows. The Head Steward stood at the service pass conferring with a junior about the wine service, his voice low and precise. Through the galley door, the sound of copper pans and running water. Through the observation car windows, the mountains were losing their edges to cloud, the peaks dissolving into gray from the top down.

The Conductor walked his pre-dinner rounds. His shoes were polished to a shine that takes daily attention, and his uniform creased as sharp as a creed. He nodded to a steward carrying linens. He checked the latch on a luggage compartment. He checked a window seal where the weather stripping had been replaced last month. He straightened a curtain tassel that was already straight.

At the velvet curtain near the Golden Spike suite, he paused and checked something behind the fabric — a fitting, a latch — and straightened the curtain and moved on.

Behind him, a steward came through the connecting door with a stack of pressed napkins, passed the same curtained panels without a glance, and disappeared into the dining car.

In the galley, Julian checked the clock — 6:47 — and began plating the amuse-bouche. In the corridor, a steward knocked on cabin doors with the quiet announcement that dinner would begin in twelve minutes. In the observation car, the last of the daylight slid off the granite peaks and was gone, and the windows became mirrors, showing the passengers their own reflections against the mountain dark.

In the Golden Spike suite, Vance's pen had stopped moving. It lay at the edge of the desk, perfectly still, as though it had been placed there. His hand rested on the ledger, fingers slightly open, and his cheek had come to rest against the page. The lamp still burned. The room was very quiet, the way a room gets when the only person in it has stopped breathing.

The orchid continued its slow curl inward. The pill organizer sat open and empty beside the lamp. And the inch of whiskey sat untouched at his elbow, poured for a man who would not finish anything again.

The Welcome Dinner was set to begin in twelve minutes. Everything was exactly on time.

## Chapter 3: The Empty Chair

There is a very specific type of silence that happens in a crowded room when everyone is trying to pretend they aren't waiting for someone important to show up. It's a brittle, glassy kind of quiet, filled with the clinking of silver against china and the sound of people clearing their throats. I have spent enough years in school front offices to recognize it immediately—it's the same silence that fills a room when the principal is late to his own assembly and everyone is wondering whether to start without him or sit there looking at their shoes.

The dining car was a sea of white linen and flickering candlelight. Bernie was occupied with a measurement of the soup spoon's curvature—"surprisingly ergonomic for a vintage set, although the weight distribution favors right-handed users"—and Arthur was staring at the entrance with the steady focus of a man who has spent his career waiting for the wrong person to walk through a door.

"He's late," Arthur said, checking his watch for the fourth time in ten minutes. "Men like Vance are never late. They make other people late to prove they're in charge, but they are always exactly where they intend to be."

Sterling Vance had chartered the *Starlight Express* — the whole train, Chicago to San Francisco — and then sold off the extra suites to paying guests, the way a man who buys a yacht still takes on passengers to cover the fuel. We'd booked ours through a luxury travel catalogue eight months ago without knowing whose party we were joining. But it was his party. He'd approved the menu, the wine list, the seating, and when the man who chartered your train hasn't sat down, nobody pours the wine. The Head Steward had been hovering near the service pass for ten minutes, a bottle of something French and expensive sweating in his hands.

"Perhaps he's just having a nap," I suggested, though I didn't believe it for a second. "The altitude can make one very drowsy. I remember when we went to the Smokies in '98, Arthur, you slept through an entire bluegrass festival."

“The music sounds better with your eyes closed, Hazel. And we are currently at nine thousand feet. It’s a different kind of air.”

He was right about the air. It had been changing since we’d started climbing—thinner, drier, the sort of air that makes you take a slightly deeper breath without knowing why. Frank used to say that mountains made him feel like his lungs were working overtime for the same pay, which was the kind of observation Frank considered very witty and which I had to hear roughly forty times over forty years of marriage.

I looked over at Elena, the nurse. She was sitting at her small table near the kitchen galley, her knitting bag tucked under her chair and her leather medication case on the seat beside her. She wasn’t eating. She was shredding a bread roll into tiny, uniform crumbs, and her eyes were on the table, not the door—which told me something. People who are waiting look at the door. People who have already gone to the door and come back empty-handed look at their hands. Elena had the tight stillness of a nurse stopped mid-task by a locked door, sitting with the question of what to do next. I’ve seen that look on the maternity ward, on the faces of nurses who knocked and got no answer and are trying to decide how loud to knock the second time.

The silver-spider-tripod woman—Skye, I’d learned her name was—was at a corner table, still filming her meal from angles that suggested the salmon had done something personally offensive to her. But I noticed that every time the staff door opened, her phone dipped and her eyes went to whoever came through, quick and sharp, before the camera came back up. She was looking for someone specific, and it wasn’t the sommelier.

Elena stood up. She smoothed her skirt the way you do when you’ve made a decision, picked up her medication case, and crossed the dining car to where Raymond was standing near the service entrance, hands clasped behind his back, surveying the room with the calm attention of a man whose train was running precisely on schedule. She spoke to him quietly—I couldn’t hear the words, but I could read her posture: the medication case held up slightly, the quick shake of her head, the way her free hand gestured back toward the corridor. The door is locked, she was telling him. He isn’t answering.

Raymond listened, nodded once, and said something brief — reassuring, from the set of his shoulders. Elena came back to her table and sat down. Raymond straightened his jacket, spoke a word to the Head Steward, and left the dining car through the staff entrance. His walk was unhurried. A man going to rouse a sleeping passenger, nothing more.

“The bisque is lukewarm,” Bernie announced, tapping his spoon against the rim of his bowl. “The thermal dissipation in this car is remarkable. If the convection currents were managed properly, the temperature would hold for another six minutes at minimum. Also, the barometric reading on my tracker is inconsistent with our elevation. I don’t quite understand it.”

“Bernie, dear, no one cares about the bisque,” I said, patting his arm. Though I did make a note of the barometric business. Bernie says a great many things that sound like filler and turn out to be the only thing in the conversation worth remembering.

I watched the dining car settle into the particular discomfort of people who know they are waiting but haven’t agreed to admit it. Forks moved. Water was sipped. No one looked at the staff door. Everyone was aware of the staff door. Elena had stopped shredding bread and was gripping her knitting needles without knitting, the yarn slack in her lap, her eyes on the middle distance.

Raymond came back. I don’t know how long he’d been gone — five minutes, perhaps seven — but I knew the moment he stepped through the staff entrance that the answer was not the one anyone wanted. His stride had shortened, and his cap was sitting a fraction to the left, which on a man that precise was the equivalent of arriving with his shirt untucked. The warmth I’d liked about him that afternoon was gone from his face, replaced by something tight and careful. He walked straight to the Head Steward and whispered something that made the Steward’s face go the color of a bleached napkin.

“Something’s happened,” Arthur said, half-rising from his chair. His voice had changed—lower, flatter, the one that used to make people stop what they were doing and start producing identification.



Just then, my ears gave a sharp, uncomfortable pop, the kind that makes you swallow hard to clear the pressure. Around the room, I saw other passengers doing the same—frowning, rubbing their jaws, or tilting their heads.

Bernie didn't rub his ears. He was staring at the digital screen of his tracker, his thumb hovering over the glass. "That's just the altitude," he muttered. "We've gained almost two thousand feet since lunch." He tapped the screen. "But the barometric reading still doesn't match. The pressurization system on this train should be compensating more smoothly than this — we shouldn't feel the climb at all in a sealed vessel." He frowned at the numbers. "Interesting system. I'd like to know how it works."

"Stay down, Arthur," I whispered, reaching for my purse. "We don't want to make a scene. Not before the main course."

But the main course wasn't going to matter. I could feel it in the way the air in the dining car had shifted — not the altitude this time, but the heaviness that fills a room when something has ended somewhere nearby. I've been around enough beginnings and enough endings to know the difference, and this wasn't a beginning. I looked back at Elena. She was looking at Raymond's face across the room, and her hands had gone still on the needles, and I saw the exact moment she understood, because her mouth opened very slightly and then closed again, and she set the needles down on the table with the care of someone putting down something breakable. Her other hand went to the leather medication case on the seat beside her — not opening it, just touching it, the way a nurse reaches for her bag when she hears a sound she doesn't like. A reflex. The fingers closed around the clasp and stayed there.

She had sent him to check. And from the look on his face when he came back, she already knew.

"Bernie," I said quietly. "I think you should put your spoon down. I don't think we'll be finishing the soup."

## Chapter 4: The Golden Spike

The dining car had gone as still as a held breath. Arthur didn't wait for permission. He stood up with the slow, deliberate grace of a man who had spent thirty years being the most important person in any room with a problem. He caught Raymond's eye as the conductor turned to leave the Steward, and something in Arthur's squared shoulders made Raymond wait for him.

"You're going to check the suite," Arthur said. It wasn't a question. "I'm Arthur Kaine, U.S. Marshals Service, retired. This is my associate, Mr. Pollard, and our medical advisor, Mrs. Finch. We're coming with you."

Raymond hesitated, then nodded and led the way. The corridor was quiet, the only sound the steady hiss of the ventilation and the clacking of the wheels beneath them.

"Mr. Vance is very particular about his privacy," the Head Steward whispered as they reached the Golden Spike door. "He double-locks the suite every afternoon at four. He told his security man, Miller, to stay in his own suite until dinner. He didn't want anyone hovering."

"And the nurse?" Arthur asked.

"She was told the same, sir. He was very insistent. He said he wanted to work on his ledgers without being 'coddled.'"

Raymond reached the door of the Golden Spike suite, his brass key already in his hand.

The Golden Spike suite was a masterpiece of Art Deco excess — geometric panels in gold and cream, a mahogany desk that belonged in a senator's office, heavy brocade curtains drawn tight against the mountain dark outside. But as the door swung open on Raymond's brass key, the room's elegance felt sealed and airless, like a museum case that hadn't been opened in years.

"Nobody move," Arthur said, and the way he said it stopped Raymond and the Head Steward mid-step, as though they'd walked into a wall they couldn't see. He stepped over the threshold alone.

Just then, a man in a dark suit appeared at the end of the corridor — thick-shouldered, with weary, alert eyes — too many years of waiting for something to happen. He stopped when he saw the group around the open door.

“What’s going on?” he asked, his voice low and raspy. “I’m Miller. Security for Mr. Vance.”

“Stay where you are, Mr. Miller,” Arthur said, not turning back from the body. “I’m Arthur Kaine, U.S. Marshals Service, retired. This is a crime scene. I need you to hold the perimeter at that end of the corridor. Do not let anyone through. Is that understood?”

Miller hesitated, looking from Arthur’s back to Raymond’s pale face, and then he nodded once, a sharp, professional acknowledgment. He didn’t ask questions. He stood his ground and turned to face the way he’d come.

Sterling Vance was slumped forward over his desk, his cheek resting against the open page of a leather-bound ledger. The Banker’s lamp cast its warm circle over his hands and the ledger and nothing else, and in that light the room looked almost peaceful — someone fallen asleep over his figures. The crystal decanter sat at his elbow, and beside it a glass holding its inch of whiskey, poured and never drunk. His silver fountain pen had come to rest at the very edge of the desk, perfectly parallel to the grain of the wood, settled there by gravity and silence.

Arthur leaned over the body without touching it. The fingernails had a faint blue tint — barely visible in the lamplight, but there if you knew to look for it. The skin of the face was slack but not contorted, the mouth slightly open, the expression closer to confusion than to pain. No bruising on the hands. No defensive marks. Whatever had happened to Sterling Vance, he hadn’t fought it. He might not have known it was happening. The blue nails. He’d seen cyanosis before — on bodies pulled from water, on overdoses in motel rooms, on a man who’d died in a sealed garage with the engine running. It meant the blood wasn’t carrying oxygen. It didn’t tell you why.

“Bernie. Get in here.”

Bernie shuffled past Raymond, adjusting his spectacles, and did something Arthur hadn't expected — he ignored the body entirely. He went first to the barometer mounted on the far wall and squinted at it, tilting his head as though it had said something rude to him. Then he turned to the side table, where a pale orchid sat in a ceramic pot beside a crystal ashtray that hadn't been used. The flower had curled inward on itself, the petals drawn tight and faintly brown at the edges.

"The barometric reading is consistent with ten thousand feet," Bernie said, still looking at the orchid. "But this *Cattleya* — the leaf apertures are closed. That's a defensive response to elevated carbon dioxide. This plant has been breathing air that a pressurized cabin shouldn't have." He touched one curled petal with a trembling finger. "The reading I got at dinner — the sawtooth on my tracker — this could explain it. If the airflow to this suite was disrupted somehow, the CO<sub>2</sub> would climb and the oxygen would drop. The main system would fight to compensate for the rest of the car, which is what we all felt — the ear pop."

"Could the altitude alone do that?" Arthur asked. "We're at ten thousand feet. The system's working harder."

Bernie hesitated. "Possibly. The pass approach puts stress on the pressurization. I'd need baseline data from a normal crossing to know whether the anomaly was natural or —" He stopped himself. "I'm not ready to say. The data is consistent with a disruption. It's also consistent with the altitude. I need more."

"And the door?" Arthur asked, turning back to Raymond.

"Double-locked from the inside, sir," Raymond said, his voice leveling. "Mr. Vance always engaged both locks. I had to use the master override to enter. It's a sealed system — no access from the corridor without the key."

Arthur's gaze drifted to the ventilation grate near the ceiling — a brass-fitted rectangle, decorative and functional, the same as every other grate on the train. It looked perfectly ordinary. He filed it alongside the cyanosis — a detail without a theory, waiting.

Hazel was standing in the doorway. She had been standing there for some time, letting Arthur and Bernie do the things men do in rooms like this — measure, examine, ask questions that have answers. She wasn't looking at the body, or at the ventilation grate, or at the orchid that Bernie was still examining as though he'd found a number that didn't belong in a column. She was taking in the room — the whole of it, the feel of it, the smell of it. The air was stale and close, with a faint sourness underneath the whiskey and the wood polish, stale air that hadn't been moving properly. The Banker's lamp was still on, and the ledger was open, and the decanter still had whiskey in it, and the curtains were drawn, and all of it looked exactly like an evening interrupted — and nobody had got up to answer the door.

Near the base of the lamp, a plastic pill organizer sat on the mahogany — the kind with days of the week and compartments for morning and evening, cheap and functional, the one ugly thing in the room. The PM slot for today was open. Empty. Hazel looked at it without interpretation, without comment — the same quiet attention she was giving the slippers and the orchid. She just noticed that Vance — whose nurse had been turned away from his door — had somehow taken his evening medication, or it had been taken for him, or the compartment had been emptied for a reason that wasn't medical at all.

And under the chair, a pair of silk slippers had been tucked neatly side by side, the toes aligned, the heels flush against the chair leg. It was the tidiness of bedtime preparation — not of slumping sideways without warning. Hazel looked at the slippers and then she looked at the slumped figure and she didn't say anything about it. She just looked.

Elena arrived. Someone had gone to fetch her, and she came quickly, her leather medication case in one hand and the knitting bag in the other, as though she'd grabbed both on reflex and hadn't thought about which one she needed. Her face when she saw Vance was complicated — shock, yes, the widening of the eyes and the small intake of breath, but underneath it something else that moved too fast to name. She set the knitting bag on the floor and went to him with practiced efficiency — a thousand sets of

vital signs behind her — pressing two fingers to his neck, lifting his wrist, holding it, setting it down.

“He’s gone,” she said. Her voice was steady and professional, the nurse’s voice, the one that held even when everything else didn’t.

She straightened up and looked at the desk. Her gaze found the pill organizer — the open PM slot, the empty compartment — and something changed in her face. A tightening around the mouth, a flicker behind the eyes. She said, very quietly, “He shouldn’t have —” and stopped.

“Shouldn’t have what?” Arthur said.

“The evening dose. I was supposed to — I usually —” She pressed her lips together. “Never mind. It doesn’t matter now.”

But she was already opening her medication case, her fingers moving through the bottles with a quick, precise inventory — she knew exactly what should be there. She stopped. Her hand hovered over a gap in the row — a space where a bottle had been, the felt lining still holding the impression. She stared at it for two seconds, maybe three. Then she closed the case and said nothing.

Arthur saw her face change — another reaction without an explanation, waiting for a theory to attach itself to.

Bernie, still at the orchid, had turned to look at Vance’s hands. The blue tint under the nails. He pulled out his tracker and checked the reading, then looked at the orchid again, and then at the grate near the ceiling. “The cyanosis is consistent with oxygen deprivation,” he said, more to himself than anyone. Then, after a pause: “It’s also consistent with cardiac arrest. Or a dozen other things. I can’t tell you which from a fingernail.”

Elena heard him. She looked at the fingernails and her jaw tightened, and she said nothing, but her hand went back to the medication case on the desk and rested there, her fingers curling around the clasp.

“It’s a natural tragedy,” Raymond said, stepping forward. His voice had steadied — the warmth Arthur had noticed earlier replaced by something careful and official. “The altitude. The strain on the heart. These things happen at elevation. We’ll notify the authorities at the next stop and —”

“No,” Arthur said, and he turned to face Raymond with the full weight of thirty years of standing in rooms where someone had died and someone else was lying about it. “We won’t be touching a thing until we reach San Francisco. And until then, this room is under my jurisdiction.”

He didn’t have a badge anymore, and his legal authority was exactly zero, but Arthur Kaine knew how to make a sentence sound like a federal mandate. It was a bluff — a calculated piece of theater designed to stop the room from being scrubbed clean before the truth could surface.

Raymond nodded once — obedience to a higher authority, automatic and complete. Behind them, the Head Steward shifted his weight from one foot to the other and said nothing.

In the corridor, half-hidden by the curtained archway, a phone screen glowed in the dim light. Skye held it low against her hip, angled toward the open door, recording without performing. Her face above the screen was still and focused — not the face of a content creator but of something sharper, something that had been waiting for exactly this and knew what to do with it.

## Chapter 5: The Midnight Steep

My cabin was small enough that if I stretched both arms I could touch both walls, which Frank would have considered a design flaw and I considered cozy. There was a single berth, a reading lamp with a brass neck that reminded me of a goose, and a window that showed nothing but dark pines sliding past, silent and unhurried, the mountains at one in the morning doing what mountains do whether you're watching or not.

I had managed to procure a kettle — never mind how — and the point is I had hot water and a tin of the lemon biscuits and two spare cups, which is really all you need to hold a meeting.

Frank's timetable was on the nightstand. I'd tucked it into the suitcase at the last minute — not from the shoebox under the bed where his dozens lived, but from the hall table drawer where he'd kept this one apart, the Chicago-to-San-Francisco route he'd annotated in blue ballpoint and his terrible handwriting. He'd written "window seat — LEFT side for Rockies" in the margin, underlined twice, as though the Rockies might move to the other side of the train if he wasn't firm about it. I hadn't looked at it since packing it. I wasn't going to look at it now. It was just there, the way Frank's things tend to be — present, unhelpful, and impossible to throw away.

Arthur arrived first, his knees announcing him before his knock did. Bernie came a minute later, bumped his head on the luggage rack, said "the clearance in this corridor is a genuine hazard," and sat on the fold-down table, which creaked but held. I poured the tea and distributed biscuits without asking if anyone wanted one, because of course they did, and because giving people something to hold makes them talk more honestly. That's not a trick I learned in any book. That's just knowing people.

Bernie set his notebook on the table, open to a small precise diagram of the train he'd been working on since breakfast. He had it laid out from front to back: the engine and the working cars at the head; then the forward Pullman, where Vance's Golden Spike suite sat with the conductor's cabin two doors along and Miller's suite and our own cabins down the same passage; then the dining car and Julian's galley, with the crew quarters tucked behind it; then the rear Pullman, where Skye's cabin sat at the far end nearest the crew passage; and the observation car at the back. He'd



marked the maintenance panels with neat X's. He had not labeled himself, because Bernie did not consider himself a feature of the geography.

Earlier that evening, Arthur and the Head Steward had moved the body out of the suite. It was the one exception to Arthur's "don't touch anything" rule — even he conceded you cannot leave a man on his desk for five days. The body went to the rear baggage compartment, unheated and cold enough at altitude to do what a morgue would do at sea level. Then the door was locked and the suite was sealed.

Arthur had also asked the Head Steward the obvious question — where were the police — and had gotten the answer he'd already worked out for himself. A chartered express makes no scheduled stops. The nearest authority with real jurisdiction was waiting at the end of the line, and Vance's own office in San Francisco, reached by radio relay — lawyers first, family apparently never — had asked that the matter be handled "with discretion" until arrival. Dispatch said hold course. So the law would meet us at the end of the line, and until then a dead man's suite was sealed with hotel locks and good intentions.

For a moment we sat there with our tea and the swaying of the train and the sound of wheels on track, which at this hour had a slower, heavier rhythm, as though the train was thinking about each turn before committing to it.

"It wasn't altitude sickness," Arthur said, setting his cup down. He said it flat, certain, and without any apparent interest in whether you agreed — which is how Arthur says most things. "Cyanotic fingernails. No defensive posture. The pen placed, not dropped. The pill organizer open and empty when his nurse never got through the door. That man didn't die of thin air."

"We agree on that," Bernie said. He was holding his teacup with both hands, which I noticed because Bernie usually holds things with one hand and gestures with the other. "But how he died is a different question, and I don't think we're going to agree on the answer."

He was right about that, as it turned out.

"The air in the room was wrong," Bernie said, and set his cup down on the table with the careful precision of a man laying out evidence. "The

orchid's leaf apertures were closed — a CO<sub>2</sub> response. My tracker recorded a sawtooth oscillation in the atmospheric pressure during the soup course, which is when we all felt our ears pop. And I found maintenance panels behind the velvet curtains in the corridor — manual overrides for the pressurization system, one every few cars. The panel nearest Vance's suite had been handled recently. No dust. The panel two cars back was filmed in mountain grit."

He paused, and I could see him organizing what came next — by weight, as always.

"I believe someone manually reduced the oxygen flow to the Golden Spike suite from the corridor. Without opening the door. At ten thousand feet, with the reduced intake, Vance would have slipped into hypoxia — confusion, drowsiness, loss of consciousness, death. It would look exactly like altitude sickness. It would look exactly like what the Conductor said it was."

"The train was climbing through a mountain pass, Bernie," I said. "Doesn't the pressure change when you go up? We were all popping our ears."

Bernie conceded this with a small tilt of his head — the closest Bernie comes to acknowledging that someone else might have a point. "The oscillation pattern was regular. Too regular — too mechanical — for natural altitude variation, which tends to be gradual. But I can't prove that without baseline data from a normal pass crossing, and I don't have it." He adjusted his spectacles. "The data is consistent with a manual override. It's also consistent with the altitude. I need the full system mapped to know which."

"It's a theory," Arthur said. "It's not evidence." He leaned forward, and his voice dropped into that lower register he finds when he shifts from listening to leading. "What IS evidence is the Digoxin."

I'd been waiting for this. I'd seen Arthur's face in the suite when Elena opened her medication case and found the gap in the row. He'd filed it — quietly, completely, with the patience of long experience. Evidence doesn't expire.

"Something is missing from the nurse's medication case," Arthur said. "She opened it in the suite and there was a gap in the row — a bottle-shaped gap.

Her face changed when she saw it — she went white and closed the case and said nothing. I saw it. Vance was on Digoxin — it's on the pill organizer label. Heart medication. And now there's a hole where a bottle should be." He looked at me. "Hazel, you talked to her. She hated him. She was in the corridor near the suite around five o'clock. She's a nurse who knows exactly what dosage of Digoxin would push a man with a bad heart into cardiac arrest — especially at altitude, when the heart's already under strain. And the pill organizer was empty. Vance's evening dose is gone. Did he take it himself, or did someone give him extra?"

"I don't think Elena wanted him dead," I said.

"Based on what?" Arthur said.

I thought about Elena's hands — the fine tremor in her fingers, the knitting needles gripped too tight at dinner, the bread crumbs all the same size. The way she'd gone white when she opened the medication case and found the gap, and closed it again without a word. My instinct said she was scared, not calculating — carrying something heavy and too tired to hold it properly anymore.

But I've been wrong about people before. Not often, but enough. There was a secretary at Milford Elementary — Carol Fenton — who cried every time the fire alarm went off, real tears, genuine panic, and we all felt sorry for her, and it turned out she'd been pulling the alarm herself because she couldn't face the afternoon staff meeting. The tears were real. The fear was real. And the alarm was still her. I thought I understood Carol — anxious, fragile, needed patience. I was so busy understanding the alarm that I missed what was happening at home. Her husband. The bruises she explained away, and I believed her, because I'd already decided what kind of trouble Carol was in and it wasn't that kind.

"I believe what I saw," I said. "But I've been wrong before, and the Digoxin is missing, and reading someone's face isn't the same as knowing they're innocent."

Arthur nodded. It was the nod he gives when someone has said what he was thinking better than he would have said it.

“There’s something else,” I said, and I reached under my berth and pulled out the tray. Silver-plated, standard issue, the kind the stewards carry through the corridors. I’d intercepted it from a young man clearing the side table near Vance’s door — told him I’d take it back to the galley, which he accepted because I am a woman of a certain age carrying a tin of biscuits and no one questions our motives.

On the tray were a glass and a teacup. The glass had a faint whiskey residue — Vance’s. The teacup had a pale ring of something herbal, barely touched, with a smudge on the handle where someone had gripped it tightly and set it down in a hurry.

“Someone visited him,” Arthur said.

“Someone visited him, didn’t finish their tea, and left before he died. Or while he was dying. Or just after.” I set the tray on the berth. “And the steward was about to tidy it away, and when people are nervous they tidy, and when they tidy, details disappear.”

“The teacup,” Bernie said, leaning forward. “If we could identify the blend —”

“Tomorrow. But there’s more.” I looked at the slippers lined up in my memory, toes aligned, heels flush. “The slippers were wrong. Sterling Vance was a man who sent back sparkling water because it wasn’t bubbly enough. He shouted at waiters. That is not a man who tucks his silk slippers neatly under his chair before unexpectedly dying at his desk. Someone tidied part of that room. And they did it from habit — the way you straighten a cushion on your way out, without thinking about whether it made sense.”

Arthur was quiet for a moment. “I missed that.”

“You were looking at the body, dear. I was looking at the room.”

“There’s a third thing,” Bernie said, and his voice had changed — slower, more careful, the voice he uses when he’s about to say something he knows will land hard. “Julian. The chef. He was in the suite at five-thirty with a tasting plate. He told Hazel about it — seared duck liver, fig reduction. He claims Vance barely looked at it. But Julian’s the only person we know was inside that room with food, and the tasting plate has been washed. Standard

galley procedure — or the most natural way in the world to make evidence disappear.”

I felt something shift in my stomach. I liked Julian. His hands were good and his pride was real.

“He’s also nervous about something,” Bernie continued. “Clock-watching, scrubbing trays that are already clean, visiting the cargo hold with urgency. A man with clean hands and a dirty conscience, or a man with clean hands and a different problem entirely. But the tray is washed, and the food is unaccounted for.”

“That could be professional habit,” I said.

“It could be. But a chef who was in the suite with food, who’s watching the clock, who scrubs things that don’t need scrubbing — if the food was tampered with, the timeline fits. Ingestion at five-thirty, symptoms developing through the evening, cardiac event before dinner.” Bernie looked at his tea. “I’m not saying he did it. I’m saying the food is on the table, if you’ll forgive the expression.”

No one forgave the expression, but no one argued with the logic either.

The rain was tapping against the window in irregular bursts. The cabin felt smaller than it had an hour ago, though nothing had moved except the conversation. We had three ways a man could have died in a locked room — bad air, bad medicine, bad food — and each one pointed at a different person, and none of us could prove or disprove any of them without equipment we didn’t have on a train in the mountains.

The train leaned into a long curve and the lamp swung gently and our tea tilted in the cups.

We sat with it — three theories, no agreement, and a dead man in a locked room who might have been suffocated, poisoned, or fed something he shouldn’t have eaten, and we couldn’t tell which because we were a midwife, a Marshal, and an actuary, not a pathologist, and the nearest laboratory was several hundred miles away through a mountain pass in the rain.

“So what do we do?” I said, though I already knew.

“I’ll map the full ventilation system,” Bernie said. “Every panel, every override, the complete circuit. If the air was tampered with, the system will show it. If it wasn’t, that’s one theory I can rule out.”

“I’ll talk to Miller,” Arthur said. “He was Vance’s bodyguard — closest person to him on this train. If anyone knows who had access to that corridor and what Vance was afraid of, it’s him.” He paused. “And I want to know more about the evening dose. Whether Vance ever took his own pills. Whether Elena could have gotten back to that door without Miller seeing.”

“I’ll talk to Elena,” I said. “About the Digoxin. I saw her face when she opened that case and found the gap. She said ‘He shouldn’t have’ and stopped herself. She knows something about those pills that she’s not sharing.” I set my cup down. “And I’ll have breakfast with Julian. A woman asking a chef about his cooking. Nothing more alarming than that.”

Arthur stood, his knees protesting as they always did, and paused at the door. “We don’t agree on what happened in that room,” he said. “That’s fine. We don’t need to agree. We need to find out.”

Bernie followed him out, still murmuring about pressure differentials. I washed the cups in the tiny sink and put the biscuit tin back on the shelf and turned off the overhead light so only the brass reading lamp was left, its gooseneck bent toward the nightstand where Frank’s timetable sat with its blue-ballpoint notes and his terrible handwriting and the instruction, underlined twice, to sit on the left side for the Rockies.

The tray was still on my berth. The teacup was still there, barely touched, its pale ring going nowhere. I moved it to the fold-down table and lay down in the dark and thought about three ways to kill a man and the fact that we couldn’t rule out any of them, which was either a problem or exactly the kind of problem that three retired people with nothing but time and biscuits were built to solve.

I wasn’t sure which. But I was going to find out over breakfast.

## Chapter 6: The Sleeping Train

The Pullman corridor at midnight was a different country from the one they'd walked through at dinner. The overhead lights had been dimmed to a low amber, and the mahogany panels that looked warm and inviting by day now seemed to absorb the light rather than reflect it. The velvet curtains along the windows hung still and heavy, and beyond them the mountain dark pressed against the glass like something trying to get in.

The train was quieter, but not silent. The ventilation system hissed steadily through the ductwork overhead—a sound that lived below the threshold of daytime attention but became the loudest thing in the corridor once the conversations and footsteps stopped. The couplings between cars clanked in rhythm with the grade, and the wood paneling creaked and settled as the temperature dropped outside. It sounded, Bernie thought, like a building breathing.

He had his GPS tracker in one hand and his phone in the other, the barometer app open and logging. Every twenty feet he stopped, held his hand near the ventilation grate, and noted the reading. Arthur walked a few paces ahead, not watching Bernie's instruments but watching everything else—the doors, the spacing between them, the sightlines down the corridor's length. He noted without commenting that the Conductor's cabin was the second door from Vance's suite. Fifteen feet, perhaps. Miller's suite was a few doors down the same corridor — close enough to keep Vance's door in sight the length of the carpet, far enough that Vance could shut himself in each afternoon and call it privacy. The door at the head of the corridor, where the Pullman met the working cars forward, was a heavy, brass-fitted barrier that looked no different from any other. The connecting door inside Vance's suite was visible through the gap where the corridor met that car — a solid piece of mahogany, deadbolted from the inside. It was a simple, old-fashioned way to keep the world out, and it had worked perfectly.

"There's a pressure differential here," Bernie said, pausing outside Vance's sealed door. He held his tracker up, frowned at it, moved six feet to the left, checked again. "Half a millibar lower than the reading at the far end of the car. Could be residual from the altitude climb. Could be something else."

Arthur looked at the ventilation grate above Vance's door. It looked the same as every other grate. "Can you tell if it was altered?"

"Not from the corridor side. But —" Bernie reached past the velvet curtain that dressed the wall between Vance's door and the next suite. His fingers found the recessed panel — brass-fitted, the same style as every maintenance access on the train. He pulled it open. Inside were two manual dials, a pressure gauge, and a row of labeled switches in railroad shorthand that meant nothing to either of them. "There's one of these every few cars," Bernie said, already photographing it with his phone. "Fire safety overrides. Manual control of the pressurization and airflow for each section."

Arthur leaned in, his eyes narrowing as he looked at the brass latch. "It's clean," he noted. "The panel two cars back was filmed in a layer of fine mountain dust, Bernie. This one's been handled recently. Polished, almost."

"Or recently maintained," Bernie said, though his voice didn't sound like he believed it. He photographed the dial positions without knowing what they meant. Without baseline readings from a normal crossing, the numbers were just numbers — they could indicate tampering or routine calibration or nothing at all. He needed comparison data, and he didn't have it yet.

He photographed the identical panel two cars down for comparison. That one was dusty and stiff. He closed both panels and stood in the corridor for a moment, his phone in his hand, thinking about the gap between what the data suggested and what the data proved, which was the gap he'd spent his entire career living inside.

They continued on through the sleeping train—past the darkened dining car, where a single light burned above the service pass and the white tablecloths glowed faintly like snow, and back through the narrow passage to the observation car.

They expected the observation car to be empty.

Skye was curled into a corner seat with her laptop open on the fold-down tray and a glass of red wine beside her that she hadn't touched. The screen cast a pale blue wash across her face, and in it Arthur could see that her eyes were red and slightly swollen—not the redness of fatigue but the particular



rawness that comes from crying and stopping and crying again. She was scrubbing through video footage, dragging the playback bar in small increments, pausing on frames—a doorway, a figure in a corridor, a timestamp in the corner of the screen.

She heard them and closed the laptop. It was fast—reflexive, not casual—the gesture of someone who’d been caught rather than interrupted. The blue wash disappeared and her face went into shadow.

“Burning the midnight oil?” Arthur said, keeping his voice mild.

“The algorithm never sleeps,” Skye said, and smiled. It was a good smile—practiced, bright, the kind of smile that probably worked very well on camera. “Just trimming content. You know how it is. Golden hour footage doesn’t edit itself.”

“At midnight,” Arthur said.

“Creativity has no schedule.” She reached for the wine glass, seemed to remember she didn’t want it, and pulled her hand back.

“We’ll leave you to it,” Arthur said, and turned. Bernie was already in the corridor, but Arthur had seen, in the half-second before the laptop closed, the frozen frame on the screen — the Pullman corridor outside Vance’s suite, shot from an angle that could only have been the archway near the dining car, with a timestamp that read 18:38. She’d been filming that corridor at 6:38 PM. Why? Surveillance of the suite door — watching who visited Vance? Documentation for something she was working on? Or something else that Arthur couldn’t read from a single frozen frame and a woman who closed her laptop too fast?

He didn’t mention it. Bernie, two steps ahead, was making a note on his phone. He didn’t mention what he’d seen either.

They walked back through the dining car and the Pullman corridor in a silence that had nothing uncomfortable in it. Arthur and Bernie had known each other since a shared dorm room at Michigan State, fifty-some years ago, and they had long since passed the stage where silence between them required explanation or apology. Arthur was turning over the timestamp and the red eyes and the wine she hadn’t touched. Bernie was cataloguing

the dust differential on the maintenance panels and the pressure reading he couldn't yet explain. Neither needed the other to process aloud. The processing would happen, and they'd know when it was done.

They parted at their cabin doors. Arthur paused with his hand on the latch and looked down the corridor one more time—the dim amber light, the velvet curtains, the sealed door of the Golden Spike suite at the far end.

The ventilation hissed. The train swayed into a curve. The corridor was empty, and the air moved through the ducts the way it was supposed to, and in the morning Bernie would try to determine whether it had always done so, or whether someone had changed its mind for it.

## Chapter 7: The Nurse's Knot

The dining car in the morning was not the dining car of the night before. The candles had been replaced by mountain light coming in at a low angle through the observation windows, and the white linen that had looked so elegant by candlelight now just looked like white linen. People were eating quietly. The chair where Sterling Vance would have sat was empty and had been set anyway, which I thought was either very professional or very unsettling, and possibly both.

Arthur and Bernie were at our usual table. Arthur was buttering his toast with the concentration of a man defusing a bomb, and Bernie was doing something to his eggs that involved a digital thermometer and his specialized tracker. He was currently checking the altitude offset against the cabin pressure again—the “sawtooth oscillation” from last night had clearly left him unsettled. I have traveled with these two men for six years and I still don’t know which one of them is more exhausting at breakfast. Arthur won’t speak until he’s finished chewing, which takes geological ages, and Bernie won’t stop speaking at all, mostly about things like the mineral content of the water or the statistical relationship between altitude and egg-boiling times. I love them both. I caught Arthur’s eye as I crossed the car with my teacup, and he gave me the smallest nod—the “Marshal nod,” which meant he was ready to back me up if I needed to claim jurisdiction over the marmalade.

Elena was at her small table near the galley, alone. Her knitting was out on the table in front of her, but her hands were in her lap and the needles weren’t moving. She had a cup of tea that looked cold and a plate of toast she hadn’t touched. She looked like a woman who had been sitting there for some time, trying to decide whether to eat or leave, and had failed at both.

I sat down across from her without asking, the way you do at a church social when someone is sitting alone and clearly needs company whether they know it or not. Frank used to say I collected strays — “You’d sit down with an axe murderer if she looked lonely enough, Hazel” — which was unfair, because I have always been quite selective about my axe murderers. I set my teacup on the table and said, “That’s a beautiful pattern. Is it interlocking cable?”

I found myself wondering if she was the one who liked herbal tea. I'd spent half the night staring at that delicate porcelain cup from the suite, the one with the pale ring and the tight-grip smudge on the handle. Elena didn't look like she gripped things tightly by choice. She looked like she was holding on because she'd forgotten how to let go.

"It's—yes. A modified Aran. Three-strand cable with a honeycomb fill."

"The tension looks very even," I said, which was true, although "even" was generous. The stitches were tight—pulled tight, the way you knit when your hands need something precise to do because the rest of you is falling to pieces. I've seen that kind of knitting before, on the maternity ward, in the hands of women waiting for news. The wool doesn't know what you're feeling, but the gauge does.

"I learned from my grandmother," Elena said, and her hands came up from her lap and found the needles, and the clicking started—quiet, rhythmic, the sound of someone returning to the one thing they know how to do when everything else has gone wrong. "She said the cables were prayers. Each twist is a different one."

"What are you praying for?" I asked, and I meant it lightly, but Elena's hands stopped.

"I can't find his Digoxin," she said.

I didn't say anything. I picked up my tea and took a sip and waited, because people who have been holding something all night will tell you the rest if you just give them a quiet place to put it down.

"The bottle was in my medication case yesterday morning. I checked it during the afternoon rounds — it was there. After — after everything, I went to inventory his medications, because that's what you do, that's procedure, and it was gone." Her voice was steady but her fingers had started a fine tremor that she tried to hide by gripping the needles tighter. "If he had a cardiac event and his heart medication was missing and I'm the nurse, they won't —" She stopped. "They'll look at me first. I know they will."

"Do you have any idea where it went?" I asked, keeping my voice in the register you use for misplaced umbrellas, not missing cardiac medications.

She didn't look at me. "I think I left it at the hotel. In Chicago. We were packing in a rush and I must have —" She stopped again, and the excuse sat between us like something neither of us believed. A nurse who loses a bottle of Digoxin and shrugs it off as a packing error. She seemed like a woman who was telling the first story that came to hand because the real one was worse.

"That must be frightening," I said.

"I hated him," she said, and the word came out fast and hard, the release of a jaw clenched all night and immediately followed by silence. Then, more quietly: "He called me 'the girl.' Three years I worked for him and he never learned my last name. He rang the bell at three in the morning because his pillow was wrong. He told me once that nurses were just maids who'd read a textbook." She looked at the cable pattern growing under her needles. "I didn't want him dead. I wanted him to stop needing me. I wanted him to fire me so I could go home and sleep and collect my severance and never hear that bell again."

I understood that kind of hate. It's the specific, domestic variety — it lives in the hallway between devotion and exhaustion and never quite gets to the door. Frank, in his last year, when the hip was really bad and the pain made him mean in a way he'd never been before—he'd ring a bell too, a little brass one I'd bought him as a joke that stopped being funny by the second week because the clapper had a tinny, insistent sound that seemed to vibrate right in my molars. I'd bring him his tea and his pills and adjust his pillow and he'd say "not like that" and I'd adjust it again and he'd say "it was better before" and I'd want to put the pillow over his face, which I never did, obviously, and which I also thought about with more specificity than I'm comfortable admitting. I loved him entirely, even when I wanted to throw that bell into the Chicago River.

"More toast?" I said, because the moment needed something ordinary in it.

"No, thank you."

I bent down to pick up a ball of wool that had rolled off the table—the dove-gray one, the fill yarn for the honeycomb—and as I reached for it my hand brushed Elena's knitting bag on the floor. It was heavier than a bag of

wool and needles should be. There was something at the bottom—angular, metallic, wrapped loosely in what felt like a spare scarf. I closed my hand around the wool, straightened up, and set it on the table next to her pattern.

“I’m always dropping things,” I said. “On the cruise last year I lost an entire set of double-points under a sun lounger and didn’t find them until Bermuda.”

Elena almost smiled. Almost.

I finished my tea and stood. “Thank you for showing me the cable technique, dear. I’ve been meaning to try something more ambitious than dishcloths.”

Chef Julian was making his morning round as I crossed back — white jacket, copper buttons, the smile of personal responsibility for your breakfast, and he’d like you to know it. He paused at the trio’s table and said something to Arthur about the eggs, and Arthur nodded politely — he reserves that expression for food, weather, and anything that isn’t a crime. Julian moved on to the next table with a glance at the kitchen clock that was brief enough to be habit and frequent enough to be something else. I filed that and sat down between Arthur and Bernie. Arthur lowered his newspaper a fraction. Bernie looked up from his eggs.

“The Digoxin is missing,” I said, quietly. “She noticed it gone after the death. She’s terrified they’ll blame her. She claims she left the bottle at the hotel in Chicago.”

Arthur’s jaw tightened. “She claims.”

“She doesn’t believe it herself. You can hear a story that a person is telling for the first time and a story that a person assembled in the night, and that one was assembled.”

“The medication,” Arthur said. “His heart medication. Missing. And the nurse can’t account for it.”

Bernie was already thinking — I could see the calculations starting behind his spectacles. Dosage, half-life, interaction effects, the probability matrices spinning. “If the Digoxin was administered deliberately — an overdose at altitude, with his existing cardiac condition —”

“I know,” I said. “She had the means. She had the access. She had three years of reasons.” I looked at my tea. “My instinct says she’s scared, not guilty. But instinct doesn’t explain where the Digoxin went, and ‘I left it at the hotel’ is the kind of answer that makes the question louder, not quieter.”

I didn’t mention the knitting bag. I wasn’t sure what it meant yet, and I don’t share things I haven’t thought about. There’s no point risking starting a fire with a match you’re not sure is lit.

I drank my tea and watched the mountain light move across the white linen and thought about the fact that Elena had said “I didn’t want him dead” without anyone asking her whether she did, and that she’d offered a cover story for the missing Digoxin that she didn’t seem to believe, and that the tremor in her hands could be fear or guilt or both, and that I liked her, which is not the same thing as knowing her — a distinction you learn the hard way if you’ve been alive long enough.

## Chapter 8: The Bridge

Chef Julian was at the trio's table again, this time with a small plate of something he called a "palate wake-up" — thin slices of blood orange arranged in a fan beside a curl of mascarpone and a single mint leaf that looked like it had been placed with surgical forceps. He set it between them with the quiet pride of a man presenting evidence of his own genius.

"For the table," he said. "Compliments of the galley. A rough night deserves a gentle morning."

"That's very kind," Hazel said, and meant it.

Julian lingered — not hovering, but present, reading the table for cues with the same quiet attention Arthur gave a room. He asked Bernie about the eggs ("the yolk was precisely calibrated," Bernie said, which Julian took as a compliment) and mentioned the lunch menu — a roast that would take advantage of the slow afternoon.

"Beautiful stretch of country coming up this afternoon," Julian said, leaning one hand on the back of an empty chair. "We'll pass through the Alder Creek gorge if the weather holds. Spectacular views — the canyon walls, you can see the old rail bridge from below. Hard country for trains, but here we are." He smiled. "My uncle used to work this line, actually. Eighteen years — signals, track maintenance, the unglamorous end of keeping things moving. Before they sold everything off."

He moved on to the next table, already adjusting his tone and his smile for a different audience. Arthur watched him go and felt something cold settle in the space behind his ribs. Alder Creek. The gorge. The rail bridge.

Alder Creek.

He finished his toast. He took a sip of coffee that had gone cold without his noticing. Hazel was looking at him across the table with the quiet attention she gave to things she wasn't going to ask about yet, and Bernie was photographing his blood orange from an angle that suggested he was documenting the plate's geometry rather than its appearance.

"Excuse me," Arthur said, and stood, and took his coffee cup with him because he needed something to hold.



The observation car was empty at this hour — most passengers were still in the dining car or hadn't surfaced yet. Arthur sat in the same corner seat where they'd found Skye the night before and looked out at the mountains. The clouds were building to the west, gray and low, and the peaks that had been sharp against blue sky yesterday were disappearing into them one by one, like stage lights dimming.

He hadn't thought about Alder Creek in years. That wasn't true. He thought about it the way you think about something you've put in a drawer and closed — you know it's there, and you don't open the drawer, and it doesn't go away.

August 1994. Three spans of the Alder Creek bridge gave way on an ordinary Tuesday — under ordinary traffic, and under the finishing crew that had been working the deck of a bridge that had only opened that spring. Two cars and a delivery truck went into the canyon, and the crew's staging went with them. Five dead — three ironworkers and two motorists — and eleven injured. Sarah Oakes was twenty-two. She was driving home from her first week at a teaching job in Glenwood Springs, and she was Jim Oakes's daughter, and Jim Oakes was a U.S. Marshal who worked out of the Denver field office and had once bought Arthur a beer after a long day of testimony and said, "The job doesn't get easier, but you get more stubborn, and that's almost the same thing."

The investigation found substandard steel in the bridge's load-bearing trusses. The steel had been supplied by a company called Pinnacle Materials, out of Pittsburgh. Pinnacle had failed two independent quality audits in the eighteen months before the Alder Creek contract. Both audits were overruled at the corporate level — someone signed off on the cheaper supplier because the margin on the bridge contract was thin and the steel was forty percent less expensive. Pinnacle Materials was a wholly owned subsidiary of Vance Capital Partners.

Arthur had worked the edges of the investigation — not lead, not assigned, but present. His colleague's daughter was dead. That had been reason enough. He'd watched the legal pressure mount. Vance's lawyers filed motions like other people filed taxes — steadily, mechanically, in volumes that made the case file grow while the investigation shrank. Settlements were

reached. NDAs were signed. The engineering firm took the public blame. Pinnacle Materials was quietly dissolved. Vance Capital Partners continued to grow.

Jim Oakes retired two years later. He and Arthur never talked about it directly. There wasn't anything to say that the silence didn't already hold.

Sterling Vance. Vance Capital Partners. Pinnacle Materials. Alder Creek. The man in the Golden Spike suite had built his fortune on margins — the margin between safe steel and cheap steel, between what the audit said and what the accountant preferred, between what was legal and what you could get away with. And a bridge fell, and Sarah Oakes went into the canyon, and the money made it disappear.

Five dead. Eleven injured. Families broken, pensions gutted, a community left holding the bill for a corporation that dissolved itself before the lawsuits could land. Arthur tried to count the people who might still carry the weight of that day — the spouses, the children, the coworkers who walked away the same week and spent thirty years not understanding why it was someone else in the canyon and not them. The number wasn't small. And some of those people, or their children, or their nephews who grew up hearing the story at Thanksgiving, could be anywhere. They could be on this train.

And now Vance was dead in a gilded room at ten thousand feet, and the train was about to pass through the same gorge where his cheap steel had killed five people, and a chef whose uncle had worked this very line had been alone in the dead man's suite with food.

Through the observation windows, the clouds had closed over the last visible peak. The light went flat and gray, and the mountains that had seemed majestic yesterday now looked like walls.

The train lurched — a hard, sudden deceleration that sent Arthur's coffee sliding across the side table. For a second, his ears gave that same sharp, uncomfortable pop he'd felt in the dining car the night before, a phantom ripple in the air pressure that made him swallow hard. Not dangerous. A speed adjustment for the grade, or a signal, or the weather making the track uncertain. But the lurch stripped the illusion for a moment, and what was

left was a train on a rail in the mountains, moving slowly through country that didn't care whether you arrived.

The Conductor's voice came through the intercom, calm and professional: "Ladies and gentlemen, we'll be reducing speed through the pass due to weather conditions. No cause for concern. Your comfort and safety remain our highest priority."

Arthur set his coffee cup upright and wiped the spill with a napkin from the armrest caddy. He sat for another minute, watching the gray mountains, and then he stood and walked back to the dining car.

Hazel looked up when he sat down. Bernie was still with his blood orange. "I need to tell you both something," Arthur said, his voice low enough that the next table couldn't hear. "Not here. Tonight."

Hazel nodded. She didn't ask what.

Across the car, Julian was at the service pass, laughing with a steward about something, plating a garnish with the easy precision of hands that knew their work as well as Arthur's knew a sidearm. Arthur looked at him, and then looked away, and finished his cold coffee.

The Conductor walked through the dining car on his way to the front of the train, checking window latches as he went. His uniform was pressed. His cap was straight. He nodded to Arthur as he passed. Arthur nodded back.

Outside, the rain came back against the observation windows, and the mountains disappeared entirely.

## Chapter 9: The Midnight Tea

The kettle was the best thing I'd done on this trip. I'd acquired it on the first afternoon through a conversation with the Head Steward about his grandmother's arthritis — a genuine conversation, not a scheme, though the kettle did appear in my cabin within the hour and I wasn't about to send it back. It was a small chrome thing, dented on one side, probably borrowed from the staff galley, and it took four minutes to boil, which is longer than it should but shorter than complaining about it would take.

I set out three cups on the fold-down table and realized I only had two saucers. Frank would have had something to say about that. Frank had opinions about tea service the way other men had opinions about sport — passionately, loudly, and with a complete disregard for whether anyone else was listening. He once sent back a cup at a hotel in Milwaukee because the saucer had a chip in it, and then spent twenty minutes explaining to the waitress that the saucer was structurally essential to the experience, which the waitress handled with a grace I still admire. I put Bernie's cup directly on the table and decided he'd survive.

Arthur knocked at ten past eleven — two quiet raps — Arthur knocks on everything like a man serving a warrant but trying not to wake the neighbours. Bernie was behind him, already talking.

"The humidity in this corridor is eleven percent higher than the observation car, which is consistent with the proximity to the —"

"Get in, Bernie," I said, and held the door.

The cabin was not built for three adults. It was barely built for one adult and a suitcase, and with Arthur's knees and Bernie's elbows it became an exercise in spatial negotiation that would have been funny if we hadn't all been so tired. Arthur took the edge of the berth because his knees wouldn't fold into any other position, and he sat with his hands on his thighs like a man waiting in a doctor's office. Bernie took the single chair, which put him roughly six inches from the fold-down table and directly under the brass reading lamp, which he immediately adjusted. I stood by the kettle because there was nowhere else to stand and because the kettle was my jurisdiction.

“Biscuit,” I said, putting the tin between them. Lemon zest. I’d made them before the trip — three dozen, packed in wax paper, a habit Frank would have called excessive and then eaten half the tin by the second day.

Arthur took one and held it without eating. Bernie took two, examined one, and ate the other.

“Last night we had three theories,” Arthur said. He didn’t ease into it. Arthur never eases into anything — he arrives, fully dressed, at the point. “Today I have what’s underneath them. It doesn’t change how he died. It changes why.”

Bernie set his cup down. Nobody picked up a biscuit.

“I’ll start with what I know,” Arthur said, “and then I’ll tell you what worries me.” He ate the biscuit in two bites — efficiently, as though food were an administrative task. “The chef mentioned Alder Creek this morning — the gorge, the scenery. His uncle worked this rail line for eighteen years before Vance Capital gutted it. But Alder Creek is also where a bridge collapsed in ninety-four.”

He told us about the bridge. August 1994. Three spans giving way. Five dead, eleven injured. Sarah Oakes, twenty-two, driving home from her first week teaching. Jim Oakes, her father, a U.S. Marshal in Denver who bought Arthur a beer once and said the job doesn’t get easier but you get more stubborn. The substandard steel from Pinnacle Materials. Pinnacle owned by Vance Capital Partners. Vance’s lawyers burying it in paper until the case file grew and the investigation shrank. Settlements, NDAs, the engineering firm taking the blame, Pinnacle dissolving like sugar in water. Vance Capital continuing to grow.

The rain had strengthened, running against the window in long uneven streaks. I didn’t say anything. There are times when the best thing you can do for someone is hold the silence open so they can put something into it, and this was one of those times.

When Arthur said “Pinnacle Materials,” Bernie’s cup stopped halfway to his mouth. He set it down on the table — carefully, precisely — and his hand went to his spectacles and adjusted them, though they didn’t need

adjusting. He didn't say a word. I noticed that, and I noticed his jaw tightening, and I filed both observations in the place where I keep things I'm not ready to talk about yet.

"So the dead man had enemies," I said. "Thirty years' worth."

"At least," Arthur said. "Five dead, eleven injured, families gutted. Damage that doesn't heal — it just gets quieter. Some of those people, or their children, could be on this train and we wouldn't know it." He looked at me. "Julian's uncle is one of them. Different injury — Vance gutted the rail line, not the bridge — but the same word at the top of the page. Vance. So the food theory we laid out last night now has a motive sitting on top of it."

He turned to me. "And then there's Elena. Hazel — you talked to her today."

I had, at breakfast — she was alone at the table by the galley. "She told me she left it at a hotel in Chicago," I said. "Neither of us believed it. She didn't even try very hard."

"So the missing bottle is still missing."

"Still missing. And she said it like she was repeating a sentence somebody else had written for her." I picked up my tea. "My instinct still says she's scared, not guilty. But she's lying about where the medicine went, and I can't square the two yet."

"A missing bottle of heart medication is a fact," Arthur said. "Facts don't go away because someone cried while telling you about it."

"I know they don't."

"My turn," Bernie said, and his voice found the register it always finds when he's talking about things he can measure — steadier, more certain, the anxiety dropping away into data. "Last night I had the clean panel. Today I have the dial."

He pulled his phone out and set it on the table beside his cup. "Secondary airflow dial on the panel nearest the suite is sitting a quarter-turn past where the identical dial on the other panels rests. Someone moved it. Recently — the brass around the spindle is the only clean brass on that panel."

“Could a technician have moved it?” Arthur said.

“A technician could,” Bernie said. “Or the train’s system could have done it compensating for the pass. Or someone in that corridor at the right minute could have moved it, and at ten thousand feet the reduced intake would have looked exactly like altitude sickness.” He adjusted his spectacles. “I still need the full circuit before I can choose between those. But a quarter-turn on a dial that shouldn’t have been turned isn’t nothing.”

We sat with it. The three rooms from last night still open — bad air, bad medicine, bad food — and now a bridge underneath all three of them, and a family in every direction.

“There’s something that doesn’t fit any of the three,” I said, and I pulled out the tray from under the berth. The glass and the teacup were still there — whiskey residue in the glass, the pale herbal ring in the teacup, the tight-grip smudge on its handle. “The chamomile. Julian brought food to the suite, not tea — and he’s an Earl Grey man through and through. Elena was turned away from the door. The chamomile came from someone else — a visit between five-thirty and dinner, and a quick exit.”

“Who on this train drinks chamomile?” Bernie asked.

No one answered, because no one knew.

“And then there’s Skye,” Arthur said.

Arthur told us what he and Bernie had seen — the observation car at midnight, Skye curled in a corner seat with her laptop open and a glass of wine she hadn’t touched. She’d closed the screen the instant she heard them, but not before Arthur caught the frozen frame: the Pullman corridor outside Vance’s suite, shot from the archway near the dining car, with a timestamp reading 18:38.

“She was filming that corridor at six-thirty-eight,” Arthur said. “Three minutes before the Conductor’s pre-dinner rounds came through. We still don’t know why.”

“If she knew about the ventilation system,” Bernie said, “she could have been checking the corridor was clear before accessing the panel herself.”

“Or she was watching the suite door,” I said. “Documenting who visited Vance. Every time a staff door opens, her phone dips and her eyes go sharp. She’s looking for something that isn’t content.”

“Or she’s a journalist,” Arthur said, “and she was filming everything, and the corridor was part of her coverage, and the timestamp is coincidence.”

“You don’t believe that,” I said.

“I don’t know what I believe about her yet. That’s why we watch and don’t approach.”

The rain had picked up. It was hitting the window in sheets now, and the train swayed through a curve that made the cups slide on the table. I caught mine. Arthur caught Bernie’s. Bernie was still thinking.

“We don’t agree,” Arthur said, and there was no frustration in it — just the flat recognition of forty years in rooms where disagreement was the beginning of the work, not the end of it. “Bernie thinks it’s the air. I think it’s the medication. Hazel sees the domestic picture and isn’t ready to commit.”

“I see three people who were in that corridor,” I said, “and a cup of chamomile that doesn’t belong to any of them. I’m not ready to commit because we don’t have enough to rule anything out.”

“Then we get more,” Arthur said. “Bernie — close the circuit. If the dial is the only one that moved, we know how. If three more moved like it, the mountain did it.”

“Already on it,” Bernie said. “I’ll watch the next altitude change. If the anomaly repeats naturally, the mountain wins. If it only repeats near that panel, it doesn’t.”

“I’ll have Miller tomorrow,” Arthur said. “With different questions than I would have asked last night. I want to know what Vance was afraid of, and whether the bridge ever came up between them. You don’t double-lock your door every afternoon at four o’clock for nothing.”

“I’ll see Julian’s galley in the morning,” I said. “I was going to talk about his family. Now I’m going to talk about his family and the chamomile. Whoever



brought that cup isn't Julian and isn't Elena. Which means it's somebody else's habit, and somebody else's habit is something I can find."

"And Elena?" Arthur said.

"Elena and I aren't finished. She gave me a story today she didn't expect me to believe. Tomorrow I'd like to give her a chance to tell me a different one."

"And Skye?" Bernie said.

"Skye is everyone's question," Arthur said. "We watch. We don't approach. Not yet."

They left a few minutes later, Arthur turning sideways to get through the door without cracking his knees on the frame, Bernie still murmuring about pressure differentials and baseline comparisons. I rinsed the cups and set them on the towel to dry, and turned off the overhead light, and the cabin shrank to the small brass circle of the reading lamp.

I couldn't see the Rockies tonight. The rain had taken them. But they were out there, and so was whatever had happened in that sealed room, and we had three theories and no agreement and a cup of chamomile that didn't belong to anyone we'd talked to yet, and in the morning I would pour tea for a chef and talk about bridges and food and family as though it were the most natural thing in the world, and I would listen for the thing he wasn't saying, because that's always where the answer lives — not in what people tell you, but in the space around it.

## Chapter 10: The Hired Shadow

Arthur found Miller in the observation car at six-fifteen, which was early enough that the mountains were still just shapes against a sky that hadn't decided what color it wanted to be. The rain had stopped sometime in the night, but the clouds sat low and heavy on the peaks, and the glass walls of the car held the gray light like a jar holding water — full but still.

Miller was in a corner seat, facing the windows, a paper cup of black coffee balanced on the armrest. He hadn't shaved. His dark suit was the same one from the night before, the jacket unbuttoned, the shirt collar loosened, and he sat with the particular stillness of a man who had been sitting for a long time because the alternative was pacing, and pacing didn't work.

"Mind if I sit?" Arthur said.

Miller looked at him. The assessment was fast and professional — not a threat evaluation, exactly, but something close to it. The weary alertness Arthur had noticed the night before was still there, but the edges had frayed.

"Free country," Miller said. Then, after a beat: "You were the one who told me to hold the corridor."

"I was."

"Appreciated that. Most civilians would have been in the way." Miller took a sip of his coffee. "You're law enforcement. Or you were."

"U.S. Marshals. Retired."

Miller nodded once, slowly, the way cops nod when something they already suspected is confirmed. He didn't ask for identification. He didn't need to. Arthur had worked with enough retired officers to know the bearing never fully left — the posture, the economy of movement, the habit of sitting where you could see the door.

"How long were you with Vance?" Arthur asked.

"Fourteen months. Before me there was a guy named Harris who lasted six. Before him, Reynolds — lasted less." Miller turned the coffee cup in his hands. "Vance went through security the way some people go through shoes. Wore you down and then blamed you for being worn."

“Difficult client.”

“Difficult man.” Miller looked out at the mountains. A thread of mist was moving through a valley below them, slow and directionless. “He wanted protection on his terms, on his schedule, visible only when he decided it should be visible. Four o’clock every day, I was dismissed. Every day. ‘Go rest, Miller. I’ll be in my suite. The door will be locked.’ Both locks. His own key plus the deadbolt. I couldn’t have gotten in if I’d wanted to.”

“Every day,” Arthur said.

“Every day. He had evening routines — files, papers, things he kept in a leather case on his desk. He’d pour his whiskey, spread his documents out, and that was his private time. He didn’t want anyone seeing those papers. The man before me, Caruso, pushed back once — told Vance that a four-hour gap was too long, that he couldn’t guarantee security. Vance fired him before the argument was over. Called the agency from the suite phone and had a replacement lined up before Caruso reached the elevator.” Miller turned the coffee cup in his hands. “I learned the lesson. Whatever he does in that suite between four and dinner is something he doesn’t want witnessed, and asking about it is the fastest way to join Caruso.”

“And the night he died?”

“Same routine. Four o’clock, out. He was in one of his moods — twitchy, short-tempered, worse than usual. He’d been looking at the route map that morning, tracing the line through the mountains with his finger, and something about it put him off. He said —” Miller stopped. Frowned at his coffee. “He said something about a bridge. Didn’t explain. Just muttered it while he was looking at the map, and then he was irritable the rest of the day. More irritable.”

Arthur kept his face neutral. “A bridge.”

“I didn’t ask. You learn not to ask. Half the time he’d tell you anyway, and the other half he’d take your head off for being nosy.” Miller shifted in his seat. “But he was rattled. I could see that much. He’d been on edge since we boarded — checking the windows, asking about the passenger manifest, wanting to know who else was on the train. Normal paranoid stuff, for him.

But the bridge thing was different. That was older. Like he was carrying it already and the route just reminded him.”

Through the glass, the mountains were gaining definition as the light strengthened. The mist in the valley had thinned. Arthur’s knees ached from the cold, a low steady pulse that had become background, like a clock he’d stopped hearing.

“Anyone visit the suite between four o’clock and dinner?” he asked.

Miller thought. “The nurse tried. Around five, five-fifteen. He’d already told her twice not to hover, so she turned back before she knocked. I saw her from the corridor — I was stretching my legs, not going far.” He paused. “And then kitchen staff. Maybe five-thirty. Brought a small tray — some kind of tasting plate or tea, I don’t know.”

“Short visit. You go in with him?”

“No. I heard him knock. Heard Vance say something — muffled, couldn’t make out the words. The door closed. Couple of minutes later, the chef came back out. Vance was alive and complaining, which was his normal state.” Miller turned the coffee cup in his hands. “I didn’t see whether Vance ate anything. Didn’t see what was on the tray. I was at the far end of the corridor.”

Arthur filed that. Julian was inside the suite with food, and the only witness to what happened in there was dead.

“The medications,” Arthur said. “Vance had a pill organizer on his desk. Evening compartment was empty when we found him. Did he take his own pills, or did the nurse handle that?”

Miller frowned. “She usually brought them. Evening round, six o’clock or so. But Vance — he’d do it himself sometimes, if she was too slow or if he was in one of his moods. He didn’t like waiting. He’d pop the lid and take them with his whiskey, which she hated because she said the alcohol affected the absorption.” Miller shrugged. “So either he took them himself, or she got in there somehow, or —” He stopped. “I don’t know. I was dismissed at four.”

“The vlogger,” Arthur said. “The young woman with the camera. She come around that corridor?”

Miller almost smiled. “That one was everywhere. Had a camera the size of a dinner plate and no sense of when she wasn’t wanted. Vance told me to keep her away from him at dinner the first night — said she pointed her phone at him and he didn’t like being filmed. I told her to give him space. She did, mostly. But she was always in the corridors, always filming something.” He shook his head. “Didn’t see her near the suite that afternoon, though. Doesn’t mean she wasn’t there.”

He let a silence settle between them — the kind of silence that invites a man to fill it if he wants to, and doesn’t pressure him if he doesn’t. Miller filled it.

“I should have been there,” he said. His voice was flat, but the flatness was effortful. “That’s the thing I keep coming back to. I know the door was locked. I know I couldn’t have gotten in. But I should have been in that corridor, not resting like some kind of —” He stopped himself. Took a breath. “He hired me to keep him safe. And I was two cars away eating a sandwich when he died.”

“The door was locked from inside,” Arthur said. “Both locks. You couldn’t have changed anything.”

“Maybe not. But I’d have been there.” Miller looked at him. “You ever lose someone you were supposed to protect?”

Arthur thought of Jim Oakes buying him a beer in Denver, his hand shaking as he held the glass, and the phone call two years later when Jim said he was retiring because the job had gotten heavier than he could carry. He thought about a twenty-two-year-old woman driving home from her first week of teaching, and a bridge that should have held.

“Not the same way,” he said. “But yes.”

They sat with that for a moment. The observation car was still empty, the other passengers not yet stirring. The coffee in Arthur’s cup had gone cold — he’d brought it from his cabin and hadn’t taken more than a sip.

The door at the far end of the car opened, and Raymond came through, moving with the same unhurried ease Arthur had noticed since they’d boarded. He checked the latch on an emergency panel, straightened a window shade that was already straight, and paused beside them. “Fresh

coffee? I can have someone bring a pot. Extra blanket?” Miller shook his head, but something in his face eased briefly — the involuntary softening that happens when someone asks a kind question at the wrong moment. Raymond nodded and moved on, his shoes catching the gray light with each step.

“Raymond was the one who opened the suite,” Miller said, watching the Conductor’s back as he disappeared through the far door. “When Vance didn’t show for dinner. Used the master key — brass thing on his belt. The head steward called him and he was there in about a minute. You and your friends had come up with him from the dining car. He opened both locks, stepped back. You went in first — told me to hold the corridor.” Miller’s jaw tightened. “Professional about it. More professional than I was.”

“Who else has a master key?” Arthur asked.

“The head steward carries one. Maybe a spare in the office safe — I don’t know. Standard setup on a train like this. The corridor maintenance panels aren’t locked at all — they’re behind the curtains but anyone who knows they’re there could open them.”

Arthur noted that. The master key narrowed things, but the panels didn’t. Anyone who had walked the corridor and pulled back a curtain — staff, a curious passenger, a journalist who’d researched the train — could have accessed the ventilation overrides. The question wasn’t who had train access. The question was who had this access, at this time, with a reason.

Arthur nodded. He finished his cold coffee and set the cup on the armrest.

“I appreciate you talking to me,” he said. “I know this isn’t easy.”

“You’re the first person who’s asked me anything that wasn’t about paperwork,” Miller said. He looked out the window again. The clouds had lifted just enough to show a ridge of dark rock above the tree line, and then closed again. “Altitude sickness. That’s what they’re calling it. You believe that?”

Arthur stood. His knees protested, and he let them. “I think Mr. Vance had enemies,” he said carefully. “And I think a man who double-locks his door every afternoon knows it.”

Miller looked at him for a long time. “Yeah,” he said. “That’s about where I am too.”

Arthur left him there, a thick-shouldered man in a wrinkled suit staring at mountains he wasn’t seeing. The corridor was quiet. The velvet curtains hung motionless on either side of the passageway, and Arthur passed the one nearest Vance’s suite without stopping, though he noted the faint brass edge of the maintenance panel behind it — automatically, without weight, an old habit — always check the exits.

Raymond was ahead of him in the corridor, already moving toward the front of the train. Arthur watched him go — the even stride, the cap set level, a man at ease in his own domain.

Arthur turned toward the dining car. He needed real coffee, and he needed to talk to Hazel, and the first was easier to get than the second would be to process.

## Chapter 11: Breakfast with the Chef

I was running low on lemon zest, which was nobody's fault but my own. I'd packed the biscuit tin full before we left Chicago and hadn't rationed properly, and now I had enough for maybe one more batch if I was careful, which I never am with biscuits. Frank used to say I baked the way some people drank — steadily, without apology, and with a complete unwillingness to acknowledge that the supply was finite. He wasn't wrong about that. He was wrong about most things involving the kitchen, but not that.

The galley was at the far end of the dining car, past the service pass and through a door marked STAFF ONLY in brass letters that had been polished so often they'd gone smooth at the edges. I knocked, because I was raised properly, and a young man in a white jacket opened it and looked at me with the expression people use when a passenger has wandered somewhere they shouldn't be.

"I was hoping to speak with Chef Julian," I said, in my school secretary voice — the one that is warm and completely impossible to say no to. "About lemon zest."

Julian appeared behind the young man's shoulder before the door had fully opened. He was in his kitchen whites, sleeves rolled to the elbow, a towel tucked into his apron, and he was holding a service tray in one hand and a cloth in the other. The tray was already clean. He was still scrubbing it.

"Mrs. Finch," he said, and his face did the thing good chefs do when someone comes to them about food — a brightening that is part professional and part genuine, because the best ones can't tell the difference anymore. "Come in, come in. Mind the threshold — it catches everyone."

The galley was smaller than I'd expected and hotter than it had any right to be. Two prep stations ran along the far wall, copper pans hanging from an overhead rack in descending order of size, and the air smelled of butter and something herbal — tarragon, maybe, or chervil — and underneath that the clean metallic smell of a kitchen scrubbed with personal conviction. There was a narrow window above the secondary sink, and through it the mountains sat gray and low and patient under their clouds.



Julian set the tray down and rinsed the cloth under the tap, wringing it with both hands. His fingers were working hard — not easy tidying motions but tight, repetitive ones — hands that needed to be busy. A nervous chef scrubbing a clean tray could be hiding something that has nothing to do with food. Or it could be a man whose instinct is to erase — to make every surface spotless, every trace gone — which is exactly the kind of habit that makes a tasting plate disappear without anyone thinking twice. I watched his hands and couldn't tell which, and he caught me looking and smiled, and the smile was quick and good, and he picked up a paring knife instead and began zesting a lemon with the casual precision of ten thousand lemons behind him and ten thousand more ahead.

"Lemon zest," he said. "For the biscuits. I had one yesterday — the lemon comes through beautifully. A little salt in the dough?"

"A pinch. Frank's mother's recipe, though I've adjusted the butter."

"Always adjust the butter." He nodded with the gravity of a man discussing scripture. "Butter is a conversation, not a rule."

He produced a small jar from a shelf — fresh zest, already curled and bright — and set it on the counter between us. "Take what you need. I'll make more."

"That's very kind."

"It's lemon zest, not a kidney." He grinned, and then the grin softened into something more comfortable, and he leaned against the prep station — a man who'd decided the person in front of him was worth the pause in his morning.

I asked about the blood orange from yesterday — the "palate wake-up" he'd served the trio. His eyes lit up. He explained the sourcing, the specific variety, how the acidity balanced against the mascarpone, and I listened with genuine interest, because I have always believed that people who care about what they do are the most interesting people alive, regardless of what the thing is. Julian cared about food the way Arthur cared about procedure — completely, and with the quiet assumption that everyone else should too.

“I brought Mr. Vance a tasting plate yesterday afternoon,” Julian said, turning the lemon in his hand. “A small one — seared duck liver on brioche, a fig reduction, a curl of aged Gruyère. Beautiful plate.” He looked at the lemon. “He barely glanced at it. Waved me off like I was delivering the mail. I asked him about getting into the cargo hold — since it was his private charter, he’d made it clear that even the ice in the galley was his personal property — and he just told me to talk to the steward about it and shut the door.”

“Some people don’t notice what’s in front of them,” I said.

“Some people don’t deserve what’s in front of them,” Julian said, and then caught himself, and the grin came back, smaller this time. “That’s unkind. The man is dead. But he was not a man who appreciated a fig reduction, and I think that tells you something.”

I agreed that it did. I also wondered, without saying so, whether it was true. Julian’s wounded pride was convincing — the tightness around his mouth when he said “barely glanced at it,” his hand turning the lemon harder. But if the food was the weapon, “he didn’t eat it” is exactly what you’d say, and wounded pride is exactly what you’d show, and hands that could plate a fig reduction with surgical precision could probably plate an emotion just as carefully. I didn’t know. I liked Julian. I also knew that liking someone is not the same as knowing them, which was a lesson I’d already reminded myself about once this week and apparently needed to hear again.

The tasting plate tray was gone, of course — back into the galley rotation, scrubbed clean — standard kitchen discipline, or the most natural method in the world for making something disappear.

I noted, without saying so, that Julian had brought food, not tea. The tray from the corridor outside Vance’s suite had held two cups: one whiskey, one chamomile. Julian was an Earl Grey man — I’d seen the tin on his shelf not two feet from where I stood, Mariage Frères, the good kind, with the dark blue label. No chamomile in this galley that I could see.

Julian checked the clock on the galley wall — a quick, automatic glance, the kind you don’t notice unless you notice everything, which unfortunately

I do. He pulled a small notepad from his apron pocket, wrote something down, and tucked it back.

“The route today,” I said, because the conversation was warm and open and this was the door I’d come to walk through. “You mentioned yesterday that your uncle worked this line?”

Julian’s hands slowed on the lemon. Not a stop — a settling, a person adjusting to a memory that has some weight to it.

“Uncle Claude,” he said. “My mother’s brother. Worked signals and track maintenance on this route for eighteen years. Loved it — said you could feel the whole mountain through the rail if you put your hand on the track in the morning, before the first train came through.” Julian set the lemon down. “And then they sold the whole thing. Some investment company bought the line, closed the regional depots, cut the workforce to nothing. Uncle Claude was fifty-three. Eighteen years of service and they gave him a letter and six weeks’ severance and told him his pension had been restructured, which turned out to mean it didn’t exist anymore.”

“I’m sorry,” I said, and meant it — because I knew what a restructured pension looked like. I’d sat in Dorothy’s kitchen and seen it.

“Vance Capital,” Julian said, and the name landed in the galley between us with the dull weight of something carried a long time. “My uncle talked about them at every family gathering for years. The company that bought the line, gutted it, sold the pieces. Said they treated the railroad like a carcass — took what was worth taking and left the bones.” He shook his head. “He never worked again. Not properly. Odd jobs, maintenance contracts that came and went. Eighteen years, and they gave him a letter.”

Vance Capital. The same name Arthur had said in my cabin, connecting the substandard steel to the bridge at Alder Creek. Julian offered it the way you offer a family word — something you’ve heard so often it’s just furniture. He didn’t know what he’d confirmed — not the bridge, not the steel, but the pattern. Vance Capital destroying what it touched.

He picked up the lemon again and went back to zesting, and his hands were steady now — the memory had settled into the practiced groove that old

family stories find when they've been told enough times. He didn't connect Vance Capital to the man who'd died a car away in the Golden Spike suite. Julian's grief about his uncle was inherited — real, but worn smooth, carried in the pocket like a stone you don't look at anymore but don't throw away.

"Excuse me one moment," Julian said, glancing at the clock again. "I need to check on something downstairs. The cold storage situation on this train is —" He made a face that expressed a professional's contempt for amateur infrastructure. "I'll be five minutes."

"Take your time," I said. "I have my zest."

He disappeared through a narrow door at the back of the galley that I hadn't noticed before — it led, I assumed, downward toward the cargo holds. I stood in his kitchen with the jar of lemon zest in my hand and the copper pans catching the gray light from the window and the smell of butter and tarragon settling into my cardigan in a way that would last until I washed it, which I wouldn't, because I like carrying the days with me.

Frank would have liked Julian. He would have said something dismissive about fancy cooking — Frank believed a meal should take less time to prepare than to eat, which is a philosophy that leads to a lot of sandwiches — but he would have liked the man behind it. The care. The pride. The way Julian talked about his uncle with the easy specificity of a childhood where work mattered, that the people who did it mattered, that a rail line wasn't just track and signals but a man putting his hand on the rail in the morning and feeling the mountain through it.

Julian came back in four minutes, wiping his hands on his apron, and walked me to the galley door warmly — he'd enjoyed the interruption and wouldn't mind another one.

"Come back anytime," he said. "I'll teach you a thing about fig reduction."

I thanked him and walked back through the dining car with my jar of lemon zest and a head full of things that didn't quite fit together — a clean tray scrubbed too hard, a tasting plate that wasn't tea, a clock watched twice in fifteen minutes, a cargo hold visited with professional urgency, and a man's

uncle who had felt the mountain through the rail of a line that someone else had decided wasn't worth keeping.

None of it added up to anything yet. But I've been alive long enough to know that things that don't add up are usually waiting for the number you haven't found, and the number is usually smaller and quieter than you expect.

## Chapter 12: The Systems Man

The dining car had emptied after lunch, and the three of them sat at their usual table with the remains of a meal that Julian had over-engineered and they had under-appreciated — a crab bisque that Bernie had pronounced “thermally flawless” before eating it in silence. The white tablecloth between them held crumbs and water rings and the ghost of a conversation that hadn’t started yet.

Arthur kept his voice low. “Miller talked to me this morning. Vance was paranoid about the route. He’d been looking at the map the morning before he died, muttering about a bridge — didn’t name it to Miller, but we know which one. Just got twitchy and sent everyone away at four o’clock, same as always. Double-locked the door.”

Hazel’s teacup paused halfway to her mouth.

“Kitchen staff visited the suite around five-thirty,” Arthur continued. “Brought a small tray. Asked Vance about cargo access. Short visit — couple of minutes. Vance was alive and in a foul mood. Miller heard him through the door but didn’t go in. Didn’t see whether Vance ate anything.”

“That was Julian,” Hazel said. “He told me this morning. A tasting plate — duck liver, fig reduction. He claims Vance barely looked at it. But Miller couldn’t confirm that. Julian was alone in that suite with food, and the only person who can tell us what happened to it is dead.”

The three of them sat with that.

“I also asked about the medications,” Arthur said. “Miller says Vance sometimes took his own evening pills if Elena was slow — popped the lid and washed them down with whiskey. Elena hated it, something about the alcohol affecting absorption. So the empty pill organizer could be self-administration. Could be Elena getting back to the door somehow. Could be something else.” He looked at Hazel. “And Elena’s cover story for the missing Digoxin?”

“A hotel in Chicago,” Hazel said. “She doesn’t believe it herself.”

“So we have three open questions,” Arthur said. “Who brought chamomile. Whether Vance ate the food. Where the Digoxin went.”

“And Julian brought food, not tea,” Hazel said. “I confirmed it this morning — Earl Grey only, no chamomile anywhere in his galley. Someone else brought that cup.”

The chamomile question again. Still no answer.

Arthur folded his napkin and set it beside his plate — a small, precise gesture that meant the briefing was over and the next thing was action. Bernie pushed his chair back.

“I want to map the full ventilation system,” he said. “Every panel, every override, the complete circuit. What I found the night Vance died was one data point. I need the pattern.”

Arthur nodded. Hazel looked at Bernie over her teacup with an expression that was either concern or encouragement, and possibly both.

“Be careful,” she said.

“I’m measuring air pressure, Hazel. It’s not dangerous.”

“I’m just pointing out that there may be things to worry about other than air pressure.”

Bernie adjusted his spectacles and stood, and took his phone and his tracker and his particular way of looking at the world, and walked toward the service corridor.

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Behind the velvet curtains, the train was a different machine. Bernie worked down the corridor lifting one drape after another, and behind each the mahogany and brass gave way to painted steel and cable runs, overhead pipes wrapped in lagging, junction boxes with hand-lettered labels in railroad shorthand that he photographed because shorthand was data and data was never wasted. The recesses were shallow and dim, each lit by a single caged bulb that threw more shadow than light, and the floor thrummed beneath him with the train’s movement — a low, continuous vibration he could feel through his shoes and into the bones of his feet.

He worked methodically, the way he worked everything. Panel one: car seven, behind a curtain near the luggage alcove. Brass fittings, two dials, a

pressure gauge, a row of labeled switches. Dusty. The dials stiff when he tested them with a fingertip — they hadn't been turned in months, maybe longer. He photographed the gauge reading, the dust pattern, the switch positions. He recorded the atmospheric pressure on his tracker and noted the time.

Panel two: car six. Same configuration. Same dust. The dials had faint wear marks — consistent with periodic depot servicing — but were stiff, the brass housing lightly scratched in the ordinary way that brass gets scratched when someone turns a dial once or twice a year during an inspection.

Linda used to watch him do this — not with trains, but with the house. The furnace filter, the weather stripping around the back door, the thermostat he checked every evening before bed. She'd lean in the doorway and say something like "Are you coming to bed or are you auditing the heating system?" and he'd say "Both," which was true but not the answer she wanted. He kept the house at sixty-eight because she got headaches above seventy. He changed the furnace filter every six weeks instead of eight because her spring allergies were bad and the standard interval didn't account for the oak pollen in their neighbourhood. He'd wanted to tell her that the thermostat was how he paid attention — that sixty-eight degrees was a love letter written in a language she didn't read. But he'd never found the words for it, and after twenty-three years she'd found a lawyer who spoke in sentences that were clear and final and had nothing to do with furnace filters.

Panel three: car five. Bernie opened the brass cover and paused.

The dials were the same. The switches were the same. The right dial had the same faint stiffness as the other panels — the resistance of a mechanism that sat idle between annual inspections. But the left dial — the one that controlled airflow volume for this section — was different. He turned it, and it moved under his fingers with an ease the others hadn't. Smooth. Loosened. The mechanism had been exercised — not once or twice a year, but regularly, the way a hinge loosens when someone opens a door every day instead of every season.



He checked his tracker: this was the panel nearest Vance's suite. The one he'd examined the night Vance died, the one with no dust, the one with the pressure anomaly. He'd noted the missing dust then, and the pressure readings, but he hadn't tested the dial against the others — there'd been no reason to, with nothing to compare it against. Now, after two panels with stiff, untouched dials, the difference was unmistakable. Not visible — he couldn't have seen it from across the corridor. But under his fingers, the differential resistance told a story the same way a thermostat reading told a story: someone had been turning this dial regularly, and only this dial, on only this panel, the one that controlled airflow to the Golden Spike suite.

He didn't write a conclusion in his notes. He wrote: *Left dial, differential resistance — mechanism loosened by repeated use. Dust pattern consistent with Ch6 findings. Compare with depot maintenance schedule.* That was enough. The data would tell him what it meant when there was enough of it, and not before.

He closed the panel and moved on.

Panel four was in the corridor outside the staff quarters — a narrower passage with cabin doors on both sides, name plates in small brass frames. He counted doors as he passed. STEWARD. STEWARD. GALLEY STAFF. HEAD STEWARD. No CONDUCTOR — the conductor didn't berth back here with the rest of the crew. His cabin was forward, in the Pullman itself, two doors from the Golden Spike suite. Bernie paused, not because the absence meant anything yet, but because his feet had already measured the other distance. From the conductor's cabin door to the panel outside Vance's suite — the panel with the scratched dial and the missing dust — was fifteen feet of corridor and a velvet curtain.

He noted the distance. He didn't circle it or underline it. It was a measurement, and measurements didn't become meaningful until they joined other measurements, and Bernie had learned a long time ago that the most dangerous thing you could do with data was decide what it meant too early.

"Can I help you, sir?"

The Conductor was behind him — not close, not crowding, just present in the corridor with the settled ease of something that belonged there. Cap

level, hands clasped behind his back, and the helpful, incurious expression that staff learn to wear when passengers wander where they shouldn't be.

"The maintenance panels," Bernie said. "I was curious about the pressurization system. Engineering interest."

"Ah." The Conductor nodded. "Fire safety, mostly. Manual overrides for each section — lets you isolate airflow if there's smoke or a chemical situation. Standard on vintage rolling stock. The original system was pneumatic; this is the retrofit." He gestured toward the panel Bernie had just closed. "I wouldn't know the engineering of it, to be honest. I just work the route. The mechanical team services them at the depot."

"You don't use them yourself?"

"Only if we had a fire or a pressure emergency. Which we haven't, thank God." He smiled — brief, professional. "Is there anything else you need? The passenger cars are more comfortable, I promise."

"No, thank you," Bernie said. "Just satisfying a curiosity."

The Conductor nodded again and moved past him, checking a latch on a supply closet without breaking stride. His footsteps were even and quiet on the steel floor — routine, nothing more. Smaller and more ordinary than the uniform suggested.

Bernie stood where he was for another minute after the footsteps faded. The corridor hummed. The pipes above him carried air to every compartment on the train — the same air, the same system, pushed and pulled by the same pumps, controlled by the same dials. He'd spent his career measuring things like this: the systems that kept people alive and the margins by which they failed. Bridge tolerances, flood levees, the actuarial tables that predicted when a structure would give way and how many people would be standing on it when it did.

The loosened dial said someone had used this system to change the air in a locked room. The data was building — the dust differential, the pressure anomaly, and now the dial that turned too easily, that spoke of practice, not neglect. But Bernie was honest enough with himself to know that he was building the case for his theory while two others sat unresolved. A bottle of

heart medication was still missing. A tasting plate had still been washed. He was measuring air while Arthur was chasing poison and Hazel was reading faces, and any one of them could be right, and the dial that felt so certain under his fingers might turn out to be the depot technician's habit, or the routine adjustment a charter suite gets for every VIP who complains the air is too dry or too cold, rather than a killer's rehearsal.

He didn't think so. But thinking wasn't knowing, and the gap between them was where mistakes lived. Linda had told him once that he loved being right more than he loved being careful, and he'd told her that being right WAS being careful, and neither of them had convinced the other, and eventually she'd stopped trying.

He put his phone in his pocket and walked back toward the passenger cars, past the conductor's cabin and through the velvet curtain and into the mahogany and brass world where the air smelled like furniture polish and the pipes were hidden and everyone breathed without thinking about where it came from.

## Chapter 13: The Lens Cloth

The observation car was empty except for Skye, which surprised me, because it was the sort of afternoon that should have drawn people to the windows — the mountains going gray and strange, the rain turning the glass into something you looked at instead of through. But the other passengers had retreated to their cabins or the bar car, and Skye had the panoramic end to herself, her tripod set up near the curved rear windows with the camera dark on top of it. She was talking to no one. Her lips were moving and her hands were doing that thing I've seen television presenters do — small, calibrated gestures, palms turning outward, chin lifting at the end of a phrase — and she was mouthing the words running a line over and over until it sounded natural, which of course meant it wasn't.

I watched her for a few seconds from the doorway. A woman practising how to be herself. It's not as strange as it sounds. I spent thirty years at the front desk of an elementary school, and every September the new teachers would stand in the hallway before their first class, mouthing their opening lines, adjusting their posture, rehearsing the version of themselves they wanted thirty children to believe in. I never told any of them I'd seen it. Some performances are kinder if the performer doesn't know they're being watched.

"I brought biscuits," I said, because I had, and because a biscuit is the most disarming object in the world. You cannot suspect a woman holding a tin of homemade shortbread of anything except perhaps using too much butter, which I do, and which is nobody's business but mine.

Skye turned with a start that was half genuine and half performance — she'd already composed her face by the time she was fully around, the way people do when they've had practice being caught.

"Mrs. Finch! Oh, how sweet. I was just — running through some voiceover for a segment. The algorithm likes consistency." She smiled the bright, generous smile you give to harmless things — puppies, toddlers, old women with biscuit tins. "Are those lemon?"

"Lemon zest. Please."

She took one and bit into it with careful delicacy — aware of her camera even when it was off, and said “Oh, that’s lovely” with what I think was genuine surprise, and sat down on the curved bench near the windows, and I sat down across from her with my tea and my tin and the pleasant expression I wear when I am paying very close attention to someone.

The rain was coming harder now. It hit the observation windows in long diagonal streaks that blurred the already blurred mountains, and the light in the car had gone the color of dishwater — flat and gray and unkind to everything it touched. Skye glanced at the windows with quiet despair — her livelihood depended on things she couldn’t control.

“This light,” she said. “Two days ago the golden hour out here was — I mean, I got footage that would make you cry. The peaks, the sky, brass fittings catching the sunset. And now?” She gestured at the gray. “My followers expect a certain look. Warm, luminous, aspirational. You can’t do aspirational in this. I’ve been trying to get a usable angle for three hours and the whole atmospheric pressure system on this train is — it’s an old pneumatic retrofit, you can feel it in the way the air sits — and the condensation on the interior glass is destroying every shot.”

I took a sip of my tea. Pneumatic retrofit. I filed it and didn’t look up. Vloggers talk about lighting and angles and golden hours. They don’t, in my experience, talk about pneumatic retrofits, and they don’t say “atmospheric pressure system” with the fluency of a phrase they’ve used before and thought about carefully. But I have been wrong about people, and I would rather be wrong slowly than right too fast, so I said, “That must be very frustrating, dear,” and offered her another biscuit, and she took it.

“It really is. I mean, this is supposed to be — the whole point of this trip was the visuals. Luxury train, mountain passes, that old-world romance.” She bit the biscuit and chewed with the focused irritation of someone redirecting their energy. “Now it’s just gray. Gray and wet. I might as well be in Newark.”

She pulled a microfiber cloth from her pocket and began cleaning the camera lens — not because it needed cleaning, but in the compulsive way people tend to things when the weather has taken away everything else

they can control. Small circles, over and over, polishing the glass as though she could will the clouds to clear.

Frank used to do that. Not with a camera — Frank wouldn't have known which end to point — but with his spectacles. Every time the mist came down in the mountains he'd pull them off and clean them with his tie, slowly and thoroughly, as though the problem were his lenses and not the entire state of Colorado. He said mountains were scenery that hides the road. I told him that was overly dramatic for a man who got anxious on any highway with a gradient, and he said I could talk when I'd driven Loveland Pass in fog, and I said I wouldn't drive Loveland Pass in sunshine because I had sense, and we'd had that conversation perhaps forty times over forty years and neither of us ever got tired of it, which I suppose is either love or stubbornness, and with Frank it was usually both.

Skye was still polishing. I watched her hands and felt that familiar pull — the warmth and the irritation braided together, as they always are when someone reminds you of a person you can't argue with anymore.

"Such a shame about Mr. Vance," I said, setting my teacup down with the mild social gravity of a woman making conversation. "I helped clear a tea tray from the corridor near his suite that evening, you know. Before dinner. It felt strange afterward — touching something that had been so close to all that."

Skye's cloth paused on the lens. Half a beat, maybe less. Then it resumed.

"I saw one of the staff in that corridor," she said. "Around six, I think? The one in the uniform — very correct, very proper. I didn't think anything of it at the time." She shrugged. "You don't, do you? Staff are just — staff."

"You notice things, though," I said. "With your camera."

"It's what I do." The bright smile again. "I film everything. Occupational hazard."

I nodded and drank my tea and thought about the fact that she'd placed a member of staff in the corridor near Vance's suite at six o'clock — inside the window, after Julian's visit and before dinner — and she'd offered it

unprompted, and I didn't know yet what that meant but I knew it was worth carrying home.

Raymond appeared in the corridor beyond the observation car — visible through the glass partition, moving from one car to the next with his clipboard, steady and exact. He crossed the frame of the glass like a figure passing through a photograph, and I happened to be looking at Skye when he did.

Her face changed. It was fast — two seconds, maybe less — but I saw it. The influencer dropped away and what was underneath was cold and focused and very still, the stillness of someone watching something they've been watching for a long time and haven't finished with yet. Not the look of a fan admiring a uniform. Not the look of a woman noticing a man. It was the look of someone cataloguing, and the eyes doing the cataloguing had nothing to do with sunsets or content.

Then Raymond was gone past the glass, and the mask came back so smoothly I might have imagined it, and Skye said, "The staff on this train — honestly, so dedicated. He's always checking on something, isn't he?" and her voice was warm and light and completely wrong.

"They do work hard," I said.

"They really do." She turned back to me with that generous, slightly pitying expression — the nice old lady, the biscuit woman, the harmless interruption to her afternoon — and said, "So Mrs. Finch, was this your first time seeing something like that? A death, I mean. On a trip like this." She tilted her head. "It must have been such a shock."

"It was unexpected," I said.

"And you were one of the first to know, weren't you? You and your friends. Arthur, and the gentleman with the glasses. You three seem so close. Were you involved in — I mean, did you see anything, the evening he died?"

The questions were pleasant and sympathetic and arrived in order, each one building on the last, and I recognized the structure because I'd been on the receiving end of it for three decades. Parents would come to the school office and say "I just want to understand what happened" and then ask six

questions that were really one question, and each question would narrow the field until they got what they'd come for. Skye was doing the same thing with a warmer smile and better lighting.

I gave her something true and useless. "We were at dinner when it happened. The dining car. Arthur noticed Mr. Vance hadn't come down, and the staff went to check." I shook my head. "Terrible thing. He seemed like a very important man."

"He was," Skye said, and her voice carried a weight that didn't match the gossip, and I watched her tuck my answer away with tidy efficiency — a place for everything, and she knew exactly what she was building.

"Well," I said, and stood, and collected my tin. "I should let you get back to your content. The light might improve."

"It won't," Skye said, and for a moment the sourness was real and unperformed, and I liked her better for it.

I walked back toward my cabin through the dining car, where the white tablecloths glowed in the gray light and a single steward was resetting silver for dinner. Through the windows the mountains had been gone for hours. But now the rain was changing. The streaks on the glass had thickened and slowed, and mixed in among them were the first heavy flakes — not the light, decorative snow you see on Christmas cards, but the wet, dense, purposeful kind. Working snow. The kind that means the sky has made a decision and isn't interested in discussing it.

I stood at the window for a moment and watched it come down. The brass fittings along the dining car windows caught no light at all. The glass showed me my own reflection, dim and indistinct against the white — a woman in a cardigan holding a biscuit tin, looking at weather that was closing in.

Frank would have cleaned his spectacles.

I went to my cabin and set the tin on the fold-down table next to his timetable and sat on the narrow berth and thought about a woman who performs herself for a living and forgot, for two seconds, to perform. I didn't know what Skye was. But I knew she wasn't what she said she was, and



I knew she was watching Raymond with eyes that belonged to someone else, and I knew she'd placed a man in a corridor at six o'clock without being asked, and I knew her questions arrived in a sequence that had been designed, not discovered.

I also knew that none of this made her a killer. It made her a person with a secret, and on this train, that was a crowded category.

The snow was heavier now. I could hear it — a soft, steady hiss against the window of my cabin, different from the rain. The mountains were out there somewhere behind it, enormous and patient and completely hidden, and the train moved through them slowly, and the world got smaller, and the glass got whiter, and I thought I might bring Arthur and Bernie some biscuits after dinner and tell them about the woman who knew what a pneumatic retrofit was and watched Raymond like she was memorising him for later.

## Chapter 14: The Cargo Run

The last plate went into the rack at nine-forty and Julian wiped the counter one more time, though it was already clean. The galley smelled of butter and the ghost of tarragon and the particular mineral smell that stainless steel takes on when it's been scrubbed too hard, which Julian's surfaces always had been, because his hands needed occupation and cleaning was the closest thing to cooking when there was nothing left to cook.

The junior steward had gone twenty minutes ago. The dishwasher hummed through its final cycle. Through the narrow window above the secondary sink, snow moved against the glass in thick diagonal streaks, the flakes fat and wet and relentless, the kind that accumulated without asking permission. Julian watched them for a moment, then checked the clock on the galley wall. Nine forty-three. He dried his hands on a towel that was already dry and hung it on the rail and checked the clock again.

He waited until the corridor sounds thinned — the last passengers drifting to their cabins, the bar car going quiet, the stewards finishing their rounds. The train had slowed in the last hour. He could feel it in the floor, a change in the vibration's pitch, the engine working harder against the grade and the weather both. Good. The slower it went, the closer it came to what he needed.

The narrow door at the back of the galley opened onto a service stairwell that smelled of machine oil and cold metal. Julian took it down, his chef's clogs replaced with soft-soled shoes he kept in his locker for exactly this purpose. The stairs were steep and grated, and the temperature dropped with each step — the insulated luxury of the passenger cars giving way to the working body of the train underneath, where the pipes ran exposed and the walls were painted steel and the overhead lights were bare bulbs in wire cages, spaced too far apart to do more than make the shadows move.

He'd made this trip four times since Chicago. The first night, his hands had been shaking. By the third, he'd had the route memorized — fourteen steps down, left at the junction box labeled CRG-3, thirty feet of corridor past the luggage racks and the spare linen storage, then the cargo hold proper, where the air was ten degrees colder than the rest of the train and smelled

of pine crating and packing foam and the faint diesel undertone that lived in the bones of every railcar ever built.

The cargo hold was longer than most passengers would have guessed. Crates and cases lined both walls on steel shelving, secured with canvas straps — luggage overflow, kitchen supplies, a crate of wine Julian had ordered for the return journey and charged to Vance's account because Vance would never have noticed and now never would. Near the far end, past the spare mattresses and a stack of folded tablecloths wrapped in plastic, three wooden crates sat on the lowest shelf, marked with the same shipping labels as the kitchen supplies. PERISHABLE — TEMPERATURE SENSITIVE. Julian had written the labels himself.

He knelt and unlatched the nearest crate. Inside, nested in custom-cut foam, a dozen pieces sat in individual compartments — ceramic vessels, a stone mask with empty oval eyes, a small obsidian blade, and in the center compartment, wrapped in unbleached cotton, the piece his contact wanted most.

Julian lifted it out. A jade figurine, six inches tall, heavy for its size. A seated figure with crossed legs and an elaborate headdress, the jade a deep mottled green that caught the caged light and held it. Mesoamerican. Old enough that the carved lines had softened with centuries of handling, the stone worn smooth in places where other hands — priests, collectors, thieves, other middlemen like himself — had held it and turned it and judged its worth. He cradled it in both palms, feeling the weight and the coolness and the dense mineral patience of a thing that had outlasted everyone who'd ever owned it.

He checked it the way he checked *mise en place* — systematically, without sentiment. No chips. No new scratches from transit. The foam held everything firm. He set the figurine back in its compartment and opened the second crate. Same. Everything where he'd packed it, undamaged, waiting.

His phone was in his back pocket. He pulled it out and checked the weather — the National Weather Service forecast he'd been refreshing every two hours since they'd left Chicago. The storm system was sprawling across the Front Range, exactly where the models had predicted, and the accumulation

estimates had gone up since dinner. Eight to fourteen inches above nine thousand feet. Winds gusting to forty-five. The pass they were approaching would be impassable by morning.

Below the forecast, a text message from a number with no name attached. Three words and a time: *Siding 7. Thursday. 0200.*

Julian read it twice. Siding 7 was a maintenance turnout on the western descent — remote, unlit, accessible by a forest service road that wouldn't be plowed until the storm passed. His contact would be there with a truck. The handoff would take fifteen minutes. The crates would disappear into the mountains and Julian would go back to his galley and plate breakfast and pour coffee and be a chef who had never been anything else.

He typed a single character — a period — and sent it. Confirmation without content. Then he deleted the thread, as his contact had instructed, though it felt like insufficient precaution for a crime that involved wooden crates and a freight car and his actual hands.

The restaurant. That was what this was for. Not a dream restaurant, not a vision — a real place, a lease he'd found in Baton Rouge, a corner spot with good light and a ventilation hood that had been installed by someone who understood the physics of a professional kitchen. The deposit was forty thousand dollars and Julian had eleven. His credit was wrecked — two failed partnerships, a line of credit he'd cosigned for his ex-sous chef who'd vanished to Portland with the balance unpaid. The banks had stopped returning his calls.

Forty thousand. The figurine alone was worth more than that, if the provenance papers his contact had provided were accurate, and Julian suspected they weren't, but that was the contact's problem, not his. Julian's problem was the deposit and the lease expiring in March and the fact that he was forty-one years old and had spent twenty years making beautiful food in other people's kitchens and wanted, just once, to do it in his own.

He repacked the crate and latched it and stood, his knees stiff from the cold floor. The cargo hold hummed around him — the low, industrial sound of the train working, the pipes overhead carrying heat to the passenger cars

where people slept in mahogany-paneled cabins without knowing or caring what kept them warm.

While he brushed foam dust from his knees, his mind went where he'd been trying not to let it go. Vance's suite. The tasting plate — seared duck liver on brioche, fig reduction, a curl of aged Gruyère. He'd carried it in at five-thirty and set it on the desk and Vance had barely looked at it, had waved one hand and said something about cargo access and Julian had smiled his professional smile and left. Two minutes, maybe less. The room had smelled of whiskey and aftershave and the faintly stale air of a man who kept his windows sealed and his people out.

Altitude sickness, they'd said. A cardiac event. Julian had no reason to doubt it. But he'd been in that room, standing where the dead man had been sitting, breathing the air that had killed him — if that was in fact what had killed him — and the proximity of it sat in his stomach like a meal he couldn't quite digest. He hadn't told anyone about the feeling. There was nothing to tell. He'd brought food. The man had died. The two events occupied the same evening but not, as far as Julian could determine, the same cause.

He climbed the stairs back to the service corridor, moving quietly in his soft-soled shoes. The corridor was dim and narrow, the overhead pipes casting latticed shadows on the steel walls. His hands smelled of foam and wood and the faint green mineral scent of old jade, and he was thinking about washing them in the galley sink when the Conductor appeared at the far end of the corridor, coming from the direction of the passenger cars.

Raymond walked with his clipboard under one arm, checking latches as he went, testing a handle, adjusting something Julian couldn't see. The caged bulbs caught him in intervals — there, then shadow, then there again. The train at night was his territory, and he moved through it without effort, part of the mechanism.

"Evening, Chef. The sourdough tonight was exceptional, by the way."

"Thank you." Julian managed a smile that cost him more than it should have.

Raymond nodded and passed. Julian pressed himself against the wall to make room in the narrow space, and Raymond went by with the easy warmth of a man who noticed good work and said so. His footsteps continued down the corridor, even and measured, and then he was around the corner and gone.

Julian stood for a moment after the footsteps faded. He couldn't have said why. Nothing had happened — a man had walked past him in a corridor, the same man who walked past everyone on this train a dozen times a day, doing his job, checking his train. He wiped his palms on his trousers and kept walking.

The galley was dark except for the blue standby light on the dishwasher. Julian washed his hands — thoroughly, the way he washed them between courses, hot water and soap to the wrists, under the nails, between the fingers. The foam and jade smell dissolved into the scent of industrial soap, and he dried his hands on a fresh towel and hung it on the rail and looked at the clock.

Ten twenty-seven.

The snow was heavier against the window now. He could hear it — a soft, continuous hiss, different from the rain that had preceded it, steadier and more patient. The copper pans hung on their overhead rack in descending size, their bottoms reflecting the corridor light that leaked through the service door, and Julian stood in his galley and listened to the storm building and thought about a corner restaurant in Baton Rouge with good light and a hood that worked and his name on the lease.

The train shuddered — a small adjustment, the brakes or the grade or the wind — and the pans swayed on their hooks, and the snow kept falling, and Julian checked the clock one more time before he turned off the light.

## Chapter 15: First Snow

I woke to a white window and thought for a moment that the blind had come down in the night, which it hadn't — I'd checked the mechanism twice before bed and it was the stiff, resentful kind that required two hands and a certain amount of negotiation, and I'd left it up because I liked waking to whatever the mountains were doing. What the mountains were doing, it turned out, was disappearing. The glass was a flat white-gray, the snow so thick and close that there was no depth to it, no distance, just the soft static of a world that had decided to close for the day.

I put the kettle on. Frank's timetable sat on the nightstand where it always sat, his red-pen circle around the San Francisco arrival and "window seat — LEFT side for Rockies" underlined twice in handwriting that looked like it had been produced during a minor earthquake. He would have pressed his face to this window and cleaned his spectacles and said something about the visibility, and I would have told him there was no visibility, and he would have cleaned them again anyway, because Frank believed that most problems between himself and the world were optical.

The Earl Grey needed watching. I'd asked the steward for loose leaf and he'd found some in the back of a cupboard that I suspected had been there since the train's previous incarnation, but it was adequate if you caught it at three minutes and not a second longer. I caught it, poured, added nothing — milk in Earl Grey is a thing people do and I have never understood it — and took my cup and two biscuits from the tin and went to the observation car.

It was empty. The curved rear windows showed nothing but white, the brass railings along the panoramic section catching a dull, flat light that made them look like old pennies. The bench seats had been arranged overnight by someone with a ruler and strong opinions about symmetry — the cushions squared, the armrests aligned, the small side tables wiped to a shine that reflected the nothing outside. I sat in what I'd come to think of as my spot, the second seat from the left where the heating vent ran under the floor and kept my feet at a temperature that didn't require complaint, and I drank my tea and watched the snow fall.

It was serious snow. Not the decorative kind that had started last evening — the light, uncertain flakes that couldn't decide whether they were rain

or ambition — but the heavy, committed sort that falls straight down and means it. The mountains were somewhere behind it. I could feel them out there — present, enormous, patient — but the snow had drawn a curtain over everything beyond twenty feet, and the train moved through a white corridor that had no walls and no ceiling and no end.

I thought about how quickly a big thing can disappear when something quiet and steady covers it.

The door at the far end opened and the Conductor came through, clipboard under one arm, moving along the windows with the unhurried precision of a man doing something he'd done ten thousand times. He ran his fingers along the window seals — not checking, exactly, more the way a pianist touches keys before playing, confirming that everything was where it should be. His uniform was pressed to a standard that would have satisfied a drill sergeant and possibly offended one, and his shoes caught the thin light with each step.

“Good morning, Mrs. Finch.” He touched his cap. “Early riser.”

“Habit,” I said. “Thirty years of school bells.”

He nodded — brief, professional, a nod that closed the subject — and continued along the windows, his fingers finding each seal, pressing gently, moving on. At the third window he paused, reached under the bench, and pulled out a folded wool blanket.

“The temperature drops when the snow sits on the roof,” he said, offering it. “Changes the insulation. Most people don’t notice until their knees start complaining.”

“My knees started complaining in 1997 and haven’t stopped since,” I said, and took the blanket, which was heavier than it looked and smelled faintly of cedar and the warm, closed-in smell of things stored in small spaces on trains. “Thank you. How high are we?”

He glanced at the windows — not at a gauge, not at a phone, just at the snow and the angle of it and whatever it was the snow told him that it didn’t tell me. “Ten thousand, four hundred and seventeen feet. Give or take.” He said



it the way I'd say the address of the school — a number he'd passed through so many times it had stopped being information and become geography.

"Your ears must pop constantly."

"You get used to it." He straightened a fold in one of the window curtains that was already straight. "My brother used to work at altitude. Steel construction, up in Wyoming. He liked the cold. Said it made the steel tighter." A small, private expression crossed his face — not sadness, exactly, but the quiet surprise of having said more than he'd meant to. "Different kind of cold up there. Drier."

"Is he still in Wyoming?"

"No, ma'am." Raymond adjusted the curtain again, though it hadn't moved. "Not for a long time. Enjoy the morning, Mrs. Finch. I'll have someone check the heating in this car — the front vents can be sluggish when the temperature drops."

He touched his cap again and went through the far door, and the observation car was mine again, and the snow kept falling, and I pulled the blanket over my knees. Raymond Delk — I'd seen his surname on the crew notice in the dining car, the little printed card by the service bell that nobody reads. He'd just told me about his brother and the steel and the cold, and somehow that made him a person with a full name instead of just "the conductor." Raymond Delk, who knew ten thousand four hundred and seventeen feet without looking and whose brother had worked steel in the cold and who straightened things that were already straight. I didn't think anything particular about any of it because there was nothing to think. He was a good conductor. He knew his train.

I drank my tea. The snow was heavier now or the train was slower, or both, and the white outside the windows had thickened into something solid, a wall of weather that pressed against the glass with the soft insistence of cotton wool being packed around something fragile. The mountains had been enormous yesterday. I'd watched them from this same seat while the rain came down and Skye rehearsed herself and the light went gray and flat. Now they were gone. Not diminished — gone. As though they'd never been there at all, as though the whole enormous jagged fact of them had

been quietly removed while no one was looking, replaced with nothing, with white, with the absence of the thing that had been there.

And that was when Dorothy arrived.

Not Dorothy herself — Dorothy was in Terre Haute, Indiana, in a second-floor apartment on Maple Avenue with a balcony that could hold one plastic chair and a coffee mug, and even the coffee mug had to be the narrow kind. Dorothy Tillman, who had been the art teacher at Garfield Elementary for twenty-six years, who had retired the same spring I did, who had a garden.

Not a decorative garden. A real one — a quarter-acre behind the house on Poplar Street where she and Bill had lived for thirty-one years. Tomatoes, basil, a row of zinnias along the fence that she planted every April in colors that had no business working together and somehow always did. And the Japanese maple. She'd planted it the autumn after Bill died, a four-foot sapling she'd driven forty minutes to a nursery in Bloomington to find because she wanted a specific variety, a laceleaf that would turn the color of cranberries in October, and the nursery man had told her it would take ten years to reach its full shape and Dorothy had said, "Good. I'll have something to look forward to."

The pension fund collapsed in 2007. I didn't understand it at the time — collateralized something, credit default something else, and Vance Capital's name was in the papers and the letters and the class-action lawsuit that Dorothy looked into and couldn't afford to join because the lawyer's retainer was more than she had left after the fund took everything that was supposed to be her retirement and turned it into a line item in someone else's quarterly report.

She called me on a Tuesday. I remember it was a Tuesday because I'd been making lemon curd and the phone rang and I answered it with sticky hands and Dorothy said, "Hazel, I have to sell the house," and her voice was flat and dry and careful, the voice of a woman who had already cried and was done with that part and had moved on to the part where you say the words out loud and make them real.

I drove over. We sat in the garden. The maple had reached its full shape by then — twelve feet, the leaves that deep cranberry she'd wanted, the canopy

broad enough to shade the bench Bill had built underneath it. Dorothy didn't look at it while we talked. She looked at her hands, which were still brown from the garden, dirt under the nails, and she told me about the fund and the letters and the numbers that didn't add up and then added up to nothing, and I sat there and listened and didn't say any of the things people say because none of them were true.

She sold the house in November. The maple was bare by then, which was a small mercy — she didn't have to leave it in its color. The apartment on Maple Avenue was clean and adequate and had good light and a balcony that could hold one chair. She put one pot on it, a small terra-cotta thing with a geranium, and the first winter wind knocked it off the railing and she didn't replace it.

Vance Capital. I'd heard the name in the news, in Dorothy's kitchen, in the legal letters she'd shown me with a bewildered fury that had nowhere to go. And I'd been hearing it for three days on this train — Vance's train, Vance's suite, Vance's death — and the name had been a sound, a label on a dead man I'd never liked, and now it wasn't. Now it was Dorothy's garden. Dorothy's maple. A geranium that fell three stories and broke on a parking lot and stayed broken.

The snow pressed against the glass. I sat in the observation car with the conductor's blanket on my knees and a cup of tea going cold and I thought about a quarter-acre on Poplar Street that didn't exist anymore because a man in a silk tie had decided that other people's retirements were his margin, and that man had died in a locked suite sixty feet from where I was sitting, and the official verdict was altitude sickness, and I was not a detective and I was not a marshal and I was not an actuary and I had no authority and no expertise and no particular right to an opinion.

The snow fell. The mountains stayed hidden. I pulled the blanket tighter and finished my tea, which was cold now and over-steeped and bitter in a way I normally wouldn't have tolerated, and I drank it anyway, all of it, and set the cup down on the side table and looked at the white and thought about Dorothy's hands with the dirt still under her nails, and the geranium, and the maple, and the ten years of looking forward that someone else's arithmetic had turned into a line on a spreadsheet.

The heating vent hummed under my feet. Outside, the snow was patient and thorough and had all the time in the world.

## Chapter 16: Weather Closes In

The snow had been falling for eighteen hours and the train had been losing to it for the last three. By mid-afternoon the windows on the windward side were crusted white to the sills, and the ones on the lee side showed nothing but a gray-white murk that swallowed the world twenty yards out and erased everything else — mountains, sky, the distinction between the two. The *Starlight Express* crept through it at walking speed, its headlamp cutting a weak yellow cone into the storm that the storm immediately closed behind, as though the train were stitching a seam that came undone with every length it traveled.

In the galley, Julian stood at the narrow window above the secondary sink and watched the snow deepen on the trackbed below. His hands were still, which was unusual — no cloth, no scrubbing, no occupation. He held his phone loosely at his side, the weather forecast open, and his mouth was set in an expression that belonged on a different face in different circumstances. Not worry. Not the tight pragmatism of the Head Steward, who had passed through ten minutes ago muttering about schedules and liability and the generator's fuel consumption. Julian watched the snow the way a man watches a horse he's bet on coming around the final turn — intent, still, privately invested in an outcome he couldn't control and wouldn't explain.

A car back, Elena sat in the window seat of her cabin with her knitting in her lap. The modified Aran had grown six inches since yesterday and the stitches were tighter than they'd been at any point on the trip — the three-strand cable pulling into itself, the honeycomb fill so dense the dove-gray yarn looked almost solid. Her needles moved without pause, a mechanical rhythm that had nothing to do with the pattern and everything to do with the hands needing somewhere to go that wasn't her medication case or her own hair or the intercom button she'd pressed twice in three years of working for him and wished she'd never touched. Outside her window the white pressed in. She didn't look at it.

In the corridor between the dining car and the Pullman suites, the Conductor checked a latch, tested a handle, moved on. Raymond's pace hadn't changed since the snow started — the same measured steps, the same unhurried attention to each fitting and seal. The storm was a professional

fact, no different from a schedule change or a slow order on the grade. He adjusted a curtain that didn't need adjusting and continued toward the rear of the train, his polished shoes marking time on the carpet, his clipboard tucked under one arm with the easy discipline of decades, through worse weather and longer delays than these.

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Hazel found the Head Steward in the service alcove near the dining car, sorting through a clipboard of his own — supply lists, she guessed, or whatever it was that men with clipboards worried about when the world stopped cooperating. He looked up when she appeared and managed a smile that cost him something.

“Mrs. Finch. Can I help?”

“I was wondering about tea,” she said. “I’ve been drinking the Earl Grey, which is perfectly adequate, but I thought I might see what else you have. At altitude my stomach gets opinionated.”

The steward nodded — a practiced, managerial nod. “We have the Earl Grey, of course. English Breakfast. And a peppermint blend — the mint’s quite good, actually. Settles most things.”

“No chamomile?”

“I’m afraid not. We don’t stock it.” He said it simply, without apology — a fact about inventory, nothing more. “I can check whether the kitchen has anything herbal, but chamomile specifically, no. It’s never been part of the service selection.”

“Pity,” Hazel said. “My friend Dorothy swears by it for altitude. I may come back for the peppermint.”

She thanked him and left, and the steward returned to his lists, and the chamomile cup that had been sitting on a tray outside a dead man’s suite — barely touched, a tight grip smudge on the handle, a cup of tea that nobody in the galley had made and nobody in the service inventory had stocked — moved one step further from explanation and one step closer to something Hazel couldn’t yet name but could feel — enormous and unresolved behind the snow, waiting to be seen.

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She found Arthur and Bernie in the observation car, which was empty except for the three of them and the storm. Arthur stood at the rear windows with his hands in his pockets, watching the white the way he'd once watched courtrooms — assessing threat, calculating distance, waiting for the wrong thing to move. Bernie sat with a small notebook open on his knee, recording numbers that the situation offered and his temperament required: wind speed estimated from the snow's angle, accumulation rate, the train's decreasing velocity measured against his GPS tracker's fading signal.

"Julian," Arthur said, without preamble. He'd been thinking about it — Hazel could see that in the set of his jaw, how he turned from the window and faced them both as if they were a briefing he hadn't called but intended to run. "The chef was in that suite at five-thirty with food. His uncle worked the Alder Creek bridge. He grew up hearing about Pinnacle and the bad steel and the people who got hurt. He's nervous — he watches clocks, he visits the cargo hold, he scrubs clean surfaces. And the tray he brought the food on was washed and back in rotation before the body was cold."

"Julian says Vance didn't eat," Hazel said.

"Julian is the only witness to what happened in that room. Vance can't confirm. Miller didn't go in." Arthur's voice had the flat, unhurried certainty of a man laying out evidence for a grand jury. "That's means, motive, and opportunity. And a man acting like he has something to hide."

Bernie looked up from his notebook. "The food theory doesn't exclude ventilation. Both could be true — the tasting plate and the panel aren't mutually exclusive."

"They're not," Arthur agreed. "But one of them has a suspect attached. The ventilation has a mechanism and no face. Julian has a family connection to the collapse, he was alone with the victim, and he destroyed the evidence. Professional habit or not, that tray is gone."

Hazel didn't answer immediately. She thought about Julian's hands, their constant need for occupation, the nervous cleaning that was either guilt or simply restless energy with nowhere else to go. She thought about Arthur's

logic, which was sound, and about her own instinct, which was not the same thing as logic and which she had learned, over seventy-odd years, to trust about two-thirds of the time.

“I’m not saying he didn’t do it,” she said. “I’m saying we don’t know he did.”

“That’s fair,” Arthur said, in a tone that meant it wasn’t settled.

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Bernie excused himself to check something in the corridor — a pressure reading, a panel, whatever it was that Bernie checked when he needed to think with his hands instead of his mouth. On his way back through the dining car he passed Skye, who was standing near the service door with her phone raised, filming.

She wasn’t filming the storm.

The camera was angled down the Pullman corridor — the same corridor where Vance’s suite sat behind its double-locked doors, the same corridor where the maintenance panel hid behind its velvet curtain. Skye held the phone steady, professional, her face composed in the careful blankness of someone doing something they didn’t want interrupted. Then she noticed Bernie and the phone dropped to her side and she smiled — the bright, automatic smile she used for everything public.

“Getting some storm content,” she said. “The algorithm loves weather.”

Bernie nodded and kept walking. He didn’t mention it to Arthur or Hazel — not yet, not until he understood what he’d seen. But he’d seen it. The camera pointed where the camera shouldn’t have been, and the smile that arrived two seconds after the phone came down, and the trained stillness in her hands that had nothing to do with travel content and everything to do with the passage where a man had died.

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At four-seventeen, the train stopped.

It wasn’t gradual — or rather, the gradual part had been happening all afternoon, the slow deceleration that everyone had felt and no one had named, the engine working harder for less distance, the wheels finding less



purchase, the storm pressing down on the rails with a weight that was patient and cumulative and, by four-seventeen, decisive.

The final moment was a shudder. A low metallic groan through the undercarriage, the hiss of brakes engaging, and then stillness — not quiet, because the heating vents and the generators and the wind were still there, but the particular stillness of forward motion arrested, of a machine designed to move being told to stop. The floor was level and solid in a way it hadn't been for four days. The faint vibration that had lived in every surface since Chicago — the cups, the railings, the brass fittings, the reading lamps — went silent.

Snow began to accumulate on the windows that the train's movement had been clearing.

In the galley, Julian's hands found the counter and gripped it, and his expression was that of a man who badly wanted the train to move.

In her cabin, Elena's needles paused for four beats, then resumed.

In the observation car, Hazel and Arthur looked at each other across six feet of carpet and said nothing, because the silence had already said it.

The intercom clicked. A brief hiss of static, then Raymond's voice — even, measured, the voice of a man whose job was to make this sound manageable.

"Ladies and gentlemen, we've encountered weather conditions that require us to hold our position temporarily. Our crew is in contact with dispatch and we're monitoring the situation closely. We anticipate resuming travel within a few hours. In the meantime, dinner service will proceed on schedule at seven o'clock — Chef Julian tells me the lamb is worth the wait. If you need anything at all, please don't hesitate to ring for a steward. Thank you for your patience."

The intercom clicked off. The storm continued. The train sat in it, sealed and still, a gilt-and-mahogany box in a white field with no edges, and inside it a dead man's suite and a washed tray and a cup of chamomile tea that had come from nowhere and three retired Americans who had run out of reasons not to ask why.

## Chapter 17: The Decision

The kettle took its time. It always did — the heating element in my cabin ran on whatever modest voltage the train's generators considered appropriate for a single-berth passenger, and since the train had stopped moving four hours ago, even that modest voltage seemed to be having second thoughts. I filled it from the tap over the tiny sink, set it on its base, and waited, because waiting is what you do with kettles and with most things that matter.

Arthur was in the chair. He'd lowered himself into it with the controlled stiffness of knees that had been filing formal complaints for the better part of a decade, one hand on the armrest, the other braced against the fold-down table, and once he was seated he arranged his legs in front of him and didn't mention the process, which was how Arthur handled most of his physical limitations — by pretending they weren't happening.

Bernie sat on the edge of the berth, which put his knees about four inches from Arthur's. My cabin was not designed for meetings. It was designed for one person and a suitcase, and with three of us in it the air felt shared in a way that was intimate rather than uncomfortable, because we'd done this before — sat in this same configuration with tea and biscuits and the fold-down table between us like a headmistress's desk, and talked about a dead man.

The snow had stopped falling and started accumulating, which is a different thing. The window showed a flat gray-white nothing, and the glass was cold to the touch if you put your hand near it, which I'd stopped doing because my fingers were already complaining about the altitude and didn't need encouragement.

"Jim Oakes," Arthur said.

He said it flat, located — pointing at a place on a map he'd been carrying for thirty years. He wasn't looking at either of us. He was looking at the dark window, or at whatever the dark window was standing in for.

"Denver field office. U.S. Marshal. Good man — solid, not flashy. He bought me a beer once, after a conference in Colorado Springs. We sat at the bar and he told me the job wears you out in the places you can't see, and you don't notice until you try to stand up." Arthur paused. "Something close to

that. It was thirty years ago. It was the kind of thing you hear and nod at and carry around without knowing why.”

He shifted in the chair. His knees didn’t cooperate and he adjusted without acknowledging it.

“His daughter Sarah went into the canyon at Alder Creek. Five days a teacher.”

He stopped. Took a breath that was controlled and even and cost him something.

“You’ve heard the rest from me — Pinnacle’s cheap steel, the audits Vance overruled, the lawyers who made it all go away. What I didn’t tell you last time was what came after. I worked the edges of the investigation back then — it wasn’t my case, but it touched someone I knew. Jim retired two years later. I don’t think he ever bought anyone a beer again.”

The kettle wasn’t ready. The cabin was quiet except for the heating vent and the faint creak of the train settling into snow that wasn’t going anywhere.

Bernie opened his mouth. I saw it — the slight forward lean, the breath drawn for a sentence he’d already started constructing. Then he closed it, adjusted his spectacles with both hands, and reached for the biscuit tin. He took a biscuit and held it without eating it, turning it once between his fingers.

The moment passed. I poured the hot water — the kettle had finally managed it — and made three cups of Earl Grey, which required some negotiation with the fold-down table because three cups and a biscuit tin and Bernie’s elbow didn’t all fit, and someone’s tea had to go on the tiny shelf above the sink, and that someone was me because I was the one standing.

“I have a friend named Dorothy,” I said.

I told them. Not all of it — not the full shape of what I’d been carrying since that morning in the observation car when the snow erased the mountains and Dorothy arrived uninvited. I told them the parts that would make them understand.

Dorothy Tillman, art teacher, twenty-six years at Garfield Elementary. A quarter-acre garden on Poplar Street with a Japanese maple she'd planted the autumn after her husband Bill died. She'd driven forty minutes to a nursery in Bloomington because she wanted a specific variety, and the man there told her it would take ten years to reach its full shape, and Dorothy said, "Good. I'll have something to look forward to."

Arthur was watching me now. Bernie had stopped turning his biscuit.

"The pension fund collapsed in 2007," I said. "Vance Capital was in the papers and the lawsuits and the letters Dorothy showed me at her kitchen table with dirt still under her fingernails from the garden she was about to lose. She called me on a Tuesday. She said, 'Hazel, I have to sell the house.' Her voice was flat and dry and careful — past crying, past argument, just saying what was true."

I picked up my tea from the shelf above the sink. It was too hot, but I held it anyway because my hands wanted something to do.

"She's in an apartment now. Second floor, Maple Avenue. The balcony holds one plastic chair. She put a geranium out there in a terra-cotta pot and the first winter wind knocked it off the railing and it broke on the parking lot and she didn't replace it."

I drank my tea. It burned my tongue slightly and I didn't mind.

"This isn't abstract," I said. "Not for me."

Nobody spoke for a while. Arthur looked at the window. Bernie looked at his biscuit, and then ate it, and then brushed the crumbs off his trousers onto my floor, which under other circumstances I would have mentioned.

"I spoke to the Head Steward today," I said, because the silence had done its work and what came next needed to come while we were still in it. "About tea. He stocks Earl Grey, English Breakfast, and peppermint. That's the full selection. No chamomile. He said they've never carried it."

Arthur turned from the window. "Never?"

“Never. And Julian doesn’t have any in the galley — I checked that days ago. So the cup on that tray, the chamomile someone made and barely drank, didn’t come from anyone who’s supposed to make tea on this train.”

I let that sit. It sat.

“There are things,” Bernie said, and stopped. He took his spectacles off, held them up to the reading lamp as though checking for smudges, and put them back on. “In the data, sometimes — when the numbers don’t support a structure, when the load calculations aren’t —” He stopped again and looked at his hands. “What do we do about any of it? We’ve no authority. No lab, no badge, no jurisdiction.”

“No,” I said. “We don’t.” I looked at the biscuit tin, which had four biscuits left in it, and at Arthur’s knees arranged at their negotiated angle, and at Bernie’s notebook still tucked in his jacket pocket, and at the snow on the window that wasn’t going anywhere, and at the corridor outside my door where a dead man’s suite sat locked and unanswered.

“We’re not the police,” I said. “We’re not even particularly qualified. Arthur’s knees won’t let him chase anyone. Bernie’s primary weapon is a GPS tracker and strong feelings about atmospheric pressure. And I’m an old woman with a kettle and a biscuit tin that is, frankly, running out. But someone died in a way that doesn’t add up, and we’re sealed on this train with whatever the answer is, and nobody else is asking.”

Arthur nodded. Once. It meant the decision was made and everything after was details.

Bernie nodded too, but slower, carrying something he wasn’t ready to put down. I didn’t push. Pushing Bernie was like pushing a filing cabinet — it wouldn’t go where you wanted and you’d hurt your back.

They stood to leave. Arthur managed it in two stages, using the armrest. Bernie was already at the door when he stopped, his hand on the brass handle, half-turned back toward the cabin.

“Hazel, there’s something I should —” He looked at me, and then at Arthur’s back, and then at his own shoes. “We should meet tomorrow. After breakfast. Somewhere we won’t be overheard.”

“The observation car is usually empty early,” I said.

“Good. Yes. Early.” He opened the door and the corridor air came in, cooler than the cabin, smelling faintly of brass polish and the sealed-in staleness of a train that had stopped moving. “Good night, Hazel.”

“Good night, Bernie.”

The door closed. Arthur had already gone — I’d heard his careful, uneven steps moving toward his own cabin, each one a small negotiation with the floor.

I sat on the berth where Bernie had been sitting. It was still warm. The three cups were on the table and the shelf and the tiny sink’s edge where one had migrated during the conversation, and the crumbs were on the floor and the fold-down table, and the biscuit tin, when I picked it up and tilted it, held six lemon-zest biscuits and a scattering of crumbs that didn’t warrant counting.

Four biscuits. I’d need to do something about that. Julian’s galley had flour and butter — I’d seen them during my visit — and Julian understood what butter was for, even if Arthur currently thought he might have poisoned someone. I could ask about borrowing the oven. People let me into their kitchens. They always had.

The heating vent hummed. The snow pressed against the glass, pale and steady and going nowhere.

We were going to do this. Three people with bad knees and reading glasses and a dead man’s name that connected to a bridge and a garden and a girl who’d been a teacher for five days, and we were going to do this because it needed doing and because no one else would and because, in the end, that’s all the reason you need.

I turned off the reading lamp and let the snow make its own light.

## Chapter 18: Hazel's Social Errand

The kettle in Hazel's cabin had given up at some point during the night. She'd filled it from the tap, set it on its base, and pressed the switch, and the small red light had come on and then gone off again, twice, before settling into a faint orange glow that suggested effort without commitment. The heating element was working against whatever the generators were willing to provide, and the generators, since four-seventeen yesterday, had been willing to provide very little.

She unplugged the kettle, wrapped the cord around its base — two neat loops, the plug tucked under — and put on her cardigan. The gray one, with the deep pockets. She checked her phone was in the left pocket and her reading glasses in the right, and she stepped into the corridor.

The train was different without motion. Five days of constant vibration had made it invisible — the faint hum in the handrails, the rattle of brass fittings, the low harmonic that lived in the walls and floor and announced itself only by its absence. The corridor was still and cold. Snow had built up on the windward windows overnight, layered thick enough to block the lower panes entirely, and the light that came through the upper glass was flat and gray and directionless. The carpet, which had always seemed to absorb sound against the train's background noise, now produced it — each of Hazel's steps landing with a soft, distinct compression that could be heard two cars in either direction.

She passed the dining car. A steward was setting tables for breakfast — white linen, silver, the mechanical repetition of someone performing a task that no longer required thought. He looked up when she passed the doorway and she smiled at him and he smiled back, and that was all. The observation car beyond was empty. Its curved windows showed a white field with no horizon, the snow and the sky the same pale nothing, and somewhere underneath it the tracks and the mountains and whatever else had been there before the storm decided to stay.

She was looking for the Head Steward. The kettle, the hot water, the altitude and her stomach — she had the conversation prepared, the mild complaint with its reasonable request, and she moved through the service corridor

with the quiet purpose of a woman who belonged wherever she happened to be standing.

The service corridor was narrower than the passenger cars, the walls plain steel instead of mahogany, the floor bare metal with rubber matting. It smelled of coffee and cleaning solution and the faintly sour note of a space that was functional rather than decorative. She passed the galley entrance — closed, Julian's domain, quiet at this hour — and continued toward the rear of the car, where the corridor bent and a door stood ajar.

She stopped. Looked at the door. Looked back down the corridor. No one.

The room inside was small — a table bolted to the wall, four chairs, a coffee pot on a hot plate with an inch of dark liquid that had been sitting long enough to develop a skin. A notice board with crew schedules and a laminated card about emergency procedures. And against the far wall, between a fire extinguisher and a stack of folded blankets, a shelf of books.

Hazel stepped inside.

The books were what you'd find in any workplace where people waited between shifts — a few paperbacks with cracked spines, a large-format manual labeled *Starlight Express — Operating Procedures*, a first-aid handbook, and a slim hardcover she almost passed over. Navy blue, no dust jacket. Gold lettering on the spine: *Davis's Drug Guide for Nurses, 17th Edition*.

She pulled it from the shelf. It resisted slightly — not stuck, but sitting forward of the other books, not flush with their spines, as though someone had taken it out and replaced it without attending to the alignment.

She opened it and a scrap of yarn fell against her thumb.

Dove gray. Three inches long, cut clean at both ends. She held it between her fingers and turned it, and even under the crew lounge's fluorescent light, the color was unmistakable — the same dove gray she'd watched Elena's needles work through for five days, the honeycomb fill that had been growing steadily since Chicago, the yarn that Elena bought in skeins and cut with small silver scissors she kept in the pocket of her knitting bag.

The yarn had been marking a page. Hazel looked at it.



*Digoxin (Lanoxin). Cardiac glycoside. Therapeutic use: heart failure, atrial fibrillation. Toxic effects: nausea, vomiting, visual disturbances (blurred vision, yellow-green halos), cardiac arrhythmia (bradycardia, AV block, ventricular tachycardia). Note: Toxicity may be potentiated by hypokalemia, hypomagnesemia, hypoxia, or renal impairment. Early symptoms may mimic altitude sickness in high-elevation environments.*

She read the entry once, quickly, the way she'd read medication charts during her years in the delivery ward — scanning for the information that mattered, discarding what didn't. Then she read it again, slower, her index finger resting beside the line about hypoxia.

She set the book on the table, open to the page, and took her phone from her cardigan pocket. Two photographs — one of the full entry with the yarn bookmark visible at the margin, one close-up of the line about toxic effects. She checked both images, made sure the text was legible, and slid the phone back into her pocket. Then she replaced the yarn where it had been, closed the book, and returned it to the shelf — forward of the other spines, exactly as she'd found it.

She was looking at the coffee pot, her hands folded in front of her, when Skye came through the door.

The younger woman stopped. A beat of stillness — her weight on her back foot, her right hand holding a phone, her left touching the door frame. Her eyes went to Hazel and then to the shelf and then back to Hazel, and in the fraction of a second between those movements her expression rearranged itself from surprise to something pleasant and social and entirely prepared.

"Oh — Mrs. Finch. Hi." The bright voice, the one that came with the camera. "I didn't think anyone else was up."

"The kettle in my cabin has decided to retire," Hazel said. "I was looking for someone to complain to."

Skye laughed — a short, genuine sound that broke through the performance before the performance caught up with it. "The power situation is brutal. My phone charger keeps cutting out. I've been rationing battery like it's the apocalypse."

She moved past Hazel to the table and picked up a book that was lying face-down on the far chair — partially hidden by a folded blanket, easy to miss if you weren't looking. Hazel hadn't been looking, and she'd missed it. Skye tucked it under her arm with a casual motion, spine against her body, but not before Hazel saw the cover: dark blue, a technical diagram of something mechanical, and the words *Railway Climate Control Systems* above a smaller line of text she couldn't read from where she stood.

"Storm content," Skye said, catching Hazel's glance and gesturing vaguely with her phone. "Trying to find interesting angles. The infrastructure of a train like this — people love behind-the-scenes stuff."

"I imagine they do," Hazel said.

"The ventilation alone is, like, genuinely fascinating. These older Pullman rebuilds use a split-circuit pressurization setup — totally different from modern rolling stock." She said it fluently — quoting what she'd been reading, not what she'd always known — and then her mouth closed a fraction too quickly, as though the sentence had gone further than she'd intended.

"I wouldn't know the first thing about it," Hazel said. "I'm just hoping someone can boil water."

Skye smiled. The book stayed under her arm.

"Good luck with the kettle," she said, and sat down at the table, the book in her lap now, her phone open to something Hazel couldn't see. She'd settled in. She was comfortable here. The coffee pot, the folded blanket over the chair — this was a space she'd been using, and using often enough that the arrangement of it had become hers.

The Head Steward appeared in the doorway less than a minute later. He wore his uniform jacket buttoned to the throat despite the cold, and his clipboard was tucked under his arm, and his face when he saw Hazel registered mild surprise and professional courtesy in equal measure.

"Mrs. Finch. Can I help you find something?"

“The kettle in my cabin seems to be struggling,” Hazel said. “I wondered if there was something wrong with the power, or if it’s just decided it’s had enough of me.”

“The generators are running at reduced capacity — we’re conserving fuel until the plows arrive. I can have someone bring a thermal carafe of hot water to your cabin. Would that help?”

“That would be lovely. Thank you.”

He stepped aside to let her pass. As she moved through the doorway, she glanced back into the crew lounge — quickly, the way you check a room you’re leaving to make sure you haven’t forgotten anything. Skye sat at the table with the book open in front of her now, reading. The steward hadn’t addressed her, hadn’t looked at her, hadn’t adjusted his expression to account for a second passenger in a space where passengers weren’t expected. Skye turned a page.

Hazel walked back through the service corridor, past the galley, past the dining car where the same steward was now folding napkins into precise triangles. Her cardigan pockets held what they’d held when she left her cabin — phone, reading glasses — but the phone held two photographs it hadn’t held before, and the reading glasses had read a page they hadn’t read before, and somewhere behind her a scrap of dove-gray yarn sat inside a drug guide marking the entry for a medication that could stop a heart or mimic the stopping of breath at altitude, depending on which page you trusted and which question you were asking.

The corridor was cold. The snow on the windows had thickened since she’d passed through twenty minutes ago, or perhaps it only looked that way because she was paying attention now. She walked at the same unhurried pace she’d used on the way in — a woman returning from a failed errand about a kettle, carrying nothing visible, having found nothing worth mentioning to anyone she might pass in the corridor.

The thermal carafe was outside her cabin door when she arrived, set on a small tray with a cup and saucer and two packets of Earl Grey. The steward had been efficient. Hazel picked up the tray, unlocked her door, and went inside, and the corridor was empty again, and the snow kept falling, and

the train sat in it with its reduced generators and its sealed corridors and its crew lounge where two women had been reading books they shouldn't have been reading in a room where neither of them belonged.

## Chapter 19: The Observation Car

The observation car was empty, which was the point of arriving early. Bernie had suggested seven o'clock. Arthur had said six-thirty. I'd come down at six-fifteen because I wanted to choose my seat before either of them could arrange me, and because the corridor outside my cabin had developed a cold draught overnight that made staying in bed feel less like laziness and more like a principled position.

The curved windows showed nothing. For four days they'd been the reason people came to this car — the Rockies in afternoon light, the passes opening up, the kind of scenery that makes you understand why Frank had wanted to do this trip and also why he'd kept putting it off, because beautiful things can be exhausting when you feel obligated to appreciate them. Now the snow had covered the lower panes entirely and the upper glass gave onto flat gray, not quite white, not quite anything. The mountains were somewhere behind it. The brass along the window frames caught nothing.

I found a thermal carafe at the service station at the end of the car and poured myself a cup of Earl Grey. It was lukewarm, which is what happens to carafes that sit out since the night steward placed them, but lukewarm Earl Grey is still Earl Grey, and I wasn't in a position to complain.

Arthur arrived at six-twenty-five, which for Arthur was practically late. He lowered himself into the chair across from mine — hands on armrests, controlled descent, pause, legs arranged — and reached for the carafe without asking. I'd already set out a second cup.

"Bernie?" he said.

"Not yet."

We sat with our tea and the gray windows and didn't say anything, which is one of the things I appreciate about Arthur. He doesn't fill silences with noise.

Bernie arrived at six-thirty-two — two minutes late for his own suggestion — carrying his notebook and a pencil that he placed on the table beside his cup and then adjusted twice until it was parallel with the notebook's spine. He poured tea, frowned at the temperature, and drank it anyway.

“Right,” he said.

“I have photographs,” I said.

I took my phone from my cardigan pocket and showed them the two images from yesterday morning. The drug guide, open to the Digoxin entry. The dove-gray yarn sitting against the margin like a pressed flower in someone else’s book.

Arthur leaned forward.

I explained what they were looking at. The *Davis’s Drug Guide for Nurses*, on the crew lounge bookshelf, sitting forward of the other spines as though someone had taken it out and not quite put it back. The yarn bookmark — dove gray, cut clean at both ends, the same shade I’d been watching Elena knit for five days. And the page it marked.

“Digoxin,” I said. “Cardiac glycoside. The toxic effects include nausea, visual disturbances, and cardiac arrhythmia.” I’d taken a pharmacology module during my midwifery training — forty years ago, and I’d kept the broad shape of it — you remember what you learned when you were young enough to be frightened of getting it wrong. “There’s a line about hypoxia. Digoxin toxicity can mimic altitude sickness at high elevation. The symptoms overlap.”

Arthur studied the photograph. He held the phone close, tilting it toward the gray light from the windows, and his attention narrowed — not his eyes, his attention, the whole of it focusing down the way it had in the locked suite and at every crime scene he’d ever worked, I suspected.

“I want to talk to her again,” he said.

“I know you do.”

“Not to accuse. To ask.” He set the phone on the table, screen up, the yarn bookmark still visible. “There are questions she hasn’t answered because nobody’s asked them properly yet.”

I believed him. Arthur had spent thirty years asking questions for a living, and whatever technique a U.S. Marshal develops for re-interviews — I was fairly sure it involved asking the same thing seven different ways until the

answer moved or didn't — he could manage it without making accusations he couldn't support.

"There's more," I said.

I told them about Skye. The train systems manual she'd picked up from the chair she'd clearly been using as her own — the folded blanket, the settled-in comfort of a space she'd made hers. The title: *Railway Climate Control Systems*. She'd said "split-circuit pressurization setup" fluently, quoting what she'd been reading, and then her mouth had closed a beat too quickly.

"She said that?" Bernie sat up straighter. He took his spectacles off, which he does when information arrives faster than he can sort it, and put them back on. "I've been reading about Pullman conversions for a week and I only just learned what split-circuit means."

"She was quoting the book," I said. "Not showing off. She'd been studying."

Bernie looked at his notebook. Opened it to a page I couldn't see, ran his finger down something, and closed it.

"I saw her filming," he said.

Arthur and I waited.

"Before the train stopped. She was in the Pullman corridor with her phone up, and I thought she was recording the storm — everyone was, the snow was dramatic — but the camera was pointed down the corridor. Toward the suites. When she noticed me she dropped the phone and gave me that bright smile of hers and said something about camera angles."

"You didn't mention this," Arthur said. Not accusatory. Factual.

"I wasn't sure it meant anything. Lots of people film corridors." He paused. "Actually, I don't think lots of people film corridors. I was thinking about the pressure readings and I didn't want another variable until I'd sorted the ones I had."

That was honest, and it was Bernie. His mind worked in columns, and he preferred them orderly. An unexplained variable in someone else's column was an inconvenience he'd deal with later, and later had arrived.

So we had Skye with engineering vocabulary she shouldn't have, a train systems manual she was reading in a crew space she shouldn't have had access to, and a camera pointed at the corridor outside a dead man's suite. I laid it out flat. The trio worked best when the evidence sat on the table and we each picked up the pieces that fitted our hands.

"I want to get her talking," I said. "Not confronting. Talking. She's careful, but she lets things through when she forgets to perform."

Arthur nodded. He was looking at the window, or at where the window met nothing. After a moment he said, "The bridge." Quietly, as though he were testing whether the word still held.

It did. Last night's conversation sat with us in the cold observation car — Jim Oakes and his beer, Dorothy and her geranium, the bridge and the steel and the girl who'd been a teacher for five days. The snow had sealed us in with all of it.

Bernie adjusted his spectacles. "I should finish the ventilation circuit," he said. "The pressure data from the corridor panels — there are readings I haven't correlated yet. I'd like to compare them against altitude markers, if I can find gradient charts somewhere on this train."

It was a retreat, and I let him take it. Whatever the bridge was doing to Bernie, he hadn't shown us the whole of it yet. He'd tell us when he was ready, or he wouldn't, and I'd stopped expecting my patience to speed things along around the same time I'd stopped expecting it to work on kettles.

"The chamomile," I said, because someone needed to and the conversation had found a gap it fitted. "We know it's not in Julian's galley. We know it's not stocked on the train — the Head Steward was clear about that. Earl Grey, English Breakfast, peppermint. That's his full list. So someone brought their own chamomile aboard, and that someone made a cup of it and left it barely touched on a tray outside a dead man's suite."

"Crew or passenger," Arthur said.

"Crew or passenger. And I'm the one who notices what people drink."



I said it lightly, because it was true and because the alternative was saying it seriously, which would have made it sound as though I were volunteering for something dramatic rather than doing what I'd been doing since Chicago, which was watching.

Arthur took out a small notebook — not Bernie's kind with its graph paper and labelled columns, but a lined pocket pad with a leather cover that had spent years in coat pockets. He wrote something short.

"Assignments," he said.

We divided the work by temperament, not by rank. Arthur would re-interview Elena. Firm questions, no assertions — he'd push on the Digoxin, the knitting bag, the hotel story that neither of us had ever believed. If Miller was available, he'd come back to him too.

Bernie would finish the ventilation data. Complete the circuit map, correlate the pressure readings, find gradient charts if they existed somewhere on this stalled train.

I would work the human angles. Skye — get her talking, test the engineering knowledge, see what came loose. Julian — and here I mentioned the biscuits, because I had to, because the tin was down to four and a woman without biscuits is a woman without leverage on a train like this. Julian had flour and butter in his galley. Julian understood what butter was for. I could ask about borrowing his oven and be in his kitchen while I was at it.

"And the chamomile," Arthur said.

"And the chamomile."

The door at the far end of the car opened, and Raymond came through.

He was in uniform — jacket buttoned, cap straight — and he walked the length of the car checking window latches, running his hand along the frames with the unhurried attention of someone doing his morning rounds regardless of whether anyone was watching. He paused as he passed our table.

"Good morning. How are the knees, Mr. Kaine? I can have someone bring a cushion for the seat."

Arthur looked up, surprised. "I'll manage. Thank you."

"Mrs. Finch, shall I have a fresh carafe sent? That one looks like it's given up." He nodded toward the thermal pot, which had, in fact, given up.

"That would be lovely," I said. Bernie was writing in his notebook and didn't look up, which Raymond took in stride.

Raymond continued through the far door and the car was quiet again.

The men stood to leave. Arthur rose carefully — hands, armrests, pause, upright. Bernie gathered his notebook and pencil, adjusted the pencil once before sliding it into his jacket pocket, and followed Arthur toward the connecting door. I heard their voices in the corridor — Bernie saying something about barometric calibration, Arthur saying something short in reply — and then the door closed and I was alone.

The observation car curved overhead, all those windows designed for a view that wasn't there. The carafe was nearly empty. The flat light lay across the table and the chairs and my cold cup of tea and the phone with its photographs of yarn and medication.

Frank would have sat here. He would have taken the chair facing west, because Frank always wanted to see where he was going rather than where he'd been, which was sensible and also meant I always got the backwards-facing seat and spent the journey watching the scenery leave instead of arrive. He'd planned this route — not this train, not this trip, but the route itself, Chicago to San Francisco through the Rockies. He had a timetable he'd printed from some railway enthusiast's website, folded into quarters in the drawer of the hall table. I'd found it after he died and put it in my suitcase without looking at it too carefully, because looking at it carefully would have meant sitting down, and at that point I hadn't been ready to sit down.

I finished my tea. It was cold now, properly cold, and I drank it because waste is waste regardless of temperature.

Then I stood up, put my cup on the tray beside the carafe, and went to find Julian about his oven.

## Chapter 20: The Midpoint Turn

The intercom clicked twice before Raymond's voice came through — the small delay that meant he was choosing his words, not reading from a card.

“Good morning, ladies and gentlemen. We've been in contact with the regional dispatch office and I want to give you an honest update on our situation. The snowfall overnight has exceeded what the initial forecasts predicted, and the plowing crews are being redirected to a derailment north of Glenwood Springs. We're looking at a delay of twelve to twenty-four hours before we can expect clearance on the track ahead.”

A pause. The intercom hum holding the silence.

“All services will continue as normal — Chef Arceneaux is preparing lunch, and the observation car and dining car remain open. The generators are running well and we have ample fuel reserves. I'll update you as soon as I have more information. Thank you for your patience.”

The click that ended the announcement was precise. Raymond's announcements always were — measured, professional, the voice of a man who understood that what passengers needed during a delay was someone who sounded as though he'd managed delays before and expected to manage this one.

In the dining car, someone set down a coffee cup harder than necessary. A woman two tables from the window said “twenty-four hours” to the man beside her, and he said something about a connecting flight in Sacramento. A cabin door closed somewhere in the Pullman corridor. The train absorbed the news the way it absorbed everything — in small, private adjustments that didn't quite add up to a reaction.

The crew moved. Bernie watched them from his seat in the observation car, where he'd returned after breakfast to work through his pressure readings. Two stewards passed through heading forward, one carrying a clipboard, the other a toolbox. The Head Steward appeared briefly in the corridor junction, spoke to someone Bernie couldn't see, and disappeared toward the engine. Julian came out of the galley, wiped his hands on his apron, and went back in. Within ten minutes the forward half of the train was busy with systems checks and supply inventories, and the rear half

— the Pullman suites, the observation car, the quiet end where the paying passengers slept — was empty.

Arthur appeared at the far end of the observation car. He stood in the doorway for a moment, giving the room the brief, automatic sweep he gave every room he entered, and then walked toward Bernie with a pace that was unhurried but not casual. Hazel was behind him, cardigan buttoned, hands in her pockets.

“Now,” Arthur said.

Bernie closed his notebook.

They moved through the connecting corridor in single file — Arthur first, then Hazel, then Bernie. The Pullman corridor was cold and still. Snow had built up on the windward windows overnight, and the light that filtered through the upper panes was thin and gray and made the mahogany panelling look darker than it was. No one passed them. From somewhere forward, the muffled sound of crew activity — a generator panel being opened, someone calling out a reading.

Arthur stopped at the Golden Spike suite. The door was closed, sealed since the body had been removed to the rear baggage compartment the night Vance died — the storm doing the work a morgue would have. Two locks — a standard cabin latch and a spring-loaded deadbolt that the Head Steward had engaged with his master key afterward. Neither was extraordinary. Hotel hardware, upgraded to brass for the charter’s aesthetic but no more secure than what you’d find in any mid-range hotel corridor.

Arthur reached into his jacket pocket and produced a slim leather case, worn soft at the edges, no larger than a pen. He unrolled it on his palm. Two thin metal instruments, one with a slight bend at the tip.

He didn’t explain. Hazel watched the corridor behind them. Bernie watched Arthur’s hands. The first lock took perhaps twenty seconds — Arthur’s fingers working with the economy of someone who had done this enough times that the motion was not a skill but a habit, the way tying shoes is a habit, or turning a key. The deadbolt took longer. He adjusted the angle of

the bent tool, paused, adjusted again, and the mechanism gave with a soft, heavy click.

Arthur pushed the door open six inches and listened. Then he stepped inside.

The suite smelled stale. Not unpleasant — the ventilation system was still cycling air through the car — but the close, dead air of a room that had been sealed with no one living in it. The bed was unmade, sheets pulled back on one side, a dent still visible in the pillow. The curtains were drawn. Arthur pulled them open and the gray light from the snow-covered windows fell across the room without improving it.

Everything was as Vance had left it — or as the death had left it. A suit jacket draped over the desk chair. Reading glasses on the side table beside a water glass. The crystal decanter, and beside it the glass with its inch of whiskey, untouched. A pen on the writing desk. A leather document case beside the desk lamp, the kind with a brass clasp and an embossed monogram that had worn smooth from handling. A phone charger still plugged into the wall. At the base of the desk lamp, the pill organizer — white plastic, seven compartments, the PM slot for Wednesday still open. The room had been locked to preserve it, and preserving it meant preserving everything, including the faint impression of a man who had expected to come back to it.

Arthur went to the desk. He opened the document case and stood looking at what was inside.

“Files,” he said quietly. “A lot of files.”

Bernie came to stand beside him. The case held tabbed folders — eight or nine of them, each labeled in a small, mechanical hand that must have been Vance’s or his assistant’s. The tabs were color-coded. Some of the labels were company names. Some were project names. Some were single words — *Albuquerque*, *Eastman*, *Meridian* — that meant nothing to the people reading them and presumably meant a great deal to the man who had organized them.

One tab, near the middle, read *Alder Creek*.

Arthur pulled it.

The folder was thick — thirty or forty pages of mixed documents. Photocopied correspondence. Financial summaries on Pinnacle Materials letterhead. A newspaper clipping, yellowed and brittle at the edges, with a headline Bernie couldn't read from where he stood. Arthur set the folder on the desk and opened it, and they stood on either side of it, turning pages.

Bernie saw the letterhead first.

It was on the fourth or fifth page — a document he recognized not by reading it but by its shape — his own handwriting, unmistakable across a room or across thirty-two years. The layout. The column structure. The actuarial notation running down the left margin in a format he'd been trained to use and had used for forty years and could not mistake for anyone else's work.

His hands stopped moving.

The header read *Pinnacle Materials — Risk Assessment, Structural Steel Supply Contract, Alder Creek Bridge Project*. Below that, the date: *November 1993*. Below that, in the author field: *Bernard Pollard, FSA, MAAA*.

Bernie stood very still. Arthur had been reaching for the next page and his hand paused — not dramatically, just the small arrest of motion that happens when you notice someone beside you has changed. He looked at Bernie. Hazel, standing by the door, looked at Bernie.

The room was quiet. The generator hum from beneath the floor. The snow pressing against the windows. The stale air of a dead man's suite holding the silence of three people waiting for a fourth thing to happen.

Bernie picked up the report. Eight pages, stapled in the upper left corner, the staple rusted to an orange stain on the paper. He turned to the second page, where the summary table would be — where he knew the summary table would be, because he had built it, thirty-two years ago, in an office in Hartford with a calculator and a set of steel-grade specifications that hadn't matched the purchase orders.

"This is mine," he said.

Arthur waited.

“November 1993. Pinnacle Materials contracted us — my firm — to assess risk on the steel supply for the Alder Creek bridge. Routine, or it was supposed to be. The purchase orders specified A572 Grade 50 structural steel, which is standard for a span that length and load class. But the cost-per-ton figures were wrong. Too low. Twenty to twenty-five percent below market for the grade on the spec.”

He was speaking in the same flat, sequential register he used for pressure readings and panel data. His spectacles had slipped slightly and he did not push them back.

“I’m not a metallurgist. I couldn’t tell you what steel they actually supplied. But the costs didn’t match the specification, and if the reason was what the numbers suggested — a cheaper grade — then the safety margin dropped below threshold. I ran the calculations. Fatigue cycling, thermal expansion, a heavy load in poor weather — the numbers didn’t support a fifty-year service life. I wrote it up. Sent it to the client contact at Pinnacle. Followed up once by phone. The secretary said someone would call back.”

He set the report on the desk, on top of the open folder, and adjusted it so the edges were parallel with the folder’s edges. A small, precise gesture — Bernie’s hands finding order as they always did.

“Nobody called back. I moved on to the next file.”

The room held. Arthur stood with his hands at his sides. Hazel stood by the door with her hands in her cardigan pockets. The light from the windows didn’t move.

“The bridge collapsed in August 1994,” Bernie said. “Nine months later. I read about it in the Hartford Courant. Five dead, eleven injured. I recognized the project name.”

Arthur’s voice was quiet and careful. “You had reason to suspect that safety protocols had been ignored.”

“Yes.”

“And you reported that.”

“I reported it to the client. To Pinnacle. To the people who were supplying the steel.” Bernie took off his spectacles and cleaned them on his handkerchief, slowly, holding them up to the gray light to check for smudges he couldn’t possibly have seen. “I didn’t report it to the state. I didn’t report it to the bridge authority. I didn’t report it to anyone who wasn’t paying my firm’s invoice.”

He put his spectacles back on.

“I did what the contract required. I did not do what the numbers required.”

Hazel moved. Not toward Bernie — she stepped to the window and adjusted the curtain, a small domestic gesture that gave the room something to do other than hold what Bernie had just said. When she turned back, her expression was steady.

“You were barely forty,” she said. “You handed them a report and assumed they’d do something about it.” She paused. “It takes a few more years to learn that some people commission reports precisely so they can say a report was commissioned.”

Bernie looked at her. Something moved behind his spectacles — not relief, not quite, but the particular stillness of a man hearing his own history described by someone who understood it without having lived it.

Arthur looked at the report on the desk. His jaw worked once — the muscle tightening and releasing — and then he picked it up, turned it over, and set it back in the folder with the other documents. He closed the folder.

“Vance kept this,” Arthur said.

“Thirty-two years,” Bernie said.

“He kept everything.” Arthur gestured at the document case, the other folders, the color-coded tabs with their project names and city names and single words that meant someone, somewhere, had been useful to Sterling Vance and had generated paperwork worth keeping. “This is what he did. He collected the evidence that other people wanted to disappear. Your report told him the bridge would fail. He built it anyway, and he kept the proof that he knew.”



Bernie nodded. A small nod — chin down, back up — confirming a figure on a balance sheet.

Arthur began gathering the bridge folder's contents, squaring the pages, making sure nothing was out of order. He added two other documents that had been loose in the case — a photocopy of what looked like an insurance filing and a stapled list, several pages long, with names and dates in a columnar format. He didn't examine either one. He put them in the folder, closed the clasp, and tucked the folder under his arm.

"We photograph everything and return the originals," he said. "But not today."

"Not today," Hazel agreed.

They left the suite as they'd entered — Arthur first, checking the corridor, then Hazel, then Bernie. Arthur pulled the door closed. The deadbolt required only a firm push from outside — it seated itself with a click that sounded, in the empty corridor, like a period at the end of a sentence. The cabin latch he left unlocked. If someone checked, they would find one of two locks engaged, which was more plausible than both.

"So much for the locked room," Hazel said quietly, watching the bolt seat itself.

"It only ever locked out passengers," Arthur said. "A push on the way out. A master key on the way in. That door never proved what we thought it proved the night he died." He looked down the corridor toward the working cars, and didn't say the rest of it.

The corridor was still empty. The crew noise from the forward cars had settled into a steady background hum — the work of managing a stalled train in a snowstorm, which would continue for twelve to twenty-four hours or longer, and which had given three retired Americans exactly the window they needed to enter a dead man's room and find what a dead man had been keeping.

Arthur stood with the folder under his arm. Bernie adjusted his spectacles. Hazel had her hands in her cardigan pockets. The snow on the windows was the same flat white it had been for two days, and the mountains behind

it were invisible, and the train sat in its silence with its reduced generators and its sealed corridors and the space between the three of them that had just become a different shape.

Bernie said, "I should have told you sooner."

Arthur looked at him for a long moment. "You've told us now," he said. It was not absolution, and it was not accusation, but it was enough for the corridor they were standing in.

They walked back toward the observation car, single file, the folder under Arthur's arm, the train going nowhere around them.

## Chapter 21: The Galley

The carafes had been refilled overnight, which meant the night steward was still doing his rounds even though the train hadn't moved in two days and the passengers had largely retreated into the quiet self-pity that settles over people who paid a great deal of money and discovered that the money did not, in fact, purchase the weather.

I poured myself a cup and found it lukewarm. I drank it anyway. Frank used to say that complaining about tea you've already poured is just narrating your own mistake to an audience, which was rich coming from a man who once sent back a pot at a Holiday Inn because the water "hadn't been angry enough." He meant boiling. He always meant boiling. But he wouldn't say boiling because his mother had told him it was common to talk about cooking in public, and Frank carried his mother's opinions the way some men carry war wounds — visibly, permanently, and with a certain baffled pride.

Arthur arrived at six-twenty and lowered himself into his chair with the staged caution that pretended it wasn't staged. He took a coffee from the carafe, tried it, and set it down without comment, which from Arthur was a review.

"Photographs are done," he said. "Every page."

That was last night's work — Arthur in his cabin with the documents and his phone and thirty years of evidence photography that retirement hadn't touched. I nodded. The images were on his phone. We'd sort through them later.

Bernie came in at seven-fifteen carrying his notebook and two pencils, which was new — he usually brought one and fussed with it until it lined up with the notebook's edge. Two pencils suggested either ambition or contingency. He poured tea, sat down, and opened the notebook before he'd fully committed to the chair, which is a trick I've never managed and suspect requires not caring whether the furniture has agreed to hold you.

He looked different. Not dramatically — Bernie doesn't do dramatically. But yesterday he'd stood in a dead man's suite holding a thirty-two-year-old report with his name on it, and today he was working his ventilation

data with a focus I hadn't seen all week. Something had settled in him. I recognized it because I'd seen the same shift in women after labor — when the hard part is done and you can stop bracing for it, and the next thing, whatever it is, becomes possible.

Arthur said he was going to find Elena. He said it as though announcing a trip to the post office — practical, already decided, no input required. He had the yarn bookmark photographs and three decades of asking people questions they didn't want to answer. I felt briefly sorry for Elena, and then I remembered the knitting bag with its metallic object and the cover story that neither of us had ever believed, and the sympathy resettled into professional curiosity.

"Be kind," I said.

"I'm always kind," Arthur said, which wasn't entirely true but wasn't entirely false either, and I let it stand because arguing with Arthur about his interview technique is like telling the sea to be less wet. The sea isn't listening and you end up looking foolish for having said it.

He left. I finished my tea and sat for a moment. The snow outside hadn't changed. The mountains behind it were presumably still there. I took their presence on faith, which is not how I usually operate, but these were unusual circumstances.

In the corridor I passed Skye coming from the dining car, phone in one hand and a small leather notebook in the other. She gave me the bright automatic smile, and I gave her the warm nod, and neither of us stopped. Fine for now.

Raymond was at the junction between the Pullman car and the dining car, crouched beside a wall panel with a small torch and a clipboard.

"Morning, Mrs. Finch."

"Good morning, Raymond. Everything running?"

"Heating circuit. Routine check." He made a note, closed the panel, and stood up. "Generators are steady, but I like to verify when we're stationary this long."

“Very sensible,” I said, and continued toward the galley, and thought nothing more about it. A conductor checking his train’s heating during a snowstorm. It would have been odd if he hadn’t.

Julian’s galley was behind the swinging doors at the back of the dining car — the border between the passengers’ world of white linen and crystal glasses and the world where the food actually happened. I pushed through and found him at the steel counter with flour on his forearms and a look that suggested the flour had personally offended him.

“Mrs. Finch.” He looked up. He did not look delighted.

“I was wondering if I might borrow your oven for an hour.”

The offense shifted to bewilderment. I explained about the biscuits — the tin was down to three, and three biscuits is not a supply, it’s a countdown — and about the shortbread I’d been making since 1987. I could do it with my eyes closed, which I’d proved once during a power cut with nothing but a gas burner and a cast-iron skillet, and Frank had said that batch was the best I’d ever made. This tells you everything about Frank’s palate and nothing about my baking.

Julian looked at me the way a surgeon looks at someone requesting use of the operating theater for card tricks.

“You want to make... shortbread,” he said.

“Shortbread,” I confirmed. “Butter, flour, sugar. I’ll clean up after.”

“In my galley.”

“Unless you’d prefer I use the observation car’s service station, but I don’t think they have an oven.”

He didn’t smile, but something around his mouth decided not to commit to the frown it had been building. He gestured toward the far end of the counter.

“Oven’s there. Two-eighty for twenty minutes or you’ll dry them out. I’ll get your ingredients.”

This last part was self-defense. Julian clearly did not want me rummaging through his stores. He went to the walk-in and came back with a block of butter, a sack of flour, and a canister of sugar, setting them on the counter with the careful formality of a museum lending out a minor painting — items that remained his property and were expected back undamaged.

“Thank you,” I said. “You know, I once catered a church supper for ninety people with a broken oven and a hot plate.”

“A hot plate,” he said.

“It was a large hot plate.”

He turned back to his work — bread, I could see now. Real bread, kneaded dough on a floured board. The packaged stock must have run out. His hands moved with an ease that didn’t need to think about what it was doing, folding and pressing and turning, and I recognized the rhythm because my hands do the same thing with pastry and have done for longer than Julian has been alive. There’s a point where your body knows something your mind has stopped tracking, and that’s when the food gets good.

He was making bread because he had to. The fresh supplies were thinning — I could see it in the gaps on shelves that had been full four days ago, the substitutions a chef with standards would find wounding. Julian was improvising, and it was costing him.

But his stress was wrong. A chef with fewer eggs is annoyed. Julian was something else. He checked the clock above the pass-through twice in ten minutes, and once he pulled his phone from his apron pocket, looked at it, and put it back with a tightness around his jaw that had nothing to do with bread. Whatever he was waiting for hadn’t arrived, and the woman making shortbread three feet away wasn’t someone he could explain it to.

I didn’t ask. I measured my flour and cut my butter into cubes and didn’t ask, because asking is not what you do when someone is carrying something they haven’t offered to show you. You bake. You let the kitchen do what kitchens do, which is make people forget they’re being watched. Butter and flour and heat are older than suspicion and more persuasive than anything I could say.

We worked in parallel for a while. His bread rose under a cloth. My shortbread went in the oven. The galley warmed — real warmth, from a working oven on a cold train — and for a few minutes the murder and the bridge and the folder under Arthur’s bed were somewhere else, and this was just a kitchen with two people baking in it, which is all any kitchen really needs to be.

Julian said, without looking up from his dough, “I used to make bread with my grandmother in Houston. Saturday mornings. She had a cast-iron Dutch oven she’d carried from Baton Rouge when my grandfather got transferred, and she said the bread couldn’t taste right without the iron.”

“My mother-in-law said the same about her teapot,” I said. “Brown Betty. She claimed the tannin staining improved the flavor. Which was a polite way of saying she never cleaned it.”

He almost smiled. Then he checked his phone again, and the almost-smile went away.

The timer went off. I pulled the shortbread out and set the tray on a rack. Golden at the edges, pale in the center, the right crumble when I tested a corner. Frank would have eaten three before they’d cooled and burned the roof of his mouth and then complained as though the temperature were my fault, which was how Frank approached most consequences of his own impatience — with genuine surprise and a firm belief that someone else should have prevented it.

“Not bad,” Julian said, glancing at the tray.

From Julian, this was the Michelin Guide.

I cut the shortbread into fingers and packed them into my tin — the tin from a craft fair in Portland, Maine, 2003, which has never been empty for longer than it takes to make the next batch — and cleaned my section of counter. Flour wiped, butter wrapped, sugar returned. Julian watched me clean with visible relief that nothing had been damaged, which is a reaction I have spent most of my life producing in people who underestimate me.

“Thank you for the oven,” I said. “And the ingredients. I’ll replace the butter if we ever reach a town.”

“If we ever reach a town, I’ll need more than butter,” he said, and there was the real worry again — not about butter, not about eggs, not about bread. Something else entirely, something the snow was making worse.

I took my tin and left him to his kitchen and his phone that wasn’t ringing.

The corridor back was cold and still. The passengers had settled into a quiet resignation — not panic, not boredom, just patient waiting that happens on the second full day of not moving. A woman I didn’t recognize was reading in the dining car. The same woman, I think, who’d said “twenty-four hours” to her husband yesterday. She was on a different page now. Good for her.

I sat down in the observation car and opened the tin. The shortbread was still warm. I ate one slowly, because when you’ve just baked shortbread in a borrowed galley on a stalled train in the Rocky Mountains during a murder investigation, you eat the first one at whatever pace you like.

Arthur was with Elena. Bernie was with his panels. I had shortbread and observations and a conductor who checked his heating circuits and a chef whose worry didn’t match his kitchen.

The snow hadn’t changed. The train hadn’t moved. But the biscuits were very good, and Frank would have hated that he missed them.



## Chapter 22: The Interviews

Arthur found Elena in the library alcove at the rear of the observation car — a narrow booth with built-in bookshelves and reading lamps that the charter company had furnished with leather-bound classics no one had opened. She was knitting. The needles moved in the quick, tight rhythm he'd noticed the first time they'd spoken, and the pattern emerging from the yarn was dense and intricate and looked, to Arthur's untrained eye, slightly angry.

"Mrs. Voss," he said.

She looked up. Her hands didn't stop.

"Mr. Kaine."

He sat down across from her without being invited. It was a small assertion — too subtle for rudeness, but Elena, who had spent years managing the boundaries of a billionaire's household, understood it immediately. He was not asking for her time. He was taking it.

"I'd like to talk about the Digoxin," he said.

Her needles paused for one beat — a single missed stitch in the rhythm — and then resumed.

"We've discussed this."

"We've discussed the fact that a bottle is missing from Mr. Vance's medication case. You told me you left it in Chicago. I didn't believe you then, and I've learned some things since."

He took out his phone. He'd cropped the photograph so it showed only the relevant page — the drug guide open to the Digoxin toxicity entry, the dove-gray yarn laid across the text like a bookmark someone had placed with care. He turned the phone toward her and set it on the table between the knitting and the reading lamp.

Elena looked at it. Her face didn't collapse — but the careful composure she wore like a uniform shifted by a fraction. Still level. Not quite where it was.

"That's a nursing drug reference," she said. "Davis's. In the crew lounge."

“Yes.”

“And that’s my yarn.”

“Yes.”

She set her needles down. Slowly, precisely, crossed on top of the work in progress. Her hands went to her lap.

“I’m a nurse, Mr. Kaine. I read drug references. That’s not unusual. That’s professional habit.”

“The bookmark is at the Digoxin toxicity page. The drug that’s missing from your patient’s medication case. The patient who died.”

“Former patient,” she said. “I never worked for Mr. Vance in a professional capacity. I was his personal assistant, not his nurse.”

“But you managed his medications.”

“I organized them. There’s a difference.”

Arthur let the distinction sit. It meant something to Elena and would mean nothing to a jury, and both of them knew it.

“Mrs. Voss, I spent thirty-one years as a U.S. Marshal. I’ve sat across from a lot of people who had reasonable explanations for unreasonable evidence. Some of them were telling the truth. Most of them weren’t. I can’t make you talk to me — I have no badge, no warrant, and no authority on this train. But I have a photograph of your yarn marking the toxicity profile of a drug that vanished from a dead man’s case, and I have a dead man whose symptoms are consistent with that drug. Those facts don’t go away because you organized his pills instead of administering them.”

Elena’s jaw tightened. A muscle worked once beneath her cheekbone — not a flinch, but the visible effort of keeping something held in place.

“I was concerned,” she said quietly. “After he died. I wanted to understand what might have happened. So I looked it up. That’s all.”

“You were concerned after he died, so you researched the drug you’d already told me was left in Chicago.”

“Yes.”

“The drug that was never left in Chicago.”

She didn’t answer. Her hands stayed in her lap. Her eyes held steady, but Arthur had interviewed enough people to recognize steadiness that was maintained rather than natural. She was holding her face the way you hold a door against wind.

“You don’t have to talk to me,” he said. “But someone on this train has answers about what happened to Sterling Vance, and right now some evidence points at you. If there’s something I’m missing, this is a good time to tell me what it is.”

Elena picked up her needles. The motion was deliberate — a reclaiming of territory, her hands back in their competence, the aluminum clicking into rhythm.

“I’ve told you what I can tell you,” she said. “I was concerned. I looked it up. I don’t know what happened to Mr. Vance, and I don’t know where the Digoxin went. I’m sorry I can’t help you more.”

It was a locked door delivered with the courtesy of leaving the porch light on. Arthur recognized the technique. He’d used it himself, decades ago, on witnesses who couldn’t be compelled — the polite refusal that conceded nothing and invited nothing and left you standing on the mat with your questions in your hand.

He stood up.

“Thank you for your time, Mrs. Voss.”

“Elena,” she said, and then looked as though she hadn’t meant to.

Arthur nodded and left her to her knitting.

In the corridor he stood for a moment with his hands at his sides. She was scared — that was genuine, visible in the held jaw and the too-level eyes and the needles picked up like a shield. But she was lying about something specific: she knew exactly where the Digoxin had gone, and she wasn’t going to tell a retired lawman on a stalled train in the Rocky Mountains.

Not him. Maybe not anyone. But Arthur had been doing this long enough to know that the people who hold the hardest are sometimes the ones who need the right listener, not the right question.

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Miller opened the door in a pressed shirt with the sleeves rolled to the forearm, and his face showed something that might have been relief.

“Marshal Kaine. Come in.”

“Just Arthur.” He stepped inside. The cabin was one of the smallest on the train — a single berth with a fold-down desk and a narrow closet that held Vance’s spare shirts alongside Miller’s own, still pressed and buttoned, still waiting. A pair of Italian leather shoes — Vance’s, too small for Miller — sat polished on the closet floor. The desk held a paperback and a glass of water on a coaster, and the bed was made with hospital corners that would have passed inspection in any service branch Arthur could name. “I wanted to go over the evening one more time, if you don’t mind. Mr. Vance’s last day.”

“Of course.” Miller sat on the edge of the bed. Arthur took the desk chair. The small room put them close enough that Arthur could see the lines around Miller’s eyes and the careful way he held his hands — folded, waiting, still shaped by decades of receiving instructions.

“You mentioned last time that Mr. Vance took his evening medication around six. The pill organizer.”

“He liked to take them before dinner service. He said the Metoprolol made food taste flat, and he wanted it settled before Chef Arceneaux’s tasting plate arrived.”

“Did he take them with water?”

“Whiskey, usually. The Balvenie from the decanter. I tried to discourage it — the cardiologist had been explicit — but Mr. Vance’s relationship with medical advice was selective.”

Arthur almost smiled. “When he took the pills that evening, did he say anything? Any complaint, any reaction?”

Miller frowned. Not resistance — concentration. He was reaching back into a day that had ended in death, trying to separate the ordinary from the significant.

“I wasn’t in the suite — he wouldn’t have me there during file time. But it was always bitter, or off. Most evenings he’d look at the whiskey like it had personally insulted him and say something — ‘that’s not right,’ or close to it — and drink it anyway. Mr. Vance said things tasted wrong at least twice a week. The altitude, the water filtration, the ice — he had opinions about everything.”

“Bitter,” Arthur said. “Around six.”

“Approximately. The routine was the same every night. Chef came up around half five with the tasting plate, Mr. Vance sent him away — I’d see the chef leave from the corridor. Pills around six. Whiskey with the pills. Complaint after. He kept to it.”

Arthur noted the sequence. The chef’s visit at five-thirty — already established. Then the pills around six, the bitter aftertaste. A complaint at six o’clock, from Vance — who complained about everything — on a train at altitude where taste perception shifts with the thinning air. The medication hitting wrong. Something in the whiskey. Eleven thousand feet of elevation doing what elevation does to the human tongue. Three explanations, all plausible, none provable without a laboratory that didn’t exist on this train or anywhere within a hundred miles of it.

“After the complaint, was he different? Behavior, mood?”

“No.” Miller considered. “He went back to his desk. Didn’t ask for dinner. He ate when he felt like eating.”

“And the tasting plate — when the chef came up at five-thirty. Did Vance touch any of it?”

“He barely looked at it. Told the chef to take it away and ask the steward about cargo access. The chef took the plate back down. I heard Mr. Vance through the door, but I didn’t go in — short visit, two minutes at most.”

Arthur filed it. Vance waved off the tasting plate — Julian's food, untouched. A data point, though it depended on Miller's recollection and on no one having tampered with the plate in transit.

"How has the trip been for you?" Arthur asked. Not interrogation — conversation, the gear change that sometimes produced more than direct questions.

Miller looked at his hands. "I've been with Mr. Vance fourteen months. Before that, a family in Palm Beach — eleven years. Before that, hotel service in Boston. I've always worked for someone." He paused. "The train has stopped, and so has the thing I do. The stewards have been kind. They bring meals. But there isn't — I don't have a function here, Arthur. The cabin is clean, the shoes are polished, and no one needs any of it."

Arthur stood. "Thank you, Miller. You've been helpful."

"Have I?" Miller said, and it wasn't false modesty. It was a genuine question from a man who could no longer tell.

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The corridor was empty at both ends when Arthur found Hazel and Bernie in the observation car. He explained the plan in four sentences: suite, photographs, return the folder, ten minutes. Hazel put down her tea. Bernie closed his notebook.

They walked the Pullman corridor in single file. Hazel took position near the dining car junction, pausing at a window, adjusting her cardigan — in no hurry and going nowhere. Bernie stationed himself at the far end, near the crew corridor, where he could see anyone approaching from the forward cars.

Arthur picked the deadbolt faster this time. The muscle memory from two days ago was still fresh, and the cylinder gave on the first adjustment. He pushed the door open and stepped inside.

The suite was the same stale air, the same gray light through snow-crusted windows, the same preserved absence. But Arthur was different — he'd come here two days ago looking for documents, and now he was looking

at the room itself, the physical evidence that Elena's evasion and Miller's aftertaste had sharpened into questions.

The pill organizer sat on the desk, near the base of the lamp. White plastic, seven compartments, each divided AM and PM. Wednesday PM was open — the hinge up, the small compartment empty. A brown prescription bottle stood beside the organizer, its label turned away. Arthur turned it. Digoxin. 0.125 mg. Prescribed to Sterling Vance, filled by a concierge pharmacy in Lake Forest, Illinois. A travel supply — thirty tablets, and from the weight of it when he tilted the bottle, most of them still inside.

He set it down and stepped back to photograph the desk arrangement from two angles — organizer, bottle, lamp. The Digoxin was here, in Vance's suite, not missing from Elena's case the way he'd been assuming for six days. Vance had it. Vance had access to his own medication, his own dosing, his own whiskey to wash it down. That didn't clear Elena — she could have tampered with the bottle before it left her possession — but it rearranged the weight of the thing. The missing bottle wasn't missing. It had been at the dead man's elbow the whole time.

The crystal decanter stood at the desk's edge, and beside it the glass with its inch of amber whiskey, undisturbed since the day Vance died. Arthur pulled the stopper and held the decanter beneath his nose. Scotch — peat and honey and the warm bite of something expensive. Beneath it, nothing he could identify as wrong. But he wasn't a chemist, and whatever Miller's bitter aftertaste had been, it wasn't going to announce itself to a retired Marshal's nose six days after the fact. He replaced the stopper. The glass told him one thing the decanter couldn't: Vance had poured that last inch and never drunk it. Whatever had gone wrong in the man's mouth that evening, it hadn't come from the whiskey.

He opened the document case. The folders sat in their color-coded order — the careful filing of a man who kept receipts on everyone he'd damaged. Arthur slid the Alder Creek folder back into its position between *Albuquerque* and *Eastman*. The photocopied insurance filing went in next, then the casualty list, pages aligned, everything as it had been. He closed the brass clasp and set the case beside the desk lamp.

The suit jacket on the chair. The reading glasses on the side table. The phone charger still plugged into the wall outlet. Sterling Vance had expected to come back to all of this, and someone had made certain he wouldn't, and Arthur had interviewed the most likely suspect and the only witness and examined the physical evidence, and he had more than he'd started with but less than he needed. A yarn bookmark. A bitter aftertaste. A Digoxin bottle that wasn't missing after all — just sitting on a dead man's desk where the dead man had put it. And a room that held its remaining answers the way the snow held the mountains — present, invisible, unreachable.

He left the suite, pulled the door closed, and engaged the deadbolt with a firm push. The cabin latch he left unlocked, same as before.

In the corridor, Bernie caught his eye from the far end and gave a small nod — all clear. Then he held up one finger. Arthur waited.

Bernie walked toward him, unhurried. "Raymond came through a few minutes ago," he said quietly. "A woman from the rear Pullman — worried about the delay, asking about connections in Sacramento. He handled it. Told her he'd personally see to rebooking arrangements when they reached the next station with service." Bernie adjusted his spectacles. "She looked better when he left than when she'd found him."

Arthur nodded. "Let's go."

They collected Hazel from her window and walked back to the observation car. Arthur sat down heavily. Hazel poured tea from the carafe without asking whether he wanted it, which was her way of telling him he looked like he needed it. He drank. It was lukewarm.

"Elena's hiding something," he said. "She admitted the yarn was hers. Said she researched the drug after Vance died because she was concerned. Didn't explain the missing bottle. Didn't explain much of anything."

Hazel was quiet for a moment. "Did she seem frightened?"

"Yes."

"Of you?"

Arthur considered. "Of what I might find out. Which isn't the same thing."



Bernie had his notebook open. “And Miller?”

“Vance complained about a bitter taste around six o’clock. After the tasting plate. After the pills. Could be the medication, could be the whiskey, could be the altitude.” Arthur set down the tea. “Could be nothing. Vance complained about everything.”

“The food?”

“Miller says Vance waved it off. Didn’t touch the plate. Sent it back to the galley.”

Bernie wrote something in his notebook — a time, a fact, a figure that would find its column. Hazel looked out the window at the snow that hadn’t changed.

“I returned the folder,” Arthur said. “Photographed the pill organizer, the decanter, and a prescription bottle — all on the desk.” He paused. “Digoxin. Vance’s name on the label. Travel supply from a concierge pharmacy. It wasn’t missing — it was in his room the whole time.”

Hazel set her cup down. Bernie’s pencil stopped.

“Elena’s been terrified about a bottle that was sitting six feet from the body,” Arthur said. “That doesn’t clear her. But it changes things.”

Nobody asked if he’d found anything useful. Arthur had spent the morning doing what he knew how to do — interviews, evidence, the careful procedural work of thirty-one years — and he’d come back with more information and less certainty, which was, in his experience, how an investigation felt in the days before it broke open or didn’t.

The train sat in its snow. The mountains were somewhere behind the white. Arthur drank his lukewarm tea and didn’t complain about it, which Hazel noticed, and which told her more about his morning than anything he’d said.

## Chapter 23: The Clinic

My cabin had settled, by Day 6, into something that resembled home. Suitcase open on the luggage stand, cardigan on the hook behind the door, tin on the shelf beside the reading lamp where I could reach it without getting up. I'd moved the complimentary toiletries into the drawer to make room for my own things, which is what I do in every hotel within the first hour, because hotel soap smells like optimism and my soap smells like soap, and I know which one I trust.

Frank called it nesting. He made it sound like a mild condition — somewhere between a hobby and a compulsion — but he was no different, only with different materials. His nightstand required a glass of water, his reading glasses, and whatever he was pretending to read that week. If any of those items were displaced he'd stand there looking at the empty space as though it had personally failed him. Six years later I still keep my water glass on the left, which is my side, and his side is still his side, because some arrangements outlast the person who required them.

I was eating shortbread — the batch from Julian's oven, still good on the second day — when the knock came.

It was a small knock. Controlled. Not Arthur's single firm rap that assumed you were already on your feet, or Bernie's double-tap that always sounded slightly apologetic. This was careful, deliberate, and almost hadn't happened.

I opened the door.

Elena Voss stood in the corridor in a gray cardigan buttoned to the throat. Behind her, at the far end of the Pullman car, Raymond passed beneath the corridor lamp — a nod in my direction, his clipboard under one arm, gone.

"Mrs. Finch," Elena said. "May I come in?"

She wasn't smiling. She wasn't performing anything. Her face had the settled look of a decision already made, and I recognized it because I had seen it hundreds of times in labor rooms — the moment when a woman stops fighting the contraction and lets it happen.

"Of course, dear. Sit down."

She sat on the edge of the berth. I took the desk chair and offered her the tin. She looked at the shortbread as though it were a small, unexpected kindness she hadn't budgeted for, and took a piece, and held it without eating.

"Would you like tea? The carafe is —"

"No. Thank you." She turned the shortbread over in her fingers. "I need to tell you something. I should have told someone days ago, and I chose the wrong person this morning, so I'm choosing again."

Arthur. The wrong person was Arthur.

I waited. Waiting is the hardest part of listening and the part most people skip, because silence feels like an invitation that needs to be filled. It doesn't. It needs to be left alone until the other person is ready.

Elena set the shortbread on the shelf beside the tin. She reached for the knitting bag at her feet — the bag she carried everywhere, the one with the metallic weight I'd felt the first time we'd spoken — and opened it.

She took out the bottles one at a time. Five of them. Brown plastic with white caps, hospital pharmacy labels, each with a name I recognized. Atorvastatin. Amlodipine. Metoprolol. Rivaroxaban. Tamsulosin. Brand names, not generics — the expensive versions that Vance's insurance covered without question. I knew the packaging because I'd handled medications for forty years, and these were not drugstore stock. These were prescribed, dispensed, and worth more per bottle than most people spend on groceries in a week.

Elena lined them on the shelf beside my shortbread tin. Five bottles, neatly spaced, labels facing forward. Even confessing, she organized.

"There's a clinic on Gratiot," she said. "East side of Detroit. It operates out of a converted storefront — the waiting room used to be a nail salon. They see eighty patients a day and they can't afford half the medications they prescribe."

She stopped. I didn't fill the silence.

“I’ve been sending them Mr. Vance’s medications for eleven months. Skimming refills — an extra bottle here, a duplicate authorization there. His prescriptions were automatic. Nobody counted.”

“The Digoxin,” I said.

Her jaw tightened. “Mr. Vance had two supplies. His concierge doctor kept refills running — a bottle at home, a travel bottle for trips. I shipped the home supply to the clinic six weeks ago.” She paused. “It’s a cardiac glycoside. The clinic was short. They’re always short.”

“And the travel bottle?”

“I packed it in the medication case for this trip. But Mr. Vance —” She stopped. Started again, steadier. “He didn’t like waiting for me to bring his pills. He must have gone through my case while I was setting up his afternoon vitals — I didn’t know until the morning after he died, when I checked and the bottle was gone. He took it and put it in his suite. He did that. And all I could think was — what else did he see in there?” She stopped. Started again, steadier. “I found the gap and I thought —”

She looked at the bottles on the shelf, not at me.

“I thought someone had taken it. Both bottles gone — one in Detroit, one vanished from my case. And now a man is dead of something that looks like his heart stopped, and I’m the person who managed his pills and lied about where they went. I didn’t kill him, Mrs. Finch. I stole his medications and sent them to people who needed them, and I cannot prove the difference.”

There it was. The thing she’d been holding since the first dinner, since the gap in the medication case, since Arthur sat across from her with the photograph she couldn’t explain. Not murder. Theft. The small, illegal, ordinary kind — driven not by greed but by the frustration of watching a man who could afford everything waste what other people couldn’t get at all.

I believed her.

Not because the story was tidy or the evidence was conclusive. I believed her because I’d spent forty years sitting with women in the worst moments of their lives, and I had learned — slowly, imperfectly, with exceptions that

still kept me humble — to hear the difference between a lie and a truth that cost more than it should. Elena Voss was telling me the truth. Her fear was not the fear of being caught. It was the fear of being mistaken for something worse than what she was.

I could be wrong. There was Carol Fenton, who I'd been certain was honest about her husband and who had, it turned out, been lying with a composure that still impressed me twenty years later. I carry Carol Fenton the way other women carry cautionary tales about recipes — a reminder that conviction is not the same as accuracy.

But this wasn't Carol Fenton.

"The yarn," I said. "In the drug guide. The Digoxin page."

"I wanted to know if it could have been — if what I took could have —" She stopped. Started again, steadier. "After he died. I needed to understand whether the missing Digoxin could have been involved. Whether I'd given someone the means without knowing."

"And?"

"The symptoms overlap with altitude sickness. I couldn't rule it out. I couldn't confirm it either. I'm a nurse, not a pathologist."

She stood up. The bottles remained on the shelf. She looked at them and then at me, and I understood that she was leaving them — not as evidence, but as proof that she had come here with nothing held back. The bag was open. The shelf was full. There was nothing left inside the knitting but the knitting.

"Thank you for listening," she said.

"Take a shortbread for the corridor," I said. She took one. She ate it on the way to the door, which was the first time I'd seen Elena Voss do anything without thinking about it first.

I watched her go down the corridor — smaller than when she'd arrived, but lighter. The bottles sat on my shelf between my tin and the reading lamp. I left them there.

Arthur and Bernie were in the observation car. Arthur had his legs stretched out, which meant his knees had been at him all day, and Bernie had his notebook open to a page with two columns and a question mark drawn in the margin.

I told them.

I told them about the knock and the bottles and Gratiot Avenue and the clinic that sees eighty patients out of a converted nail salon. I told them about the Digoxin — two bottles, the home supply shipped to Detroit six weeks ago, the travel bottle that Vance took from Elena's case himself. I told them Elena had sat on my berth and laid out five bottles and told me the truth, and that I believed her.

Arthur listened without interrupting. When I finished, he sat forward and put his hands on his knees.

"The desk," he said. "The Digoxin bottle I found in the suite — travel supply, Vance's name, concierge pharmacy. She's saying he took it from her case himself."

"That's consistent with what you found," I said. "Right where she said he'd put it."

"It's consistent." He was quiet for a moment. "Five bottles on a shelf and a sixth in a dead man's suite. Her story fits the evidence. But I can't verify the home supply went to Detroit instead of somewhere closer, and fitting isn't the same as confirmed." He held up a hand before I could respond. "I'm not saying she's lying. I'm saying that a sympathetic explanation is not the same as evidence."

"I've sat with women in crisis for forty years, Arthur. I know what a real confession sounds like."

"I know you do."

He said it without condescension. He meant it. And he wasn't going to move, because Arthur's positions weren't built on stubbornness — they were built on thirty-one years of sorting true confessions from convincing ones, and the sorting required more than instinct.

Bernie turned his pencil end over end. “The bottles are consistent with her story. They don’t prove it.” He looked at both of us over the rims of his spectacles. “But if the home supply was shipped six weeks ago, and Vance died this week, the chain of custody is very long. Difficult to administer something you mailed to Michigan a month and a half before the opportunity presented itself. And the travel bottle — if that’s what’s on the desk — was in Vance’s suite, not Elena’s possession.”

Arthur considered this. A concession, not to Elena’s innocence, but to the geometry of the thing.

“We don’t drop it,” he said. “Not yet. But we look elsewhere.”

“Skye,” I said.

Arthur nodded. Bernie wrote something in his notebook.

I went back to my cabin and sat on the berth where Elena had sat. The bottles were still on the shelf, labels facing forward in their tidy line. Five medications bound for a clinic in Detroit, a sixth already shipped, and a travel bottle sitting on a dead man’s desk because he didn’t like waiting for his nurse. An investigation that had just lost its strongest suspect.

I closed the shortbread tin. I turned off the reading lamp and sat in the dark, listening to the generator and the wind and the quiet of a train that wasn’t going anywhere. I was certain about Elena and I was respectful of Arthur’s doubt, and I held both at once, because that is how you do this work. You believe what you believe, and you leave room for being wrong, and you get up in the morning and keep asking.

## Chapter 24: The Card

The crew lounge was quiet at six in the morning. Breakfast service had pulled the stewards forward to the dining car, and Skye had the room to herself — the narrow table, the reading lamp, the wool blanket she'd draped over the chair back her first week aboard and that no one had moved since. She sat cross-legged in fleece and thermal leggings, her hair pulled back with a pencil, and spread the maintenance log across the table beside the schematics she'd photographed and printed on the train's small business-center printer three days ago.

She'd been at this for ninety minutes. The log was a bound ledger — handwritten, which surprised her, though it shouldn't have on a train that polished its brass fittings like museum pieces. Inspection dates, component codes, notes in three different hands. She cross-referenced each entry against the schematics, matching panel numbers to corridor locations, marking the ones that controlled airflow to the Pullman suites.

This was the work. Not the hashtags, not the golden-hour selfies at the observation car windows, not the breathless captions about #TrainLife and #RockyMountainVibes that she posted to an account with forty thousand followers she'd assembled in eight months from nothing. The account was a tool. The persona was a door. Skye Tanaka was an investigative journalist, and she'd been building a case against Sterling Vance for three years before she set foot on this train.

Vance had banned press from the charter — no credentials, no exceptions, no appeals. His lawyers had made that clear to every outlet that applied. So Skye had become someone who wouldn't need credentials. An influencer. A content creator. A young woman with a good camera and an eagerness to tag the charter company in exchange for a complimentary suite. The booking agent hadn't asked for references. She'd asked for Skye's follower count.

Three years. The story had started as a master's thesis — corporate negligence in American infrastructure, the cost of cutting corners on materials that were supposed to hold weight — and had become the thing she couldn't set down. Vance Capital. Pinnacle Materials. The substandard steel that saved eleven cents a pound and killed the people who trusted it. The Alder



Creek bridge collapse, 1994. The sealed settlements. The investigative files that went nowhere. The lawyers who buried what the steel couldn't.

Her father's name on the casualty list.

Kenji Tanaka. Ironworker, Local 433. She'd never met him. Her mother had been five months pregnant when the bridge went down, and Skye was born into the quiet that followed — the settlement check that arrived without explanation, the sealed records, the way a family reshapes itself around an absence it can't discuss. She grew up in a house in Fresno where the bridge was the thing her mother didn't mention until the year Skye turned twelve and asked.

Her mother had told her one thing about the last morning. Skye had carried it since.

*He left before five. I heard him making coffee in the dark, and I almost got up, but you made me so tired, even before you were born. When I came downstairs the mug was in the sink and his boots were gone from the mat.*

His boots were gone from the mat. Skye had spent ten years in journalism — local papers, the Republic, two years at ProPublica on an infrastructure beat — and no sentence she'd written landed as hard as her mother's voice saying that.

She closed the maintenance log and checked her schematic notes on the laptop. Panel 5 — the one nearest the Golden Spike suite. She'd mapped it, photographed it from the corridor, noted where the dust was missing. She'd come aboard to document Vance's history for a long-form piece, and then Vance had died, and the story had changed shape beneath her hands. Not just corporate history anymore. Something had happened on this train, and the official explanation — altitude sickness — didn't account for the wilted orchid, or the nurse's face when they opened the suite, or the retired lawyer who'd started asking questions before the body was cold.

She hadn't approached them. Three retirees working an investigation — she'd watched them from across the observation car, assessing. The big man with the bad knees, flat-voiced, authoritative — former law enforcement, or Skye had never profiled one. The smaller man with the notebook and spec-

tacles who measured everything twice. The woman in the cardigan who sat quietly with her shortbread and missed nothing. They were working the same problem from a different angle, with different instincts. Skye had considered making contact and decided against it. Her cover couldn't survive a direct conversation with people that observant.

She saved her notes and closed the laptop. Enough for this morning. The stewards would cycle back through soon, and she didn't need someone glancing at ventilation schematics on a screen that should have been showing Instagram.

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The corridor from the crew quarters to the rear Pullman ran past the galley. Skye walked it at her usual pace — phone in hand, head tilted toward the screen, the automatic posture of someone on her way to photograph something. It had become second nature, the performance that was also camouflage: nobody interrupted a woman looking at her phone.

She glanced through the galley doorway as she passed. Julian stood at the service counter with his phone held toward the frosted window, arm raised, searching for a signal that hadn't existed in three days. His other hand rested on the counter beside a prep tray he hadn't touched. He wasn't cooking. He wasn't prepping. He was waiting for something that had nothing to do with bread dough or breakfast service, and the set of his jaw said the waiting had gone on too long.

Skye kept walking. She'd clocked Julian's off-hours pattern in her first week — the cargo hold visits, the restless clock-checking, the anxiety that spiked whenever the train stopped. She'd noted it. Whatever Julian Arceneaux was doing, she hadn't figured it out yet, and she had enough threads to follow without adding his.

Footsteps behind her. She moved to the wall to let Raymond through — the conductor with a small flashlight in one hand, his clipboard held against his chest, moving through his train with the unhurried ease of a man tending his own property.

"Morning," he said.

“Morning.” He was already past her, pausing at a junction box where the Pullman met the galley passage, checking something with the flashlight, making a note on his clipboard. Skye didn’t look back.

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Her cabin was at the far end of the rear Pullman — the smallest suite on the train, which had suited the booking agent’s idea of what an influencer deserved and suited Skye’s need to be at the periphery, close to the crew passage, away from the social pressure of the main carriages. She opened the door and stepped inside.

Nothing was displaced. The berth was made — she’d done it herself that morning, a habit from years of motel-room reporting where housekeeping meant questions. Her bag sat on the luggage rack, zipped. The toiletries lined the narrow shelf. Her laptop sat on the fold-down table where she’d left it, lid closed.

She opened the laptop and saw the slot.

The 256-gigabyte micro-SD card she’d left in the reader was gone. She’d pulled it from her phone last night to edit footage — the corridor clips, the ventilation panel close-ups, the timestamped sequences she’d been assembling into a visual timeline. She’d left the card in the laptop’s slot when she went to sleep, the way she always did when she had more editing to do in the morning.

The slot was empty. Nothing else had been touched — not the laptop, not her notebooks on the shelf above, not the lavalier mic or the spare battery in the side pocket of her bag. Just the card. Neat. Deliberate.

Before the stall, she’d been uploading to cloud storage every evening — the charter’s satellite Wi-Fi had been decent, one of the few genuine perks of the influencer cover. But the snowstorm had killed the signal on Day 4, and everything after that had existed on the card and only the card. Three days of footage. The corridor surveillance — timestamped clips of Elena near the suite entrance, Julian leaving the galley after hours, the ventilation panel that someone had been adjusting. Gone.

She sat on the berth. For a few seconds she didn’t move.

The corridor clips were the closest she'd come in three years to real-time documentation — the people around Vance in his final hours, their movements and patterns and the small betrayals of schedule and habit that print journalism couldn't capture. She'd been building the visual architecture for a story her mother had started telling her in a kitchen in Fresno, and someone had walked into her cabin while she was cross-referencing maintenance logs and pulled the whole thing out.

*His boots were gone from the mat.*

The generator hummed beneath the floor. Frost on the window had thickened overnight into fern-like patterns, backlit by gray morning light. Somewhere forward, a door opened and closed, and voices carried — a brief, strained exchange between passengers, the forced civility of people who had been sharing a train for a week and had run out of things to say to each other.

Skye opened the laptop. The pre-stall uploads were there — she clicked through the folder structure, her breathing evening out as each file loaded. Background footage from the first three days. The initial train walkthrough she'd shot for "content" that was actually a systematic survey of corridor layout and door positions. Early clips of Vance at dinner, of Elena organizing the medication case on the first evening, of the observation car at sunset with passengers she'd identified and catalogued. Research material from before the trip — interviews with an engineer who'd studied retrofit pressurization, a retired NTSB inspector who'd worked the Alder Creek investigation, a bridge historian in Denver. All there. All intact.

The post-stall footage was gone. And whoever had taken the card had told her something useful: someone on this train knew she was filming things a travel influencer had no reason to film. They might not know she was a journalist. But they knew she was watching, and they'd decided to stop it.

Skye closed the laptop. She picked up the phone, opened the camera, and checked the internal storage. Twelve gigabytes free. Not much. Enough for short clips, careful framing, nothing wasted. She'd started at the Tucson *Star* with a thirty-dollar digital recorder and a spiral notebook, and she'd broken stories with less.

She photographed the empty card slot on the laptop — documentation, timestamped — and slid the phone into her jacket pocket. She put on her puffer vest, checked her reflection briefly, and opened the cabin door.

The corridor was empty. From the dining car she could hear the muffled sounds of breakfast service — silverware, murmured conversation, the small organized rhythms of people holding to routine because routine was the last thing that still felt controllable. She closed the door behind her and walked toward the observation car, where the light was best and the windows ran floor to ceiling.

Skye lifted the phone and framed a shot of the frost on the window beside her — ice crystals catching the first real light of morning. Good content. The kind of thing an influencer would post.

She took the shot and kept walking.

## Chapter 25: Afternoon Tea

The biscuit tin was getting light. I noticed it when I picked it up from the shelf — that telltale shift when a container is more empty than full. Two batches since Chicago, the lemon zest from home and the shortbread from Julian’s galley, and both were thinning out. Seven days of offering biscuits to strangers and suspects and one nurse who needed them more than she knew.

Frank used to say I could extract a confession from a stone wall if I brought the right biscuits. He meant it as a complaint, which was rich coming from a man who once spent forty-five minutes trying to open a jar of marmalade before asking me to do it.

Arthur had laid out the case that morning, counting points on his fingers. Skye Tanaka: technical vocabulary no travel influencer should possess — “pneumatic retrofit,” “split-circuit pressurization,” terms from engineering manuals, not Instagram captions. Caught filming the Pullman corridor before Vance’s death, not the scenery. Regular access to the crew lounge, where she’d been reading a railway climate control manual and quoted from it until she noticed me listening. The Head Steward tolerated her presence without comment. And the corridor footage — her camera pointed at the Pullman corridor outside Vance’s suite at 18:38, before he died. Not the scenery. Not the dining car. The corridor.

“She knows too much about this train,” Arthur had said.

Bernie had agreed. Her vocabulary wasn’t surface knowledge — she’d come aboard already understanding how pressurization worked.

I was assigned the social approach, which suited me. Arthur would have sat her down with photographs and a flat voice, and she’d have shut like a clam. Nobody shuts down over shortbread.

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I found her in the observation car after lunch. She was in a window seat on the east side, phone in hand, photographing the frost on the glass with practiced attention — professional framing, careful angles. The afternoon light caught the ice and made it glow.

The car was half-empty. A few passengers in the far section reading or staring at mountains they'd been staring at for three days, the same peaks in the same snow. A couple near the back were having one of those low, tight conversations that happen when people have been in each other's company too long and haven't decided whether to be honest about it. The generator hummed beneath the floor. Condensation had crept down the inside of the windows, pooling along the brass frames, and someone had wiped one pane with a napkin, which had made it worse.

I sat two seats from Skye — close enough to talk, not close enough to impose — and set the tin on the armrest between us.

"Shortbread? I've got more than I can eat, and they won't keep in this damp."

She looked up. Quick eyes, intelligent, a bit guarded — always sorting what she took in before deciding what to show. She smiled. It was a good smile, practiced but not empty, and she took a biscuit with easy grace.

"Thank you, Mrs. Finch."

She knew my name. On a stalled train with thirty passengers and nowhere to go, everyone knows everyone by the end of the first week, whether they want to or not.

"How are you managing?" I said. "A week is a long time to be stuck, let alone without decent tea."

"The carafes are not great," she said, with a half-smile.

"They're dreadful. Tea should be made, not stored. The moment you pour it into a thermal carafe it starts dying, and by the time it reaches you it's the temperature of bathwater and tastes about the same."

She laughed — short and real and slightly surprised — and I liked her for it, which is a habit I should know better about by now.

"The heating isn't helping either," I said. "My cabin was comfortable enough the first few days, but since we stopped it's been getting colder."

"It's the system," she said. She bit into the shortbread. "When the train's moving, the main engine generates excess heat that feeds the boilers. Stationary, you're on the auxiliary generator, which doesn't have the same

capacity. The corridors lose heat first — distribution drops off at the extremities.”

She said it easily, naturally, the way you explain something you’ve understood for a while and forgotten isn’t common knowledge. Then I saw the small correction — not dramatic, just a half-beat where she heard herself.

“I read it on one of those plaques,” she added. “Near the galley, I think. They have information panels about the train’s history.”

I’d seen the plaques. They discussed the mahogany woodwork and the original 1947 route. Not heating distribution systems.

“Fascinating,” I said, and I meant it, although not as she supposed. “I had no idea it was so complicated. And the altitude doesn’t help, I expect?”

“Not really. Pressurization at this elevation — these older Pullman retrofits weren’t designed for extended stops at ten thousand feet. The system maintains, but it struggles.”

I took a sip of my thermal tea and let the silence sit for a moment. Outside, the mountains held still. They had been holding still for three days, and the patience of them was starting to feel aimed at us specifically.

“Arthur says we’re quite near Alder Creek gorge,” I said. “He thinks the views would be spectacular if we could see anything through all this white.”

Skye’s hand stopped. A beat, maybe less. The shortbread held still between her fingers, and her eyes went somewhere that had nothing to do with this car or this conversation or the frost on the windows. Then she was back, and the smile was back, and her hand moved again.

“I’ve heard it’s beautiful,” she said. “The canyon walls, the old rail bridge. One of the most photographed spots on the western routes.”

“You’ll have to come back when the weather cooperates,” I said. “Get some proper footage for your feed.”

“Definitely.”

She ate the rest of the shortbread. Raymond came through the far end of the car and paused to check a window latch, exchanging a word with the



couple about extra blankets — his voice warm and unhurried. Skye glanced at him and glanced away, the way you glance at furniture.

We talked for a few more minutes about nothing much — the food getting simpler, the other passengers, whether the storm would break before the last of the coffee ran out. She was good company. Quick, observant, funny when she chose to be. She asked about my trip — why a luxury train, was I alone — and I told her about Frank and his trip and the shoebox of timetables under the bed, and she listened with real attention, which is rarer than people think.

When she stood to leave she reached into the tin and took a second biscuit.

“For later,” she said. “Thank you, Mrs. Finch. This was nice.”

I watched her walk toward the far door, phone already up, framing a shot of something in the corridor. She moved with purpose even when she was performing aimlessness, and I did wonder whether she knew that about herself.

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The car emptied as the afternoon light thinned, passengers retreating into the private boredom of their own cabins. I stayed.

I went through what I had.

The vocabulary was the clearest thread. “Pneumatic retrofit” in the observation car, days ago. “Split-circuit pressurization” in the crew lounge. And now — in a conversation about nothing more than the cold — heating distribution, auxiliary generators, pressurization at altitude. She hadn’t read a plaque. She’d spoken from understanding, the kind that comes from study, not from a sign on a wall.

Add the filming. Her camera pointed at the Pullman corridor, not the storm. Pointed at the corridor outside Vance’s suite at 18:38 — before he died.

Add the crew lounge. The manual. The steward’s tolerance. Access to spaces passengers don’t need and don’t go.

Arthur would call it the strongest case we’d built. We still had questions about Elena, and Julian’s nervousness still needed answering. But neither

of them had shown anything like this — the deep, specific knowledge of how the train worked, worn like a second skin and covered with a lie about a plaque. Whatever had happened to Vance, Skye Tanaka understood this train in ways that went far beyond what her cover story could explain.

But the Alder Creek moment sat with me.

I couldn't name it. Her hand had stopped. Her eyes had gone somewhere. And the place they'd gone was not where a person goes when you mention a crime scene. I have been in enough rooms with enough frightened people to learn — slowly, and with mistakes that still keep me honest — the difference between hiding something and carrying something. They look the same from the outside. They are not the same.

Skye Tanaka was carrying something about Alder Creek. I didn't know what.

Frank kept a list of things he intended to do, written on the back of an electricity bill and pinned to the corkboard in the kitchen. Half the items had been there for years. He never crossed anything off, because that would have meant admitting he'd finished something, and Frank preferred to keep his obligations theoretical. I found the list after he died, and most of it was ordinary — fix the gutter, re-grout the shower, sort the photographs into albums. But one line near the bottom said *ask Hazel about the summer*, and I never found out which summer he meant, or what he wanted to ask.

Some questions sit until you're ready for them. Others sit until it's too late.

I closed the tin. Eleven biscuits. I'd tell Arthur and Bernie at dinner — lay out the evidence as clearly as it deserved. But I'd also mention the pause. The half-second where Alder Creek landed on something in that young woman's face that was older than suspicion, heavier than guilt, and familiar in a way I couldn't yet place.

I picked up the tin and went to find my cabin.

## Chapter 26: The Cargo Hold

Arthur found Miller in his cabin with the door open, polishing shoes that didn't need polishing.

The cabin was small — single berth, fold-down desk, narrow closet. Vance's spare shirts hung inside alongside Miller's own, pressed and buttoned on their hangers as if the man who wore them might call for one. Italian leather shoes sat on a square of newspaper on the desk, and Miller worked a brush across the left toe cap with steady, circular focus — maintaining a routine that no longer had a purpose.

"Got a minute?" Arthur said from the doorway.

Miller set the brush down. "I've got nothing but minutes, Mr. Kaine."

Arthur leaned against the frame. His knees had stiffened in the cold, and standing was better than sitting on the train's low berths. "I want to go back to the tasting plate. The evening Vance died."

Miller's jaw tightened — not evasion. Effort. He was trying to get something right.

"I've been going through it," Miller said. "Every night. Sitting here, going through it."

"Tell me."

"He didn't touch the food. I told you that before, but I've been replaying it, and his exact words came back." Miller picked up the brush, set it down again. His hands needed occupation and the shoes had stopped cooperating. "He said, 'Get that off my desk' — or words to that effect. Didn't look at it. Chef brought the plate in, Vance told him to take it away and ask the steward about cargo access, and the Chef walked out. Full plate."

"You're sure about full."

"I saw it go in. I saw it come out. The toasts, the cheese, the spread — all of it. Untouched."

Arthur nodded. A week of sitting alone in a small cabin, replaying the last evening of a dead man's life, and the vague impressions of the first days had

hardened into exact words and specific images. Witnesses did that. They sharpened when they had nothing to do but think.

“Alright,” Arthur said. “Thank you.”

Miller picked up the brush and started on the right shoe. Arthur watched him for a moment, then pushed off from the frame and left. You did the work that was in front of you when the work that mattered was gone. He understood that.

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He was halfway to the observation car when he heard the cargo access door — the heavy clank of a handle built for freight, not passengers. Then footsteps, quick and purposeful, heading below.

Arthur stopped. The service corridor was dim and narrow, the luxury of the upper cars stripped to rubber matting and bare steel. At the far end, the cargo access stood ajar, a thread of cold air leaking through.

Julian. The clock-watching, the phone-checking, the cargo hold visits that Hazel had flagged — anxiety that ran deeper than kitchen concerns. The trio had noted the pattern without acting on it, because Skye had become the priority. But Arthur was here, and the door was open, and thirty-one years of habit said follow.

The stairs were steep — more ladder than staircase, metal rungs bolted to the wall. Arthur’s knees complained on every step. The air changed as he descended — colder, drier, carrying the mineral smell of freight and old grease. The generator’s vibration was stronger down here, transmitted through the steel floor and into his joints.

The cargo hold opened at the bottom: a long, low space lit by caged work lights that threw hard shadows across stacked crates and luggage racks. Supply boxes, catering containers, a rack of fire extinguishers strapped to the wall. The unglamorous belly of the *Starlight Express*, where the brass and mahogany gave way to function.

Julian was at the far end, crouched beside three wooden crates on the lowest shelf. One was open. He held something in both hands — small, dense, mottled green — turning it in the work light as if seeing it for the last time.

Arthur watched from the foot of the stairs. Julian hadn't heard him come down — the generator covered the descent, and Julian's attention was entirely on the object in his hands. His chef's whites were rumpled, the apron gone, sleeves pushed to his elbows. He looked smaller than he did in the galley, where the copper pans and the prep stations and the sharp smell of butter gave him scale. Down here he was just a man crouched beside a box.

"Chef," Arthur said.

Julian's head came up. The jade figurine — because that's what it was, Arthur could see now, a seated figure in deep green stone, six inches tall, hands resting on crossed legs — nearly slipped from his fingers. He caught it, held it against his chest, and for a beat his face went through every option available to him.

None of them were good.

"Mr. Kaine." His voice came out flat. "This isn't — I can explain this."

Arthur came closer. The crate was lined with custom-cut foam, precise, professional — each piece nestled in its own cavity. A ceramic vessel with painted figures. A small obsidian blade, black and glinting. A stone mask with empty oval eyes. And an open space where the figurine had been.

The crate's label, in Julian's own handwriting: PERISHABLE — TEMPERATURE SENSITIVE.

"It's pre-Columbian," Arthur said.

Julian closed his eyes. When he opened them, the fight had gone out of his face. He set the figurine back in its foam cavity with the careful hands of a chef who couldn't help treating delicate things with respect, even now. Then he sat on the steel floor, his back against the shelf, and told Arthur everything.

A collector he'd met through a former sous chef. Coded texts on an unlisted number. Three crates loaded in Chicago, labeled as temperature-sensitive ingredients. The handoff: Siding 7, a maintenance turnout on the western descent — remote, unlit, accessible by a forest service road. The pickup crew was supposed to meet the train during the scheduled stop, but the train

had stalled forty miles east of the turnout, and the snowstorm had buried the road.

Three days of checking his phone for a signal that didn't exist. Watching the snow pile up on a plan that was already dead.

"How much?" Arthur asked.

"Forty thousand for the full set." Julian's voice had gone mechanical, reciting figures he'd calculated a hundred times. "The restaurant deposit. Baton Rouge — corner spot, good light, proper ventilation hood. I need it by April or I lose the lease. I've got eleven thousand. Two partnerships — the first one bought a boat with the operating fund. The second one disappeared to Portland with the line of credit." He looked at the crates. "After that, nobody returns your calls."

"And the uncle," Arthur said quietly. "Vance Capital."

Julian's mouth tightened. "Uncle Claude worked this line eighteen years. Track, signals, depot work. Vance Capital bought the company, gutted the workforce, closed the depots. My uncle lost his career and his pension." He paused. "I charged a case of Burgundy to Vance's account for the return trip. Seemed fair."

Arthur let the silence hold for a moment. Julian's grudge was real — you could hear it in the flatness when he said the name — but it was the resentment of a family wound, not the heat of a man who'd crossed a line. Arthur had sat across from killers. This wasn't what they looked like.

"The food," Arthur said. "The tasting plate you brought to the suite."

"He told me to take it away." Julian said it without hesitation. "Didn't touch it. I brought it back to the galley full. Ask anyone in the kitchen."

That matched Miller. Two sources, independent, consistent. Vance hadn't eaten the food. The tasting plate had gone in full and come out full, and the washed tray in the galley — Julian's compulsive scrubbing, the habit Hazel had noticed — was professional reflex, not evidence of anything except a nervous man who cleaned when he was anxious.

Arthur stood. His right knee locked, and he waited a beat for it to release before stepping away from the shelf.

“I’m not customs,” he said. “And I’m not law enforcement anymore. I’m trying to find out who killed the man upstairs, and it wasn’t you.”

Julian looked up at him. “How do you know?”

“Because the food came back full. Two people have told me that now, and neither one has a reason to lie.”

Julian said nothing. Arthur walked to the stairs and took the first rung.

“Your crates ride to San Francisco,” he said without turning around. “What happens after that is your problem.”

He climbed. The stairs were worse going up — his right knee caught on the third rung and he had to pause, one hand on the wall, waiting for it to let go. The service corridor above was empty and cold. From somewhere forward, the muffled sounds of the dining car carried through the walls — silverware on china, low voices, dinner being served to people who had nowhere else to be.

Arthur closed the cargo access door behind him and headed for the observation car. Two suspects cleared — Elena’s clinic, Julian’s antiquities. Neither was the killer. The field was narrowing, and what was left was a young woman with too much knowledge about train systems, an unresolved chamomile question, and a ventilation panel that had been loosened by hands that knew what altitude could do.

Below him, in the hold, Julian sat among his crates and did not move. The jade figurine rested in its foam bed, hands on its crossed legs, with the carved and ancient patience of something that had been waiting six hundred years and could wait a little longer.

## Chapter 27: Alder Creek

I didn't bring the biscuit tin.

That might not seem significant, but props matter. The tin says I'm here to be pleasant. Leaving it behind says something else.

The Alder Creek moment had kept me awake. Not the evidence against Skye — Arthur and I had gone through that at dinner the evening before, along with his news about Julian and the cargo hold. Smuggling, not poisoning. Three crates of pre-Columbian artifacts and a restaurant lease he couldn't afford, and Arthur had said it flatly, his knees still stiff from the stairs: "Not our killer." Bernie had nodded, adjusting his spectacles, and I'd watched both of them cross another name off a list that was getting very short.

But the evidence wasn't what lingered. The pause was. That half-second in the observation car when I'd mentioned the gorge and Skye's eyes had gone to a place I recognized but couldn't name.

I'd told them about it. Arthur had listened and said, "Could mean anything." Bernie had adjusted his spectacles and said nothing, which was his version of the same thing. They trusted evidence. I trusted pauses.

Raymond was in the corridor near the dining car, adjusting a heating vent with his clipboard tucked under one arm. "Morning, Mrs. Finch. Bit colder today — we're doing what we can with the auxiliary." I told him I appreciated it, which I did, and kept walking.

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Skye's cabin was at the far end of the rear Pullman — the smallest suite on the train, tucked against the crew corridor. I knocked.

She opened the door in a sweatshirt and reading glasses. No camera, no microphone, no silk scarf with the tiny clip. The cabin behind her was small and full of purpose: laptop open on the fold-down desk, spiral notebooks bristling with colored tabs, a stack of manila folders wedged between the wall and the berth. Not the curated space of someone who photographs her breakfast. The workspace of someone doing something else entirely.

"Mrs. Finch." Surprised but not unwelcoming. "Come in?"



I sat on the edge of the berth — the only option besides the desk chair.

“I don’t think you’re a travel influencer,” I said.

There are gentler openings, and I know most of them. But I was tired of being gentle, and she was tired of being watched, and we’d spent a week circling each other like two cats who can’t decide whether to fight or share the windowsill.

Skye took off her reading glasses and set them on the desk beside the laptop. She looked at me for a long moment — not defensive, not frightened. Deciding.

“No,” she said. “I’m not.”

She told me in clean, efficient sentences. Investigative journalist — print, mostly, but building toward a documentary. Three years on Vance Capital, Pinnacle Materials, and the Alder Creek bridge collapse. Vance had banned all press from the charter, so she’d built an influencer persona from scratch. Forty thousand followers in eight months, a complimentary suite through the booking agent, and a cover that was always going to dissolve the moment anyone competent looked closely.

“Which you did,” she said.

“The vocabulary gave you away,” I said. “Pneumatic retrofit. Split-circuit pressurization. And yesterday — auxiliary generators and heat distribution at altitude. No content creator talks like that.”

“I know.” The ghost of a smile. “The longer you live in a cover, the more it slips. You start thinking you’re good at it, and that’s when the mistakes come through.”

“The filming,” I said. “The corridor.”

“I was watching Vance’s suite door. Documenting who went in, who came out, how long they stayed.” She turned the laptop toward me. A frozen corridor frame, dim and familiar — the Pullman corridor, shot from the archway near the dining car. “My angle covered the door and about ten feet of hallway. The maintenance panel is behind the curtain — you can see the edge here.” She tapped the screen. “But the panel itself is out of frame.”

She'd been watching the door, not the corridor. If someone had reached that panel behind the curtain — and Bernie's data suggested someone had — her camera wouldn't have caught it.

"My post-stall footage is gone," she said. Not dramatic — the flat delivery of a loss already processed. "Three days of recording. I pulled the card from my phone to edit on the laptop, left it in the slot overnight. In the morning it was gone. Nothing else touched — the laptop, my notebooks, the mic. Just the card."

I walked over and checked the door I'd just walked through. No scratches around the lock, no scuffing on the frame. Someone had come in with a key.

"You didn't report it," I said.

"To whom? I'm supposed to be an influencer with nothing to hide. I can't explain three days of corridor surveillance without explaining everything else."

---

She had given me the professional version. Clean, strategic, complete. It explained the vocabulary, the filming, the crew lounge, the engineering manual, the steward's tolerance. It explained everything except the thing I'd come to ask about.

"Yesterday," I said. "In the observation car. When I mentioned Alder Creek."

She went very still.

"Your hand stopped. Half a second. And your eyes went somewhere that had nothing to do with our conversation."

The cabin was quiet. The generator hummed through the floor, and outside the frosted window the same mountains held the same positions they'd been holding for four days.

"My father's name was Kenji Tanaka," she said. "Ironworker Local 433. He was on the bridge when it fell."

She said it the way people say the things they've said many times — the words worn smooth, the delivery careful, the grief underneath compressed into something that could pass for composure.

“August 1994. My mother was five months pregnant. He left before five and his boots were gone from the mat. That’s how she told me about the last morning. That’s how I always think of it.”

She looked at the closed laptop. Her face was controlled but her hands were not — she pressed them flat against her knees, holding still by force.

“I never met him. Everything I know about my father comes from my mother’s voice telling me about a morning I wasn’t alive for. And from three years of court filings and FOIA requests and interviews with engineers who remember what the steel was supposed to be.”

I had been right in the observation car. What I’d seen in that half-second wasn’t guilt. It was grief — not fresh, not raw, but hardened over decades into something that looked, from the outside, like cold purpose. Skye Tanaka hadn’t come aboard to kill Sterling Vance. She’d come to document what he’d done, because no one else had, and because the man who’d cut corners on a bridge had never answered for the five people who fell.

I said I was sorry about her father. It was true and insufficient, but it’s all anyone ever has for something like this.

She nodded — not a thank-you, not a dismissal. An acceptance.

We sat together in her small cabin. She had lost a father to cheap steel before she was born. I had lost a husband to time six years ago. The losses were nothing alike and entirely the same, and neither of us tried to say so.

“You’re not a suspect,” I said. “Not for us. Not anymore.”

“I know.” And then, quieter: “Thank you for asking about Alder Creek. Yesterday. Nobody on this train has said the name.”

“Kenji,” I said.

She nodded again, and there was nothing more to say about it.

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I left her cabin and walked back through the Pullman corridor. The condensation on the windows had thickened into streaks, and someone had given up wiping them and left a wadded napkin on the sill. Day eight. Four days

stopped. The train had developed the stale, closed smell of a space that had been breathing its own air too long.

Three suspects. Three secrets. Elena's clinic. Julian's smuggling. Skye's journalism. Every one of them had a reason to act strangely, and none of them had killed Sterling Vance. We had spent eight days investigating people who were guilty of being human — compassion, ambition, grief — and the person who had actually committed murder was still on this train, still breathing, still walking the corridors.

Frank used to say that when you couldn't find your keys, it was because you were looking where they should be instead of where they were. He delivered this as though he'd invented the concept, which was charming the first time and less so the fortieth, but he wasn't wrong. He was rarely wrong about the obvious things. It was the subtle ones that got past him.

I stopped at a window and looked at the mountains through the wet glass. Somewhere out there, beyond the snow, was Alder Creek gorge, where a bridge had fallen and taken five people with it and started a chain of events that led, thirty years later, to a dead man in a locked suite on a stalled train.

But the bridge wasn't my question. My question was smaller and closer, and I'd been ignoring it for days.

Chamomile. Not from the galley. Not from the service stock. Someone's private supply, in a cup on a tray outside a dead man's door. I'd been assigned that question in the observation car a lifetime ago — "I'm the one who notices what people drink" — and then I'd let it go, pulled toward the dramatic suspects, the stolen medications, the cargo hold, the journalist with the dead father. The quiet question had been sitting there the whole time, patient as the snow on the mountains.

I didn't know whose chamomile it was. But I knew it was small and domestic and mine to find, and I'd been looking in the wrong direction.

I turned from the window and went to find Arthur and Bernie.

## Chapter 28: The False Clearing

Bernie laid his graph-paper notebook open on the table between the thermal carafes and smoothed the page with his palm. He'd been carrying the notebook since Chicago, filling it in small, precise handwriting that tilted slightly left — the same handwriting, Arthur thought, that had filled the 1993 actuarial report now sitting in Vance's document case.

"Seven panels," Bernie said. "I've tested all seven. The system is original pneumatic with a 2014 retrofit — manual override dials for each ventilation section, pressure gauges, labeled switches in railroad shorthand." He adjusted his spectacles. "Panels three, four, six, and seven are stiff. The dials require real force to turn — eight to twelve pounds of rotational pressure, by my estimate. Mountain dust undisturbed on the brass housings. Nobody's touched them since this run began."

"And panel five," Arthur said.

"Panel five." Bernie tapped his notebook. "Left dial turns with two or three pounds. The mechanism has been worked — the contact surfaces are smooth, polished by repetition. Mountain dust cleared from the dial and its collar but present on the surrounding fixtures. Not cleaned. Exercised."

Hazel held her tea with both hands. The observation car's curved windows were opaque with condensation, the mountains invisible behind four days of accumulated moisture. Above them, the heating system labored — a low, mechanical effort that hadn't been noticeable when the train was moving.

"How many times?" Arthur asked.

"Several. You don't wear brass smooth in two or three turns." Bernie flipped to the next page. "I also measured airflow response. Adjusting dials on panels six and seven — my controls — the system responded slowly. Sluggish mechanisms, sluggish airflow. Panel five responds immediately. The connection between the dial and the ventilation damper is loose, fast, broken in by repetition." He paused. "At the altitude of the Carrow Tunnel approach — above ten thousand feet — reducing the fresh-air intake through a single suite's circuit by forty percent would drop oxygen concentration to dangerous levels within twenty to thirty minutes. The timeline

fits. Julian left the suite at five-thirty. The panel was adjusted sometime after that. Vance was found unresponsive at dinner.”

Arthur sat with it. He’d been skeptical of the ventilation theory when Bernie first raised it a week ago — suggestive but unproven, atmospheric data that could have been altitude variation, a loose dial that could have been routine maintenance. The data in front of him now wasn’t suggestive. It was comparative, specific, and damning.

“Can you prove it?” Arthur asked.

“No.” Bernie took off his spectacles and cleaned them with his shirt. “We don’t have a body, a lab, or a toxicology report. I can’t prove Vance died of hypoxia any more than we could prove Digoxin or food poisoning. What I can tell you is that someone exercised that dial repeatedly, the mechanism could kill at altitude, and the timeline fits. And the other two theories are dead.” He put his spectacles back on. “This is the strongest available evidence. On a stalled train, it’s the only evidence.”

Arthur nodded slowly. “Then this is what we work with.”

Bernie closed the notebook. He didn’t mention his 1993 report, or the numbers he’d sent to a client contact who never called back. He didn’t need to. His hands were steady on the notebook’s cover, the pen clipped to the binding, everything aligned. Thirty-two years between a report nobody read and a finding that mattered, and the method was the same: measure, compare, let the discrepancy speak. He’d followed the numbers all the way through this time.

“Then the question is who,” Hazel said.

They went through it. Panel access was unrestricted — the panels weren’t locked, just hidden behind curtains in service corridors. But knowing how to use them, knowing what altitude would do, knowing which circuit served which suite well enough to practice on it dozens of times — that narrowed the field. Long-term crew with mechanical knowledge. Familiarity with vintage pneumatic systems. Proximity to the Golden Spike suite.

“Raymond,” Bernie said.

The name sat on the table between them.

Conductor. Twenty-five-year veteran. Cabin fifteen feet from the suite. He'd explained the ventilation system to Bernie himself, down in the Pullman corridor, days ago. Knew the altitude without checking a gauge. Knew every system on this train.

"I'll talk to him," Arthur said, and stood. His right knee caught, and he waited for it to release before stepping into the aisle.

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In the corridor between the observation car and the dining car, Arthur passed Miller and Elena walking together. Not arm in arm — nothing so definite. But side by side, unhurried, with the ease of two people who had found each other's company preferable to solitude. Miller wore his dark suit, pressed and buttoned, though the collar had finally loosened. Elena had her knitting bag over one shoulder, the needles clicking faintly against each other as she walked. They nodded to Arthur — Miller's nod crisp, Elena's warmer — and continued toward the rear Pullman.

Behind him, through the observation car's glass partition, Hazel watched them go. Her expression softened into something Arthur didn't turn back to see.

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The dining car between meals had the hollow feel of a stage between performances. White linen still on the tables, but the silver service had been replaced with stainless steel — fewer pieces, simpler settings. The menu board near the entrance listed three options where there had been eight on the first night. A junior steward cleared coffee cups from the far end.

Raymond sat at a corner table with his clipboard and a pencil, reviewing a crew schedule. His uniform was immaculate — brass buttons polished, cap set beside him on the linen, shirt pressed despite four days without laundry service. He looked up when Arthur approached and smiled.

"Mr. Kaine. Sit down, please. Can I get you anything?"

"I'm fine." Arthur took the facing chair. "Do you have a few minutes?"

"Nothing but." Raymond set down his pencil. "What's on your mind?"

Raymond was experienced and observant — he'd see through a casual approach and think less of you for trying it. Arthur had decided on the walk over not to pretend.

"We've been looking into Mr. Vance's death," Arthur said. "You know that." "I'd noticed." No defensiveness. A trace of amusement. "You, Mrs. Finch, and Mr. Pollard. Not the most covert operation I've seen."

"We believe the ventilation system was used to reduce the oxygen supply to Vance's suite during the high-altitude approach. Manual override on the corridor panel."

Raymond's expression shifted — not alarm, but serious attention. He leaned forward, forearms on the table. "That's possible. The system allows it — that's what the manual overrides are for, though the intended use is fire suppression and emergency pressure equalization."

"Who would know how to do it?"

"Anyone who read the maintenance manual. It's not complicated — the dials are labeled, the circuits are mapped." Raymond paused. "But understanding what it would *do* at altitude, what reducing intake by that margin would mean for someone in a sealed cabin — you'd need to understand the relationship between elevation and oxygen concentration. And you'd need to know which circuit served which suite."

"Do you know those things?"

"I do. Twenty-five years, Mr. Kaine. I started in freight — box cars, grain hoppers. Moved to passenger service in oh-six. This route, these mountains, I've run them more times than I can count." He picked up his pencil, turned it between his fingers. "The mountain doesn't care who's aboard. Ten thousand feet treats everyone the same — billionaire, brakeman, the mice in the walls."

"How did you end up on this run?"

"I volunteered. Best assignment available. The *Starlight Express* is the finest rolling stock on any line in the country — original vintage cars, full restoration, private charter money behind every detail. Good equipment,



good route, good pay.” He smiled. “I’m sixty-one. These don’t come around often.”

Arthur watched him. Thirty-one years of sitting across from people — witnesses, suspects, fugitives — and you developed a sense for the ones managing their presentation. The careful word, the rehearsed gesture, the flicker of recalculation behind a steady face. Raymond showed none of it. He was at ease in his dining car, in his uniform, in the conversation. Either he had nothing to hide or he was the best Arthur had encountered.

“What was your impression of Vance?”

Raymond set the pencil down. “Mr. Vance was used to people doing what he wanted,” he said. His voice was even, unhurried. “The staff, the schedule, the train itself — he expected everything to bend his direction. The mountain didn’t get that memo.”

He said it with a faint smile — small talk about a difficult passenger, nothing more. Arthur almost smiled back.

“I’d like to see the maintenance schedule,” Arthur said. “For the ventilation panels.”

“Of course.” Raymond opened his clipboard and turned it around on the table. Columns in neat handwriting — dates, panel numbers, checkmarks, brief notes. *Panel 2, window seal. Panel 5, routine. Panel 7, pressure check.* A record of professional diligence, offered without hesitation. “I check each panel on a rotating schedule. Every forty-eight hours during normal operation, every twenty-four during the stall — the heating load changes the pressure dynamics.”

Arthur studied the schedule. Thorough, consistent, and entirely unremarkable.

“Thank you,” he said, and meant it.

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He found the Head Steward in the service corridor near the crew quarters, polishing a brass fitting that was already fine. Arthur recognized the habit — keeping your hands busy when the work that mattered was gone.

“Raymond?” The steward straightened. “Twenty-five years I’ve worked with him, off and on. Fifteen on this route.”

“Any problems? Complaints, friction with the crew?”

“Never. Not once.” The steward folded his cloth into quarters. “He’s the first person new crew ask for when they have a question. Last person to leave the train at the end of a run.”

“How was he with Vance?”

“Patient. Professional. Mr. Vance was difficult with everyone — Raymond handled him the same way he handles every difficult passenger. Distance and courtesy.”

“Any change in his behavior recently? Anything off?”

The steward considered it, genuinely. Then shook his head. “He volunteered for this charter three months ago. Same Raymond since day one.”

Arthur thanked him and walked back.

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Bernie and Hazel were where he’d left them, the thermal carafes between them, the condensation on the windows unchanged.

“Nothing,” Arthur said. He sat down and his knee thanked him for it. “Twenty-five years of clean service. No connection to Vance — no history, no grievance, no personal angle. The Head Steward vouches for him without hesitation. Raymond volunteered the maintenance schedule, walked me through every detail, didn’t hedge on a single question.”

“You believe him,” Hazel said.

“I do.”

Bernie leaned back in his chair. “So we have a probable method. We have the mechanism. We have a panel that’s been exercised dozens of times by someone who understood exactly what it would do. And we have no one.”

Arthur thought about the pattern. Elena had a Vance grudge — years of workplace proximity, stolen medications, a hatred she didn’t bother to hide. Julian had a Vance grudge — his uncle’s career gutted by Vance Capital.

Skye had a bridge connection — her father killed at Alder Creek. Everyone they'd looked at had carried a reason.

He took out his phone and scrolled to the photographs from the suite break-in — Vance's documents, shot in the dim light of the Golden Spike suite three days earlier. The casualty list was three photos, taken at angles to catch the columnar format. Names and dates of injury. He pinched the screen wider and ran his thumb down the columns, looking for something that would connect to the railroad, to the crew, to anyone still aboard who hadn't already been cleared.

But the list offered only names and dates. No job titles. No employers. No addresses.

*Hargrave, T. Delk, R. Moreno, J. Wisniewski, P.*

Surnames and initials, sixteen casualties reduced to two columns on a page. Arthur scrolled to the second photo, found more of the same, and put the phone away.

"Every person we've investigated had a connection," he said. "Elena to the workplace. Julian to the railroad. Skye to the bridge. If the conductor has one, I can't find it."

Bernie closed his notebook and pressed his thumb along the spine. "Someone practiced on that dial. Someone who's been aboard long enough to loosen the mechanism. Not once — but several times."

"Who's been here that long?" Arthur said.

No one answered. Outside, the snow lay thick on the windows, unchanged for days. The generator hummed through the floor. Somewhere forward, a door opened and closed — a passenger restless in the same corridors they'd been walking since Tuesday.

"There are documents we haven't been through," Hazel said quietly. "The rest of Vance's folders. And someone got into Skye's cabin with a master key."

Bernie nodded. Arthur said nothing. They sat in the observation car with their lukewarm tea and their probable method and their empty suspect list, and outside the snow fell and the train did not move.

## Chapter 29: The Shifting Story

The thermal carafe had gone cold. Not lukewarm — properly cold, which meant Julian had stopped refreshing them, which meant the galley was running low on something. Propane or patience. I poured myself a cup anyway. Cold Earl Grey is still Earl Grey, and waiting is easier with something in your hands.

Bernie sat across from me, graph-paper notebook open to his ventilation data, pen clipped to the binding. He hadn't written anything new in twenty minutes. The numbers had done everything numbers could do, and now we needed something else entirely. Outside the observation car, the condensation had thickened into channels — small determined rivers cutting through frost, the mountains behind them reduced to shapes I'd stopped trying to identify.

Arthur came through the connecting door favoring his left leg. His right knee had been worse since the cold set in, though he'd have admitted to a fondness for interpretive dance before he'd acknowledge the pain. He sat beside Bernie, placed both hands flat on the table, and for a moment just looked at them.

"Miller lied," he said.

Not *misspoke*. Not *forgot*. Lied.

"About what?" Bernie asked.

"Where he was." Arthur looked at the cold carafe, decided against it. "He wasn't in his cabin eating a sandwich. He was in the corridor outside Vance's suite, walking to the dining car to get a whiskey."

I held my teacup and let him continue.

"On the way out," Arthur said, "he heard movement. Footsteps near the curtained section of the corridor. Didn't stop — crew in corridors is nothing unusual. He got his whiskey. Sat with it for ten, fifteen minutes. Then walked back." Arthur paused. "On the way back, he heard Vance through the suite door. Agitated. Pressing the intercom. Trying to get someone to respond."

“And he kept walking,” I said.

“And he kept walking. Went back to his cabin and told himself it was another complaint about pillow temperature.” Arthur’s hands were still flat on the table. I’d seen him sit like that in the dining car, in my cabin, in the observation car at midnight. It was how he held himself when the thing he was feeling wasn’t the thing he intended to show.

Bernie picked up his pen. Not to write — to hold. “Corridor movement going out. Ten to fifteen minutes. Vance on the intercom coming back.” He adjusted his spectacles. “Forty percent reduction at that altitude — my data gives twenty to thirty minutes before oxygen drops to critical levels. The interval works.”

He said it carefully, the way an actuary presents a finding he wishes weren’t accurate. As a measurement, not an accusation.

Arthur leaned back. “He told me he was two cars away. That was day two. Six days later and he’s suddenly in the corridor, fifteen feet from the suite, bracketing the murder with a whiskey errand. I’ve asked him three times about that evening and the story keeps moving.”

“The story gets more honest each time,” I said. “That’s different.”

“Maybe.” Arthur’s voice settled into its professional register. “A retired cop knows how to manage what he tells you. Give a little more each round. Stay ahead of what the investigators already have. He knew we’d confirmed ventilation. He knew we’d come back with harder questions. So he gets out in front of it — admits the corridor, admits the sounds, and hopes it looks like belated honesty instead of managed disclosure.”

“You think he was at the panel,” I said.

“I think his story puts him in the corridor during the window. I think a labeled dial doesn’t require an engineering degree. I think fourteen months of being called furniture by a man who rang a bell at three in the morning might qualify as motive.” He looked at me. “I also think I used him as my primary source for eight days and he was lying to me the entire time.”

That was the part that cut. Not the suspicion — the betrayal. Arthur had given Miller the courtesy of one professional to another, the short nod in

the corridor that said *I see what you are*. He'd built timelines on Miller's testimony — the food, the four o'clock dismissal, the bitter aftertaste, the intercom. And Miller had been standing on a lie the whole time.

"He's been carrying this since the night Vance died," I said. "The lie didn't start as a strategy. It started as a man saying the thing that hurt less."

"That's one reading," Arthur said.

"It is."

Bernie closed his notebook. "Either he heard the panel being used and the victim responding, which makes him a witness who sat on critical information. Or he used the panel himself, poured a whiskey to establish his movements, and heard the results on the way back." He paused. "The numbers work for both."

"I know what the numbers say," Arthur said, and the conversation ended the way conversations end when everyone has made their point and no one has changed anyone's mind.

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I left them to it. The observation car had said what it was going to say, and staying would have meant circling.

The corridor outside was cold at the junction — one of those pockets where the heating couldn't reach, or had stopped trying. Half the wall sconces had been switched off to save generator fuel, and the ones still burning threw long shadows across the mahogany. Day eight. Everything on this train was slightly less than it had been the day before — the light dimmer, the air staler, the corridors quieter. A slow subtraction that nobody mentioned because mentioning it would make it real.

Frank went to the doctor once, January, two years before his hip got bad. Didn't tell me the results for a week. I could tell something was off — his coffee held in both hands instead of one, standing at the kitchen window facing the yard instead of the sink, which meant he was having a conversation with himself that he didn't want me to hear. On the fourth day I asked and he said it was nothing. On the seventh he told me. Benign cyst. Absolutely harmless. The doctor had been cheerful about it.

But for a week he'd carried it around as though someone had handed him a sealed envelope he already knew the contents of. Because admitting he was waiting for test results meant admitting he'd been frightened enough to go, and Frank would rather have dug a ditch with a teaspoon than say the word *scared* out loud.

The cyst was nothing. The week of silence told me everything I needed to know — not about the cyst, but about him. About what men do with the small true thing that frightens them. They bury it under a version that sounds better, and they tell the better version until they half-believe it, and then someone asks a direct question and the whole structure comes down at once, not because the truth was terrible but because the hiding was.

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I found Miller in the library alcove at the rear of the observation car — the narrow booth with the reading lamps that had started flickering two days ago. He was sitting with a paperback open on the table, flat to a page he wasn't reading. His suit was pressed. His collar buttoned. His hands rested on either side of the book, holding it in place against nothing.

He looked up when I sat down across from him. No alarm, no rehearsal. Just the expression of someone who had recently told the truth and discovered it was heavier than the lie.

"Mrs. Finch."

"Mr. Miller." I didn't ask permission for the chair. At my age, chairs are practical matters. "Arthur spoke with you."

"Yes." He looked at the paperback, then at me. "I should have said it sooner."

I waited. Ten years of home visits teaches you that silence does better work than questions, and what people choose to fill it with tells you more than anything they planned to say.

"He was on the intercom when I came back," Miller said. "Pressing the button. Saying something I couldn't quite make out through the door." His thumb ran along the paperback's spine, pressing the crease flat. "He did that three, four times a week. Middle of the night, middle of dinner — pillow's wrong, water's wrong, the light's wrong. But this time —" He stopped.



Pressed the crease again. “His voice was different. Faster. Not angry, just — faster. Like he wanted someone to come and they weren’t coming.” He looked at the table. “I heard that, and I thought, *not again*. And I kept walking.”

He wasn’t looking at me. He was looking at his own hands on the table, at the pressed cuffs of a shirt maintained for a position that no longer existed.

“I wasn’t two cars away,” he said quietly. “I was right there. And I heard him.”

I didn’t tell him it wasn’t his fault. Telling someone he didn’t fail when he’s convinced he did is a comfort that serves only the person offering it. I told him I’d bring him some tea if Julian still had anything hot. He said he’d appreciate that. I left him in the alcove with his unread book and his pressed cuffs and the thing he’d finally said out loud.

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Walking back, I passed Raymond’s cabin. Light under the door. A pen on paper, or a schedule being reviewed — whatever conductors do when their train has been sitting still for four days and there’s nothing left to conduct. I walked on.

In my cabin, I opened the biscuit tin. Five. Five lemon-zest biscuits between me and the end of this, and I couldn’t see the end of anything. A nosy old woman with shortbread and no useful theory about who killed Sterling Vance.

Miller might have spent eight days polishing a dead man’s shoes to cover what he’d done. Or he might have been carrying the one failure that mattered and no way to say it that didn’t sound like a confession. I didn’t know which. Arthur had his pattern — the shifting story, the managed disclosure, the retired cop’s playbook. Bernie had his interval, clean and indifferent. And I had Miller’s thumb pressing flat a crease in a paperback he hadn’t turned a page of, which proves nothing except that the man was in pain, and pain is not evidence.

Carol Fenton, 1997. I’d been sure the husband was harmless. I liked her, and she was convincing, and I wanted the easy answer. I was wrong, and a

woman spent four more months in that house before someone less gullible than me asked the right question.

I'd been more careful since then about wanting things to be simple.

I turned off the reading lamp.

## Chapter 30: The Man Who Kept Walking

Arthur's right knee stiffened at the junction between the Pullman and the dining car passage. He stopped, let it work itself loose, and kept going. The corridor was dim — most of the wall lamps off now, the remaining bulbs throwing long shadows that shifted with the current. Eight days on this train. Four of them motionless. The brass fixtures had dulled somewhere around day six, and nobody had brought them back.

Elena was ahead of him, walking toward the rear Pullman with her knitting bag over one shoulder. She moved without hurry, the needles again tapping against each other in the bag's canvas interior. She saw Arthur and nodded — not warmly, not coolly. The nod of two people who had been in proximity long enough to stop performing. She continued past him, and he let himself notice it: she was walking from the direction of Miller's cabin. Not from his door. Just from the right corridor, at the right time, with no urgency in her step. Arthur turned and kept walking.

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Miller's door was second from the end. Arthur knocked twice — firm, evenly spaced. The door opened.

The cabin was the size of his own, maybe smaller. Single berth, fold-down table, narrow closet with the door standing open. Miller's suit jacket hung inside on a wooden hanger, collar straight, shoulders squared on the bar. His shoes sat paired by the closet's base — polished recently enough that the leather still caught the overhead light. A paperback lay closed on the fold-down table, a train schedule tucked inside as a bookmark.

Miller stood in the doorway in his shirtsleeves, collar buttoned. He didn't look surprised.

"Mr. Kaine."

"Can I come in?"

Miller stepped back. There was nowhere to sit except the berth and the single chair at the fold-down table. Arthur took the chair. Miller sat on the edge of the berth, hands on his knees.

Arthur didn't ease into it.

“Your story has moved three times,” he said. “First you were in your cabin, two cars away. Then you were in the corridor. Then you heard Vance on the intercom.” He kept his voice level. “You know how that reads.”

“I know how it reads.”

“Then tell me what you haven’t told me.”

Miller’s thumbs pressed against his kneecaps. Not fidgeting — holding.

“I’ve told you everything that happened,” he said. “What I haven’t told you is why.”

He looked at the closet, at the jacket on its hanger.

“Vance fired two bodyguards before me. Both for the same thing — they stayed when he told them to leave. Four o’clock, every afternoon. He wanted his privacy, and he didn’t want it negotiated. Harris pushed back once, said it was a security risk. Terminated by morning. Reynolds tried to explain that he couldn’t guarantee coverage with a daily four-hour gap. Gone before dinner.” Miller’s voice was even, practiced only in the sense that he’d turned it over enough times to say it straight. “I learned. When he said leave, I left. When the bell rang at three in the morning because the water was wrong, I came. When four o’clock came, I disappeared. That was the arrangement.”

“And the intercom.”

Miller was quiet for a moment. His thumb ran along the crease of his trousers at the knee.

“I heard him through the door on the way back from the dining car. The intercom tone, then his voice. Not angry — that would have been normal. He sounded like he needed someone to come.” Miller paused. “And I stood there with a glass of Scotch and fourteen months of knowing that going to him uninvited was how I’d lose the position. So I told myself it was the pillows, or the water, or the temperature. And I walked back to my cabin.”

A heating pipe ticked somewhere in the wall — metal contracting in the cold.

“By the time I sat down I knew it wasn’t the pillows,” Miller said. “But by then I’d already made the choice, and going back would have meant admitting I’d heard him and done nothing. So I drank the Scotch.”

“And the lie.”

“The lie.” Miller looked at his hands on his knees. “When you asked me the first time, I said I was two cars away. Because ‘I was right there’ is a different sentence. It makes me a different man.” He met Arthur’s eyes. “I wasn’t managing you, Mr. Kaine. I was managing what I could stand to say. And when that stopped working, I said more. Not because I had a strategy. Because I couldn’t hold it where I’d put it.”

Arthur listened and watched. The polished shoes by the closet. The jacket squared on its hanger. The crease in the trousers, maintained by hand. Fourteen months of being summoned and dismissed, and when the one summons came that mattered, Miller had done exactly what the job had taught him to do.

Hazel had seen it first. Not the details — she didn’t have the details yet. She’d read it in the library alcove, in the unturned page and the careful posture. Arthur had been looking for what he knew — the managed disclosure, the retired cop drip-feeding his confession — and he’d found it because that was the pattern he expected. The pattern was real enough. His reading of it was wrong.

Miller’s hands rested flat on his knees. Capable hands. Arthur looked at them and thought, briefly, about Skye Tanaka’s cabin. The SD card lifted from a laptop reader, nothing else disturbed, the door undamaged. A lock picked or a master key. Miller could pick a lock — any officer with a decade on the job could manage a cabin latch. Arthur had recently done it himself.

But Miller didn’t know Skye was filming corridors. Didn’t know she was a journalist. Had no stake in footage he’d never seen. The skill was there. Everything else was absent.

Arthur let it go.

“Thank you,” he said, and stood. His right knee tightened, and he waited it out before stepping toward the door.

“Mr. Kaine.” Arthur turned. Miller was still on the berth, hands on his knees, looking at the jacket in the open closet. “I know the timeline. Mr. Pollard was clear about how long it took. I probably couldn’t have changed anything.” He paused. “But I would have tried.”

Arthur nodded once — not agreement, not absolution. Acknowledgment. He left the cabin and pulled the door shut behind him.

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The observation car setup was as he’d left it. The trio’s table by the curved windows, fogged past seeing through. Bernie’s notebook sat closed on the linen. Hazel held a cup of something that had gone cold long enough to stop pretending otherwise. Bernie had his spectacles off, cleaning them with the hem of his shirt — slow, circular strokes, the gesture of a man maintaining equipment while his mind ran idle.

They both looked up when Arthur sat down.

“It wasn’t him,” Arthur said.

He didn’t elaborate. What he’d heard in that cabin — the firings, the bell, the four o’clock disappearances, the Scotch in the corridor — those were Miller’s to carry, not Arthur’s to redistribute. The conclusion fit in three words. The rest was private.

Bernie put his spectacles back on. “You’re certain.”

“I’m certain.”

Hazel said nothing. She watched Arthur — not his words but what sat behind them. Whatever she found there, she kept to herself.

Bernie opened his notebook, looked at the pages of ventilation data, and closed it again. The numbers had done their work. The work had led nowhere anyone could follow.

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Nobody spoke. The heating system labored through the walls — a sound that had been invisible when the train was moving and now filled every silence. Outside, snow against glass. Inside, three people at a table in amber

light with a method as confirmed as they could produce under the circumstances, and an empty suspect list.

Arthur had looked at every person on this train who carried a reason to want Sterling Vance dead. Elena's secret was compassion. Julian's was greed. Skye's was grief. Miller's was shame. Raymond's record was clean. Four of them had four secrets, and none of them was murder.

"We have the method," Bernie said. "We have the mechanism. We have a panel that someone used with precision and practice." He set his spectacles straight. "And we have no one."

"No," Arthur said.

Quiet. The observation car holding them in its dimmed light while the world outside stayed white and unmoving. Hazel turned her teacup in her hands — not lifting it, not setting it down. Turning it the way she turned things over, Arthur thought. Small revolutions that looked idle and weren't.

"There's still the chamomile," she said. Not to Arthur, not to Bernie. To the cup, or to herself, or to the question she'd been carrying since they'd divided the work in this car days ago. Who on this train drank chamomile when the galley had never stocked it?

Arthur thought about locks and keys. A cabin door opened without damage. A card taken and nothing else touched. Someone with access and precision — and a reason none of them had found.

Two questions, sitting in the same silence, pointing at the same dark space. Neither of them said so. The generator hummed. The windows stayed fogged. The train sat in its snow, and the snow kept falling, and nothing on the mountain moved.

## Chapter 31: The Cupboard

Four biscuits in the tin. I'd been counting them for two days. Not eating them — counting them. Which is not useful behavior, but when the investigation has gone to nothing and the corridors are getting colder and there's no one left to suspect, a woman needs something to keep track of.

The cabin was colder than it had been the night before — I could feel it in the door handle when I reached for the carafe on my side table. The tea inside had gone cold hours ago. I didn't bother pouring. Julian's supplies were thinning along with everything else on this train.

I sat on the edge of the berth and thought about chamomile.

Not strategically. Not as Arthur would — motive, opportunity, means. Just the question I'd been given four days ago in the observation car, when we divided the work three ways and I said I'd find out who on this train drank chamomile when nobody stocked it. And then Elena needed talking to, and Julian needed watching, and Skye needed understanding, and Raymond needed investigating, and Miller needed the truth pulled out of him, and the chamomile sat there. The small domestic question, waiting in the queue behind every dramatic one.

I could hear Frank's voice, actually. Not the words — Frank wasn't the sort for direct advice — but the tone. The slightly patient, slightly amused tone he used when I was looking for my reading glasses while wearing them, or when I spent half an hour convinced the bathroom tap was leaking and he said nothing until I'd exhausted myself checking the fixtures, and then he pointed at the window. Condensation running down the sill and dripping onto the tile. He'd noticed it three days earlier and hadn't mentioned it because, he said, I seemed to be enjoying the investigation.

That was Frank. He noticed things quietly and held them until they were needed, and I noticed things loudly and chased them until I ran out of breath. Between us, we usually found the tap.

The heating had been worse overnight. I could feel it in the brass fittings — they'd been cold for days, but now they felt actively hostile, the metal pulling warmth out of your fingers if you touched the door handle too quickly. The corridors had cold pockets at every junction where the warm



air from one car couldn't quite reach the next. Raymond had been managing all of it — the generator, the fuel rationing, the passengers who wanted to know when they could go home — for five days without a break and without, as far as I could tell, anyone asking how he was holding up.

I put three biscuits from the tin into a napkin. Kept one for myself. The shortbread was getting stale — two days past its best — but it was butter and sugar and lemon zest, and someone keeping a train alive in a snowstorm might appreciate it.

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The corridor between the Pullman and the service passage was dim. Three of the five sconces still burning, the others dark, their brass mounts gone greenish where the condensation had settled. A woman I recognized from the dining car — Mrs. Alderman or Alderton, gray coat, persistent cough — stood in her cabin doorway wearing what appeared to be two cardigans layered over a blouse, arms crossed, looking at the corridor wall as though it owed her an explanation.

“Cold morning,” I said.

“It's been cold for five mornings,” she said, and went back inside.

She wasn't wrong. The train had been contracting around us for days — less light, less heat, less of the polish and performance that had made it feel like a floating hotel. The mahogany was still mahogany, but it looked tired now. Everything on this train looked tired. Including me, I suspected, although I'd stopped checking mirrors around day six because the news wasn't improving.

Raymond's station was past the service corridor, through the narrow passage where the galley met the conductor's office — a cubby, really. Desk bolted to the wall, schedule board with handwritten updates, a coat hook, a narrow shelf. I'd walked past it half a dozen times without stopping. A conductor's office is like a thermostat — part of the infrastructure, not part of the scenery.

He was there. Sitting at the desk with a clipboard and a pencil, working through what looked like a fuel log — columns of numbers in neat, even handwriting. His uniform jacket was buttoned but the collar was looser

than I'd seen it before, and there were shadows under his eyes that hadn't been there a week ago. He looked up when I appeared in the doorway and his expression did something I recognized from ten years of home visits — the brief surprise of a person who has been working alone long enough to forget that other people exist.

"Mrs. Finch."

"I brought you something," I said, and held out the napkin. "They're two days old, but they're made with real butter, and I thought you might have missed lunch."

He took the napkin, opened it, and looked at the biscuits the way you look at something you'd forgotten people do. "You baked these?"

"In Julian's oven. He supervised, which mostly meant standing behind me making French sounds."

Raymond almost smiled. Not quite — he was too tired for quite — but the muscles moved in the right direction. "Thank you. That's very kind."

"I also wanted to ask about the heating," I said, because I did. "The corridor junctions are getting cold enough to notice, and Mrs. Alderton — Alderman — the woman with the cough — she's layering cardigans, which is never a good sign."

He set down the clipboard. "Generator's holding. We've got fuel for another three days at current draw, maybe four if I cut the rear Pullman to half-circuit overnight. Nobody's going to freeze." He said it calmly — he knew his train as thoroughly as I knew a house. What's working, what's struggling, where the draft comes in. "I've been running the heating longer in the public cars and shorter in crew quarters. Passengers notice more."

"And what about you?"

"I'm crew," he said, as though that answered it.

I'd come to ask about the heating. I'd asked about the heating. I could have thanked him and left. But the cubby was small, and he looked like he hadn't talked to anyone who wasn't asking him for something in days, and I am, for better or worse, the sort of woman who sits down.

He must have noticed, because he stood before I could say anything else. “Can I make you a cup of tea? Julian’s carafes aren’t what they were.”

He reached for a small electric kettle on the shelf — the personal kind, the size you’d pack in a suitcase. Beside it, a tin box with a hinged lid, and a clean mug hanging from a hook. He filled the kettle from a water bottle, clicked it on, and opened the tin.

The smell came first.

Chamomile. Dry, papery, faintly sweet — the smell of the flower heads in the tin reaching the warm air of the cubby. I knew it the way you know the smell of your own kitchen. I also knew it from a corridor tray outside a dead man’s suite, eight days ago — a cup of chamomile barely touched, with a tight grip smudge on the handle.

Raymond pinched the leaves into a strainer with practiced fingers — steady, precise, the grip of a man who makes this tea every evening. Two cups. One for me, one for him. He wasn’t performing generosity. He was making tea because someone was visiting, and that’s what you do when someone visits. The kettle clicked off and he poured.

“I usually drink Earl Grey,” I said. My voice sounded normal, which surprised me.

“This is all I’ve got, I’m afraid. I bring my own supply — can’t stand what they stock in the galley. Peppermint tastes like a dentist’s office.” He set the cup in front of me. “Chamomile’s been my evening tea for thirty years. My mother drank it. Couldn’t sleep without it.”

I held the cup. The steam curled up between us and I breathed it in and thought about a phantom — a tea that wasn’t in the galley, wasn’t in the steward’s inventory, wasn’t stocked anywhere on this train. A cup on a corridor tray that someone had held too tightly and barely drunk. And here it was, in a tin box on a shelf in a conductor’s cubby, offered to me with biscuit crumbs on the desk between us.

I drank it. It was good. He drank his. We sat in his small, tidy workspace — the schedule board with its neat columns, the clipboard squared to the desk edge, the pencil parallel to the clipboard — and he told me about the

plowing crews. Two rotary units dispatched from Grand Junction. Another day, maybe two. He talked about the stretch of track between the tunnel and the switchback, how the drifts built up differently on the south-facing grade because the wind came off the ridge at an angle. He knew the mountain as well as he knew the heating circuits — thoroughly, without showing off about it.

I finished my tea and thanked him. He thanked me for the biscuits. I left him in his cubby with his fuel log and his chamomile and his quiet certainty about how things worked.

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Walking back through the service corridor, I counted what I knew.

No chamomile on this train. Not in the galley, not in the steward's stores, not in any passenger's tea service. I'd confirmed it with the Head Steward five days ago — Earl Grey, English Breakfast, peppermint. That was the list.

Raymond Delk carried his own supply. Always had. His mother's tea.

And a corridor tray outside a dead man's locked suite had held a cup of chamomile — barely touched, gripped hard — and nobody had ever explained where it came from.

I didn't build a case. I'm not Arthur. I didn't calculate an odds ratio. I'm not Bernie. I held the two facts side by side and let them sit there — a tea preference and a corridor tray — and felt the quiet unease of having finally looked in the cupboard I'd been walking past since the beginning.

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Arthur and Bernie were in the observation car. Same table, same fog on the windows, same posture of two men waiting for a direction they didn't have. Bernie had his notebook open to a page of ventilation data he'd stopped updating. Arthur had a cup of something cold and his reading glasses on the table beside it.

I sat down and told them. Raymond drinks chamomile. He made me a cup. He carries his own supply — has for thirty years. Nobody else on this train has chamomile. And a cup of chamomile was on the corridor tray outside Vance's suite the night he died.

Arthur listened without moving. Then he took off his glasses, held them up to the light, and set them back on without cleaning them.

“We cleared him,” he said.

“I know.”

“Yesterday. No motive, no connection, twenty-five years of clean service.”

“I know that too.”

Bernie tapped his pen against the notebook binding. “It’s a data point. One data point doesn’t reopen a closed file.”

“I’m not reopening anything,” I said. “I’m telling you what I found.”

Arthur put his glasses back on. He didn’t dismiss it. He didn’t pursue it. He set it down on the table between us, next to the cold tea and the closed notebook and the fog, and left it there.

“All right,” he said.

Outside, the snow had stopped falling for the first time in two days. The mountains were still there — had been there the whole time, behind the fog and the frost and the five days of white nothing. The peaks showed through in places now, sharp and indifferent, and the light was different. Brighter. Almost honest.

One biscuit left in my cabin. One data point on the table. Both insufficient and both, I suspected, not nothing.

## Chapter 32: The Conversation

Bernie's notebook lay open on the observation car table. The curved windows showed mountains for the first time in days — peaks visible against a clearing sky, snow crust bright along the ridgelines, the light sharper than it had been all week. Condensation trails ran down the glass where the fog had lifted.

The tablecloth under his notebook had wrinkled in the same direction for three days. Nobody had smoothed it. A water ring marked the linen where Hazel's teacup had sat that morning. Arthur's reading glasses case lay near the salt cellar. The observation car still held its shape — the mahogany ceiling, the brass lamp fixtures, the wide windows designed for scenery — but nobody was looking at scenery, and hadn't been for some time.

The data filled six pages in his careful hand. Panel designations, resistance measurements, airflow response intervals, comparative analysis across seven access points. All of it clean. All of it verified. All of it confirming a method as proven as anything could be without a laboratory.

He turned back to the page that bothered him. Panel 5: resistance two and a half pounds. Airflow response: immediate. The other panels ranged from nine to twelve pounds, with response lags of twelve to eighteen seconds. The resistance was explained — a mechanism loosened by repeated use. But the response time wasn't just about the dial. The air itself moved differently through that section, and he couldn't account for why.

He closed the notebook. Opened it. Took off his spectacles, breathed on the lenses, and cleaned them on his sleeve. The numbers were finished. The question behind the numbers wasn't.

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The corridor between the observation car and the Pullman was cold at the junction — the gap where warm air from one car failed to bridge to the next. Half the sconces were dark. The brass had gone greenish where condensation had settled, and the carpet runner was damp at its edges. The smell of the Pullman had changed over the stall — less polish, more human. Wool and stale coffee and the faint metallic edge of moisture on brass.

Miller and Elena sat on a bench in the Pullman passage. Elena had knitting in her lap — something smaller than her earlier projects, a glove or the start of a hat, dove-gray yarn working through her fingers without urgency. Miller sat beside her with his hands folded, collar unbuttoned for the first time Bernie had seen. Neither of them looked up.

Bernie passed without slowing.

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The service corridor ran behind the galley — rubber matting underfoot, pipe runs exposed along the ceiling, the generator's hum closer here than anywhere else on the train. The mahogany stopped at the galley door. Beyond it, painted steel and functional hardware. The air was warmer than the passenger corridors — generator and heating equipment radiated through the steel walls — but it smelled of work. Machine oil and the faint burnt-dust scent of insulation running hot.

Raymond was at a panel two sections back, the velvet curtain pulled aside and clipped to a hook. His flashlight balanced on the pipe above the panel housing, clipboard under one arm, free hand testing the dial assembly. The uniform was buttoned, cap straight, but the collar had loosened further since the stall and the shadows under his eyes had settled in.

He looked up when Bernie appeared.

“Mr. Pollard.”

“I have a question,” Bernie said. “About the ventilation.”

Raymond's expression shifted — not guarded, not wary. Interested. He set his clipboard on a pipe bracket and turned toward the open panel.

“The response time,” Bernie said. He gestured at the dial housing. “When I tested this unit — the one nearest Mr. Vance's suite — the airflow adjusted almost immediately. Other panels lag twelve, fourteen seconds before the system registers a change.” He pushed his spectacles up. “The resistance I can account for. Loosened mechanism. But the response differential — that's not hardware wear. Something else is happening.”

Raymond's fingers found the left dial without looking — automatic, a pianist's hand at middle C. “You're right. It's not just hardware.” He tapped

the ductwork above the panel, a junction where two trunk lines met in a welded seam. “Section five sits at the split — where the main supply trunk from the generator divides into forward and aft circuits. Shortest ductwork run on the train. Air reaches the suite faster because it travels less distance.” He traced the pipe with his finger toward the forward car. “That’s part of it. The other part is altitude.”

“Altitude.”

“At four thousand feet — Denver, say — the air in these ducts has density. Mass. When you adjust a dial, the system has to push through that mass to equalize. It absorbs the change. Takes time.” He’d turned this over enough times that the explanation had found its own shape — unhurried, precise, lived rather than rehearsed. “Above ten thousand feet, the air thins out. Less resistance in the pneumatics. Less buffering between the adjustment and the result. You turn the dial up here” — he touched it again, lightly — “and the train answers right away. Nothing between you and the effect.”

Bernie looked at the ductwork junction, the split where the trunk line divided. He’d measured the output without considering the architecture — the distance between the dial and the suite’s intake vent. Shorter duct run, thinner air. The response wasn’t just faster because of the dial. It was faster because the physics were different at this altitude, in this section of the train.

“So the differential isn’t wear alone,” he said. “Mechanical advantage compounded by atmospheric conditions.”

“Both working together.” Raymond straightened from the panel. “The hardware moves easily because it’s been maintained. The air moves fast because there’s less of it.” He paused, and when he spoke again his voice carried the directness of knowledge, not performance. “Most people think of ventilation as binary. Open or closed. It isn’t. You make an adjustment, the train responds, and if you’ve been paying attention long enough you learn to feel the answer. How fast, how much, how the air settles through a car at different hours.” He looked at the dial. “It’s a conversation. You learn the questions. The train provides the answers.”

“I understand that,” Bernie said. And he did.



Raymond pulled the curtain back across the panel and unclipped his flashlight. He glanced down the corridor — checking, by habit, whether anything else needed attention — and then lowered himself onto a steel equipment trunk bolted against the wall beside the panel housing. He set the clipboard across his knees and let his shoulders settle. The posture of a man who had been on his feet for most of five days and had found, briefly, a reason to stop.

Bernie leaned against the opposite wall. The pipe behind him was warm — one of the heating circuits, still working.

A pipe above Raymond's head clicked — metal contracting as the load shifted. Down the corridor, the generator's tone dropped half a register. Raymond glanced toward the sound, automatically, then back.

"How long have you been on the railroad?" Bernie asked.

"Twenty-five years. Started in freight — box cars, grain hoppers, the runs nobody volunteers for. Moved to passenger service in oh-six." Raymond set the light on the trunk beside him. "You stop seeing the scenery after a while. Never stop feeling the train, though. How the couplings sound at speed, whether the generator's running hot, which section draws more current than it should." He looked at the pipe runs above them, the corridor's working architecture stripped of mahogany and brass. "I put my name in for this charter three months ago. This route — the Carrow, the high passes — it's the most demanding stretch of track I know. I've run it thirty times, maybe more."

"You don't get tired of the same stretch?"

"Not this one. The flatlands get long — Denver to the grade is just hours. But the mountain work changes every winter. Snow shifts how the track sits. Ice moves the ballast. You recalibrate." He tapped his knee. "This charter's the finest rolling stock I've worked. Prewar Pullman restoration, everything maintained to standard. And the route." He gestured at the walls around them — the train's bones, stripped of decoration. "Most conductors want easy runs. Flat track, sea level, good weather. I never saw the appeal."

"And you wanted this one more time."

“One more time.” Raymond’s voice was quiet — not tired exactly, but arrived. He’d been traveling toward this stretch of track for a long time and was, finally, on it. “A route gets into you after enough years. Where the grade shifts after the tunnel. How the wind builds on the south face. Where the drifts settle and where they don’t.” He looked at his hands. “This was the one I wanted to finish with.”

Bernie understood. The pull of a system you’d studied until its rhythms became your own — not learned but absorbed, until the boundary between the observer and the observed had dissolved. His actuarial tables had been no different. Thirty years of mortality rates and load-bearing calculations, learning to hear what the inputs said before the outputs confirmed it. Linda had told him he loved the numbers more than he loved her, and in the decade since she’d left he’d tried to determine whether she was wrong. He still hadn’t managed it.

“Thank you,” Bernie said. “For the explanation.”

“Any time.” Raymond picked up his clipboard and flashlight. “Not many passengers ask how things work. It’s nice when someone does.”

Bernie pushed off the wall and walked back toward the Pullman junction. Behind him, the click of the flashlight switching on. Raymond already moving to the next panel.

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Nothing had moved in the observation car. Notebook on the table, pen in the spine. The mountains through the curved windows had sharpened in the late afternoon light, the snow on the upper slopes catching the sun in bands of white and pale gold.

He sat down, opened the notebook to a blank page near the back, and wrote in his careful hand: *Panel 5 — response differential. Two factors: (1) shortest ductwork run, junction of main supply trunk. (2) Altitude effect — above 10K ft, reduced atmospheric density = less pneumatic buffering. Manual adjustments register immediately. Per Raymond, conductor (verbal, Day 9).*

He didn’t circle it. Didn’t draw a line to the comparative data at the front of the notebook. It was a footnote — the last variable in a completed dataset, catalogued and explained.

Bernie closed the notebook and set his pen on top of it. Outside, a bird crossed the clearing sky — the first movement against that blue in days. It passed behind the western ridge and was gone.

He cleaned his spectacles on his cuff, put them back on, and looked at the closed notebook. Every measurement taken. Every anomaly accounted for. A complete record of how Sterling Vance had died, and not one line in it that pointed at a name.

## Chapter 33: The List

The biscuit tin was empty. I'd known it was empty since this morning — the last one eaten in my cabin sometime after midnight, crumbs on a napkin I'd forgotten to throw away — but I opened the lid and looked inside anyway, not because I expected anything to have changed but because your hands sometimes just need a task.

The cabin was cold. Not the sharp, honest cold of the first morning after the stall but the kind that has settled in and unpacked and is no longer making excuses for itself. Condensation on the brass door handle had started to bead and run. The thermal carafe on my side table had gone tepid hours ago and I hadn't replaced it because Julian's tea was no longer worth the walk — leaves reused twice over, water tasting of pipes.

I put the lid back on the empty tin and sat there thinking about chamomile.

The chamomile had found its source and the source had been cleared, and that should have been the end of it. But I sat with the feeling that something didn't fit and waited to see if sitting made it fit any better. It didn't. It hadn't all day.

One data point, Bernie had said. And he was right. One data point isn't a case or an argument or even a proper question. It's a cup of tea that smelled like a dead man's corridor tray, made by a conductor who keeps chamomile on a shelf because his mother drank it and who poured me a cup without being asked because that's what you do when someone visits. It was kind. It was also the only chamomile on this train, and the question I'd been carrying since Day 5 had finally found somewhere to land, and Arthur had said *We cleared him* in a voice that closed a door.

I closed the tin. The snap of the lid was too loud in the quiet cabin.

The sky had cleared. I could see mountains through the window for the first time in days — actual peaks, not the gray nothing that had sat over everything since the stall. The light was sharper. Everything looked closer than it was.

I picked up my phone.

Arthur had shared the suite photographs four days ago — sent them to all three of us so we could review at our leisure, which for Arthur meant systematic study, for Bernie meant cataloguing by document type, and for me meant scrolling through once, feeling faintly cross about the small screen, and setting the phone down. I am not a phone person. Frank used to say I held mine like a bar of soap I was afraid of dropping, which was unfair but not wrong.

Frank remembered full names. It was one of his things — not a skill he'd practiced, just something his brain did without effort. The Hendersons at number forty-two, Bob and Margaret, Margaret with an 'e.' Alan Wojciechowski three doors down, which Frank could spell on the first try and I never managed once in thirty-one years on the same street. When someone new moved in, he'd come home from his walk and report the name, correctly, and it would stay. I called people by their first names, or I called them the woman with the red door or the man whose dog barked at six in the morning, and that worked fine because you don't need a surname to know whether someone is happy or frightened or lying. You need to watch how they hold their teacup and whether their hands are steady.

But sometimes you do need the surname. Sometimes the first name is all the warmth and the surname is where the history lives, and you don't know you needed it until it's already in front of you.

I opened the photos and swiped through. The insurance filing, the Alder Creek folder, Bernie's report — all looked at, argued over, absorbed into the case and the reason three retired Americans were still sitting on a stalled train caring about a dead man none of them had liked. The casualty list was toward the end. I'd glanced at it once before — stapled pages, columnar format, sixteen names. Arthur had gone through it on his phone, scrolling with his thumb, looking for occupational connections and institutional links. Companies, unions, contractors. He'd found nothing. Bernie had noted the format — standard insurance reporting, pre-digital. Neither of them had read the names. Not for who they were.

I read the names.

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Sixteen names and dates of injury. That was all — no job titles, no addresses, no descriptions of what happened to them. Just surnames and initials in two columns on a page, the way an insurance company counts the cost of a bridge falling down.

I read them anyway. Tanaka, K. Kenji. Skye's father, whose boots were gone from the mat one evening and never came back. A man I'd never met, reduced to a letter and a date on a form that didn't care who he'd been or who he'd left behind.

Fourteen more. Names I didn't recognize, attached to dates I couldn't do anything with. I read each one and tried to see someone behind it, which is a useless exercise on a phone screen in a cold cabin, but I stopped apologizing for how my mind works some time ago.

The sixteenth name.

Delk, R.

I set the phone on the berth beside me. The screen stayed lit for a moment, the name glowing against the white column, and then went dark.

Delk.

Raymond Delk, who keeps chamomile in a tin on a shelf in his conductor's station and writes his fuel log in neat, even handwriting. Raymond Delk, whose brother liked the cold — said it made the steel tighter. I remembered him telling me that in the observation car on Day 4, heavy snow on the windows, the wool blanket he'd brought me smelling of cedar and old storage. His brother the steelworker. *Not for a long time*, Raymond had said, quietly, and I'd heard the loss in it and moved on, because loss is ordinary and doesn't usually require investigation.

Delk, R. A steelworker's brother on a list of people broken by a bridge that Sterling Vance built with steel he knew was wrong.

I sat with it — the name, the chamomile, the route chosen three months in advance — and let the picture come clear. Someone who had been carrying something for thirty years.

The light through the window had shifted. Still clear, but the shadows on the lower slopes had lengthened and the peaks had that late-afternoon brightness that doesn't hold.

I put the tin on the side table and the phone in my cardigan pocket and went to find Arthur and Bernie, because some things you can sit with and some things you have to say out loud.

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The corridor was dim — two sconces burning out of five, the brass fittings greened by a week of condensation. The observation car, when I reached it, was half-lit. Three ceiling fixtures dark, the rest giving off that yellowish cast they produce when the generator is at its limit. The curved windows framed the full range — clear sky, snow on the ridgelines, the whole sweep of it wider than any cabin window could hold.

Arthur and Bernie were at the usual table. The linen had gone untended — creased, a water ring near the salt cellar, nobody caring anymore. Arthur had his reading glasses on and a cup of something cold in front of him. Bernie's notebook was closed, which either meant he'd finished his calculations or run out of questions, and with Bernie those aren't always different things.

I sat down and told them.

"Raymond's surname is Delk," I said. "There's a Delk on the casualty list. R. Delk. And Raymond told me about his brother — steelworker, liked the cold, said it made the steel tighter. That was Day 4, before any of this."

Arthur took off his glasses. Held them in his right hand, deciding how much of what he'd heard he was willing to let in.

"We cleared him," he said.

"I know."

"I sat across from that man in the dining car and asked him direct questions for twenty minutes. He answered every one without flinching. Volunteered his schedule. The Head Steward vouched for him." He set the glasses on the table, carefully, beside the cold cup. "And now his brother's name turns up on a list we've had for four days. I read 'Delk, R.' on that list with my own

thumb on the screen, and it was a name in a column, nothing more. His uniform says Raymond. The duty board says Raymond. The Head Steward calls him Raymond. Twenty minutes of questions across that table and I never once had a surname to put beside it.”

“I’m telling you what I found.”

“Yesterday we had no connection between the conductor and Vance. None. I looked for exactly that.” He paused. “Now we have chamomile and a surname. Two things that were sitting in front of us the whole time. Or two things that were placed there for us to find.”

Bernie tapped his pen against the notebook binding — twice, then stopped. “Chamomile was one data point. This is two. Two points is a line.”

“Two points is a line someone drew for you,” Arthur said.

Nobody spoke. The mountains filled the curved windows, snow on the upper slopes catching the last of the afternoon light in bands of white and gold, and none of us were looking at them.

“I’m not drawing a line,” I said. “You went through those photos looking for institutions — companies, unions, contractors. You were looking at structure. I was looking at names.” I let that sit for a second. “And I found one.”

Arthur put his glasses back on. Looked at me, then at Bernie, then at the mountains.

“All right,” he said. “But we’ve been wrong about one man two times in three days, and I’d rather not make it three times.”

---

Bernie left first — said something about reviewing his notes, which meant he wanted to sit alone and decide what two data points were worth when one was a surname and the other was a cup of tea. Arthur left a few minutes later without saying where he was going, which was Arthur’s way of telling you he needed to walk.

I stayed.

The observation car emptied as the light changed. One of the remaining ceiling fixtures buzzed and dimmed, and then it was just the windows and



the mountains and the quiet that comes after you've said something that can't be taken back.

I thought about Raymond in his station, pouring chamomile he hadn't been asked for, tired and grateful for a visit. The clipboard squared to the desk edge. The pencil parallel. How he'd talked about his brother with the careful brevity of practiced restraint.

Frank would have caught it immediately. He'd have heard "Raymond Delk" and seen "Delk, R." on the list and put them together before the tea went cold. But Frank noticed names and I notice people, and what I'd noticed about Raymond Delk over nine days was how he straightened things that were already straight, knew his altitude without checking, and carried his mother's tea in a tin box on a shelf in a room where nobody visited.

I didn't know if that made him a killer. I knew it made him worth asking about.

The last light left the peaks and the mountains went gray, ridge by ridge, losing their edges to the evening. I sat in the observation car with my hands in my cardigan pockets and the phone against my knuckles and waited for tomorrow, because tomorrow was when the asking would have to start.

## Chapter 34: The Frame

Bernie arrived first. The observation car was empty except for the light, which came through the curved windows at an angle that hadn't existed for most of the week — direct, winter-sharp, throwing long rectangles across the linen and the mahogany and the brass lamp fixtures that nobody had polished since the stall began. The mountains were fully visible for the second morning running. Snow on the upper ridges, blue shadow in the draws, the whole range presented with a clarity that felt like an argument.

He sat at the usual table. The water ring from Hazel's teacup was still on the linen, dried to a faint circle. Arthur's reading glasses case lay near the salt cellar. The tablecloth had creased in the same direction for four days.

He opened his notebook to the back page and read what he'd written there yesterday afternoon in his careful hand:

*Panel 5 — response differential. Two factors: (1) shortest ductwork run, junction of main supply trunk. (2) Altitude effect — above 10K ft, reduced atmospheric density = less pneumatic buffering. Manual adjustments register immediately. Per Raymond, conductor (verbal, Day 9).*

He read it twice. It was clean, complete, accounted for. The last variable in a finished dataset.

He closed the notebook and set it on the table and waited.

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Hazel came from the Pullman direction, cardigan buttoned to the collar, no biscuit tin. Arthur arrived a minute later from the dining car — reading glasses already on, which meant he'd been up for a while and had been thinking with a pen in his hand.

Nobody asked how anyone had slept. Hazel sat. Arthur sat. The light through the windows was strong enough to show the thinning at Arthur's temples and the tiredness around Hazel's eyes that she wasn't bothering to hide.

"I want to lay this out properly," Arthur said. "Not the shorthand from last night."

"Go ahead," Hazel said.

Arthur removed his glasses, held them in his right hand, and set them on the table — his way of saying he was working from memory, not notes.

“The chamomile was in his station. An open room — no lock, no door, shelves visible from the corridor. Anyone who walked in would see the tin. Anyone who knew we were investigating would know that the chamomile question was still open — Hazel’s been asking about it in shared spaces since Day 5.” He paused. “The name on the casualty list — ‘Delk, R.’ — has been sitting in Vance’s document case since before we boarded this train. Available to anyone who got into that suite.”

Arthur’s voice was level — not combative, procedural. “Raymond was cooperative when I interviewed him. Forthcoming. Volunteered his maintenance schedule without hesitation. That’s what you do when you’re innocent. It’s also what someone does when they know the investigation is coming and they want to look clean for it.”

Bernie watched Arthur’s hands. Still. Not fidgeting with the glasses, not reaching for the case. Controlled.

“Thirty-one years,” Arthur said. “I’ve seen three federal cases where the obvious suspect was the wrong one. In two of them, the evidence looked exactly like this — clean, sequential, each piece pointing at the same person. In one case, a colleague planted a badge number in the victim’s phone to frame another agent. Took us four months to untangle it.” He picked up the glasses. “I’m not saying Raymond is innocent. I’m saying the evidence has a shape, and I’ve seen that shape manufactured.”

The observation car was quiet. One of the remaining ceiling fixtures buzzed — a faint, electrical complaint that had been there for two days and that Bernie had stopped hearing until now.

Hazel didn’t respond immediately. She looked at the mountains through the curved glass — the ridgelines sharp, the snow catching the morning light in clean white bands.

“Who?” she said.

Arthur frowned.

“Who frames him?” Hazel said. “Who else on this train has access to the ventilation panels, knows the altitude effect on airflow, understands the route well enough to time it for the tunnel approach, and also has a reason to want Sterling Vance dead?” She wasn’t raising her voice. She wasn’t arguing. She was asking. “Elena’s cleared. Julian’s cleared. Skye’s cleared. Miller’s cleared. The Head Steward has known Raymond for twenty-five years and vouched for him without hesitation. So who puts ‘Delk’ on a list in Vance’s own document case and arranges for a conductor’s brother to have been hurt in a bridge collapse thirty years ago?”

Arthur said nothing.

“And the chamomile isn’t something someone planted,” Hazel continued. “Raymond told me it was his. Made me a cup with his own hands and talked about his mother drinking it. You can’t frame a man with something he’s already claimed.” She paused. “The slippers in Vance’s suite were aligned under the chair. Too neatly for a man who’d collapsed. I’ve been carrying that since Day 2. Raymond straightens curtain tassels that are already straight. He squares his clipboard to the desk edge. His pencil sits parallel to the schedule board. He aligns things. It’s not evidence — it’s who he is. And the night Vance died, Raymond was alone in that suite for five minutes — the man who went to wake him and found what he’d done instead. Whatever else was happening behind that careful face, his hands went on being his hands. Habits don’t stop at a closed door.”

Bernie turned to his closed notebook. Then to Hazel. Then to Arthur. The light had shifted — one of the long rectangles had moved across the tablecloth and was touching the edge of the salt cellar.

“You’re describing a frame,” Arthur said. “Assembled from available materials.”

“I’m describing a person,” Hazel said.

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The silence held for the length of time it took the ceiling fixture to buzz twice and stop.

Bernie opened his notebook. Not to the back page — to the front, where his investigation data lived. He turned pages slowly. Panel measurements,

pressure readings, resistance comparisons across seven access points. The complete record of how Sterling Vance had died. He turned past it to the comparative timeline, the crew schedule analysis, the interviews logged by source and date.

“We have five things,” he said. “Chamomile — Raymond’s private supply, only source on the train. Surname — ‘Delk, R.’ on the casualty list, a brother hurt in the bridge collapse. Panel access — Raymond’s territory, fifteen feet from the suite. Route volunteering — he put his name in three months ago, specifically for this charter.” He looked up. “And the maintenance log. ‘Panel 5, routine.’ Logged the same as every other panel. But Panel 5 is the one with the loosened dial, the missing dust, the immediate airflow response.”

“Five circumstances,” Arthur said. “Not five pieces of evidence.”

“Five circumstances pointing at the same man.” Bernie pushed his spectacles up. “Arthur, what’s the probability that all five are coincidental?”

“I’m not arguing coincidence. I’m arguing arrangement.”

Bernie turned to the back page. The altitude footnote. He’d written it yesterday and filed it as mechanical explanation — the last variable, catalogued and closed.

He read it again.

*Altitude effect — above 10K ft, reduced atmospheric density = less pneumatic buffering. Manual adjustments register immediately.*

Raymond’s voice came back. Not the words as Bernie had recorded them — the words as Raymond had said them, standing at the open panel in the service corridor with his fingers on the left dial.

*You turn the dial up here and the train answers right away. Nothing between you and the effect.*

Bernie had heard a technician explaining a system. A man who’d spent twenty-five years learning the relationship between his inputs and the train’s responses. He’d understood it — felt the kinship of two people who loved the precision of well-mapped systems.

But there was another way to hear it.

*Nothing between you and the effect.*

Not a technician describing physics. A man describing what happens when you adjust the airflow to a locked suite at ten thousand feet and there is no buffer, no delay, no margin between the act and its consequence. A man who knew — not theoretically, not from a manual — that at this altitude, in this section of track, the system would answer immediately.

Bernie set the notebook down. The page stayed open.

“He explained the altitude differential to me yesterday,” he said. “Why Panel 5 responds faster than the others. Shortest ductwork run, and the air is thinner up here — less resistance in the pneumatics.” He looked at Arthur. “He said, ‘You turn the dial and the train answers right away. Nothing between you and the effect.’ I wrote it down as a footnote. Mechanical explanation for an anomaly in my data.”

“And now you’re reading it differently,” Arthur said.

“I’m hearing it differently. There’s a distinction.” Bernie took off his spectacles, breathed on the lenses, cleaned them on his cuff — the old habit, the one that meant he was deciding something. “A man who maintains ventilation systems can explain how altitude affects airflow. That’s knowledge. A man who says ‘nothing between you and the effect’ — with that precision, that intimacy — is describing something he’s felt. He wasn’t teaching me. He was telling me what it’s like.”

Arthur studied the notebook. The open page. The careful handwriting.

“That’s interpretation,” he said. “Not evidence.”

“It’s both.”

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The mountain light moved. The rectangle on the tablecloth had reached the far edge. The buzzing fixture went quiet, then started again.

Arthur put his glasses on. Took them off. Put them back on — the cycle that meant he was turning something over and hadn’t found a place to set it down.

“If Raymond did this,” he said, “I sat across from him in the dining car and asked him direct questions for twenty minutes and he looked me in the eye and answered every one. The Head Steward vouched for him. Twenty-five years of service. Not one complaint.” He folded the glasses and set them beside the cold cup. “If he did this, he’s the best I’ve seen. And I’ve seen a few.”

“Or he’s not that good at all,” Hazel said. “He’s a man who carried something for thirty years and the opportunity arrived and he took it. If it hadn’t arrived, he’d have carried it the rest of his life.” She looked at Arthur. “That’s not deception. That’s patience.”

A bird crossed the window — dark, quick, gone behind the western ridge.

“So what do we do?” Arthur said. The question had arrived where it was always going to arrive. “We’re not law enforcement. We have no jurisdiction, no forensic capability, no authority on this train. We have a surname on a list, a tin of chamomile, and a notebook full of measurements that prove how a man died but not who killed him.”

Bernie watched Hazel. She was facing the mountains — or watching the space where the bird had been, he couldn’t tell. Her hands were in her cardigan pockets.

“The plows are a day or two out,” Arthur said. “San Francisco after that. We can hand everything to the authorities — the photographs, the data, the casualty list. Let them build the case properly.”

Hazel turned from the window.

“I thought I might return Raymond’s blanket,” she said. “The one he lent me on Day 4. I’ve had it in my cabin since then. It seems wrong to keep it any longer.”

The words sat on the table between them. Arthur’s jaw tightened — a small movement, barely visible, but Bernie saw it.

“Hazel.”

“It’s a blanket, Arthur. It needs returning.”

Arthur looked at her for a long moment. She held his gaze — steady, unhurried, the same expression she'd worn in a hundred rooms where the news was bad and the only useful thing was not to flinch.

"Not alone," Arthur said.

Hazel didn't answer. She stood, smoothed her cardigan, and walked toward the Pullman corridor. Her footsteps were quiet on the carpet — unhurried, purposeful, ordinary. The footsteps of a woman running an errand.

Bernie closed his notebook. The altitude footnote was no longer a footnote. Raymond's words were no longer a technician's explanation. And Hazel was not returning a blanket.

The mountains filled the curved windows, bright and indifferent, and the train sat still beneath them.



## Chapter 35: The Errand

The blanket was folded on my lap. I'd done it properly — squared the edges, matched the corners, a fold meant for someone who notices when things aren't straight. It still smelled faintly of cedar and whatever the storage cupboard had been holding before Raymond put it there. Wool holds its smells. Frank's winter coat kept the garage for two years after I moved it to the hall closet, and I never minded because the garage meant him, puttering with his workbench and his timetables and the little brass clock he was always meaning to fix.

The observation car was quiet. The curved windows held nothing but mountains — fully visible for the second day, sharp-edged, the snow catching morning light in a way that made everything look rinsed. Three of the ceiling fixtures had gone dark and a fourth was buzzing in a way that suggested it was thinking about it. The linen on the table still held yesterday's creases and nobody had cleared away Arthur's reading glasses case or the salt cellar or the water ring from my teacup, dried to a pale circle I could have scratched off with a fingernail but didn't.

I sat with the blanket and the mountains and the fact that I had told Arthur I was returning it, which was true, and which was also not the whole truth, and I was old enough to know that those two things can exist in the same sentence without cancelling each other out.

Arthur had gone somewhere. Bernie had gone somewhere. The debate was an hour old and the debate was finished, not because anyone had won but because the three of us had run out of ways to say the same things differently, and now there was only the doing or the not-doing, and I had never been good at not-doing. Frank used to say I couldn't leave a crooked picture on someone else's wall, which was an exaggeration but not by much.

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Skye came in from the dining car direction. No phone in her hand, no headphones, no performance. She looked the way she'd looked in her cabin on Day 8 when I'd gone to her about Alder Creek — the mask put away, the intelligence unhidden, a young woman carrying something she'd been carrying alone for too long.

She sat down across from me without asking and looked at the blanket.

“That’s Raymond’s,” she said.

“He lent it to me on Day 4. I’ve been meaning to return it.”

She studied me for a moment. I let her.

“I need to tell you something,” she said. “And I’m telling you because you’ll know what to do with it, and I don’t, not anymore.”

I waited. Skye was not a person who needed prompting, only space.

“I’ve been going through the train manual — the one I had in the crew lounge. The full engineering spec, not the passenger safety card.” She spoke without hurrying but without pausing either, each fact placed where it belonged before she opened her mouth. “The ventilation system is split-circuit. Seven access panels, each controlling a section of the Pullman corridor and the cabins branching off it. Panel 5 serves the junction where the main supply trunk meets the suite ductwork. Shortest run on the train. At altitude — above ten thousand feet — the pneumatics lose buffering. Less air density, less resistance. Any manual adjustment at Panel 5 registers almost immediately in the suite.”

“Bernie worked that out too,” I said. “From the other direction — measurements, not schematics.”

“I know. I’ve been watching your group.” She said it without apology. “Two paths to the same answer is better than one.”

She reached into her jacket pocket and took out her phone. Turned it toward me. The screen showed a still frame — gray, slightly grainy, the Pullman corridor shot from a low angle. Timestamp in the corner: 18:34, Day 1.

“This is from my pre-stall uploads. The SD card was stolen but these were already on the laptop — I pulled a few frames onto my phone this morning.” She swiped. The next frame was nearly identical — same corridor, same angle — but there was a shadow along the left wall, near where the curtain hung over the panel alcove. Not a person. Not clearly anything. A darkening that hadn’t been in the previous frame.

“I was watching the suite door,” she said. “That was my whole angle — who went in, who came out, when. Not continuously — I was swapping batteries and dumping files; there’s a gap from about twenty to six until a quarter past. This is off to the side, right at the edge of frame. I didn’t notice it when I reviewed the footage the first time because it wasn’t what I was looking for.”

“And now?”

“Now I know where Panel 5 is. And that shadow is in the right place at the right time.” She put the phone down on the table, screen up. “It’s not proof. I know that. But it’s consistent.”

I looked at the frozen corridor on the small bright screen and thought about Raymond standing in that alcove with his hand on a dial, adjusting something he’d adjusted a thousand times before, only this time the adjustment was the point.

“His name is Delk,” I said.

Skye’s eyes moved to mine.

“Raymond Delk. There’s a Delk on the Alder Creek casualty list — R. Delk. His brother.” I kept my voice even because the facts deserved evenness. “He told me about his brother on Day 4. Liked the cold, he said — said it made the steel tighter. I didn’t think anything of it at the time because why would you.” I paused. “And the chamomile on Vance’s tray the night he died — there’s no chamomile in the galley, none stocked on the train. Raymond keeps a tin in his station. His mother’s tea. He made me a cup yesterday and the smell was the same.”

Skye was very still. Not the journalist’s stillness — something older, something underneath.

“The casualty list,” she said. “Tanaka, K. is on that list.”

“I know. I read every name.”

“Robert Delk,” she said. “One of the eleven injured. Steelworker. I chased him for an interview when I was starting the documentary — he’d settled

early, signed the confidentiality agreement, never talked to anyone. I stopped chasing him. He'd earned the quiet."

Neither of us spoke. The mountains held the windows, white and blue and unconcerned with any of it, and somewhere on that list between the T's and the D's were two men whose families were on this train thirty years later — a daughter across from me, a brother tending it — arriving at the same place from different directions.

"Three years," Skye said, quietly. Not to me, exactly. "Three years building a case against Vance for what he did. And someone on this train built a different kind of case." She picked up her phone and put it back in her pocket. "I wanted to put him in a courtroom. Raymond wanted something else."

"Yes."

"My father's name is on that list and so is his brother's, and I don't know what to do with that."

"No," I said. "I don't imagine you do."

She looked at the blanket on my lap. Then at me. Whatever she saw in my face, she didn't ask about it. She stood, and she nodded once — not agreement, not farewell, just acknowledgment that something had passed between us that didn't need wrapping in more words — and she walked back toward the dining car, and I was alone again.

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The light had moved while we talked. The long rectangles on the mahogany had shifted east — mid-morning, the sun clearing the ridgeline, the shadows shortening until everything briefly looked clean and unhurried and nothing like what was actually happening on this train.

I smoothed the blanket on my lap. The wool was coarse under my palms, honestly made.

Frank kept the Rockies timetable in the hall table drawer for eleven years. I found it after he died — Union Pacific, Chicago to Emeryville, annotated in his handwriting. The departure times circled in blue ballpoint, a note in the margin that said *window seat — LEFT side for Rockies*, underlined twice.

Eleven years of planning a trip he never mentioned was urgent, because it wasn't urgent, because there would always be next year, because carrying a plan is easy when you believe the opportunity will come.

He ran out of time. I was on his train now, in his forward-facing seat, and the mountains he'd planned eleven years for were right there through the glass, and he wasn't here to see them, and I had long since stopped being angry about that because anger requires someone to be angry at and Frank hadn't died on purpose. He'd just run out of time.

Raymond Delk had carried something for thirty years too. Not a timetable — a brother broken at Alder Creek and a name he couldn't do anything about. And then the opportunity arrived, not next year but this year, this charter, this route, and he'd put his name in three months early and packed his mother's chamomile and come to work.

The difference was that Frank's carrying led to a trip his wife took without him, and Raymond's led to a dead man in a locked suite. The scale was not the same, and I was not fool enough to confuse them, but I understood what it was to hold a thing so long the holding becomes ordinary and you forget it's heavy until the day you set it down.

I stood up. The blanket was folded and the morning was clear and the corridor toward the front of the train was dim and cold and I knew the way.

It was a blanket. It needed returning. And there were things I wanted to ask Raymond Delk that couldn't wait for San Francisco, because some questions only work when you're standing close enough to see whether the answer is true, and I had spent forty years in rooms where that mattered and I was not going to start waiting now.

I walked toward the front of the train. The carpet was worn thin in the middle of the corridor where ten days of the same feet had tracked the same path, and the brass fittings had gone dull, and the blanket was warm against my arms, and the mountains through every window I passed were brilliant and unhelpful and absolutely silent.

## Chapter 36: The Engine Car

The corridor narrowed past the dining car, and the train shed its pretenses as Hazel moved forward. Carpet gave way to rubber matting, then bare steel plating. The mahogany panels ended. The brass sconces disappeared. The walls became painted metal, then unpainted, rivets exposed, inspection markings stenciled in yellow.

She passed through Raymond's station — the small cubby where she'd sat yesterday morning and drunk his mother's chamomile. The clipboard hung straight on its hook. The pencil lay parallel to the schedule board. The tin box sat on the shelf beside the electric kettle, lid closed. Everything aligned, everything attended to, the room empty.

The forward door was steel-framed and heavier than the others. It opened onto the engine car.

The space had never pretended to be anything but what it was. Steel walls, bolted panels, instrument gauges in rows — round-faced, their needles steady behind scratched glass. The diesel generator's hum was louder here, not the background thrum that had lived beneath the carpeted corridors for ten days but the source of it, a low vibration that rose through the floor grating and settled in the chest. The air smelled of fuel oil and hot metal and grease worked into surfaces over years. Overhead pipes ran exposed along the ceiling, lagged with stained insulation. A fire extinguisher hung by the door, red and industrial, the only color in the room. No linen. No crystal. No carved mahogany. The engine of everything, stripped to its purpose.

Raymond stood at the far panel, one hand resting on a pressure gauge housing. His uniform was pressed, his shoes polished — six days stalled in the mountains and he still looked ready for inspection. He turned at the sound of the door, and his eyes went to the blanket before they went to her face.

"Mrs. Finch." He stepped back from the panel. "You shouldn't be up here. It's cold."

"I've been meaning to return this." She held out the blanket. "You lent it to me on Day 4. I should have brought it back sooner."

He took it with both hands. The wool passed between them. “You didn’t need to come all this way.”

“It seemed wrong to keep it any longer.”

Raymond sat on the metal stool bolted near the instrument panel and set the blanket across his lap. He smoothed it once — squaring the edge that had come loose, aligning the fold — the same automatic gesture Hazel had watched him make with curtain tassels and clipboard edges for ten days. Then his hands went still, resting on the wool.

He looked settled here. Not the professional warmth he carried in the dining car and the corridors, but something quieter. His eyes tracked to a gauge over Hazel’s shoulder, checked the reading without thinking about it, and came back.

The generator hummed. Cold light came through a narrow window set high in the steel wall — not the panoramic glass of the observation car but a functional slit, enough to see weather by. The sky through it was blue.

“I never properly thanked you for the tea,” Hazel said. “The chamomile. Your mother’s, you said.”

“Her habit, not her recipe.” A faint smile — warm, genuine, the Raymond she’d known since Chicago. “She just put the leaves in the pot and waited. Said the water would figure it out.”

“My mother-in-law was the same. Brown Betty teapot. Never cleaned it once in forty years. Said the tannin staining improved the flavor.”

“Sounds like she and my mother would have gotten along.”

“They might have.” Hazel let the warmth hold for a moment. Then: “The chamomile on Mr. Vance’s tray — the night he died. That smell. I’ve been carrying it for ten days.”

Raymond was still for a moment. “It’s a common enough tea.”

“Not on this train,” Hazel said. “The Head Steward confirmed it. No chamomile in the galley, none in the stores. None anywhere — except your station.”

Raymond's hands didn't move on the blanket. His face held the same attentive courtesy. Then his jaw settled — not a flinch but a release, a muscle held for a very long time simply easing.

"Your brother," Hazel said. "You told me he liked the cold. Said it made the steel tighter."

"He did."

He looked at his hands on the blanket. "And the cup," he said. "I'd been bringing him chamomile since Chicago. He always waved it off. That night I set it down on the side table and went back to my rounds."

Hazel thought of the teacup on the corridor tray — barely touched, the smudge on the handle where a hand had gripped it hard and set it down in a hurry. A man alone in a room going wrong around him, his mouth gone bitter and his thoughts gone slow, reaching for the one warm thing within reach and not understanding why it didn't help.

"When Mrs. Voss couldn't raise him at the door, I went up," Raymond said. "I knew before I had my key out. You learn the sound of an empty room." His thumb moved along the folded edge of the blanket. "I opened his air back up at the panel before I went in — the same quarter-turn, the other way. The whole car would have felt the system equalize. I expect you felt it at your soup." He was quiet for a moment. "His slippers were crooked under the chair. I straightened them. I didn't decide to — I found it afterward, the way you find a bruise." His hands went still on the wool. "Five minutes in that room, and that's the part I can't put down. Not the dial. The slippers."

Outside the narrow window, the mountains were white and sharp against a sky that had been clear for two days.

"Delk," she said, quietly. "R. Delk. On the Alder Creek casualty list. In Mr. Vance's own papers."

Raymond's fingers found the folded edge of the blanket and closed around it, gathering the wool slowly into his palms. He looked down at his hands, then back at Hazel.

His face had opened. Not collapsed — the composure was still there, the professional steadiness, the years of holding himself upright in pressed



uniforms on moving trains. But underneath it Hazel could see what she'd seen in hospital corridors and school office doorways and living rooms where people stood when the news had already arrived and the only question remaining was what came next. The lines around his mouth had deepened. His eyes were steady, but the effort of steadiness showed for the first time — a tension in the muscles holding them, as if the face had grown tired of its own discipline.

She knew what that looked like. Forty years of watching people in rooms where the truth was already present and the only question was whether anyone would name it. What she saw in Raymond was not the relief of being caught. It was the relief of being seen — of carrying something so long that even the seeing felt like rest.

"Thirty years," Raymond said. He wasn't looking at Hazel. He was looking past her, at the gauge on the far wall or at something the gauge couldn't measure.

"Bobby still lives in Cheyenne," he said. "Gets around with a cane. He gardens — tomatoes, mostly. Says the altitude's good for them." His fingers worked the edge of the blanket. "He doesn't know I'm on this train."

Hazel heard what lived underneath those words. Not what Raymond had done. What he'd done it for. A brother who gardened and didn't know.

"I'm not here to ask you questions," she said. "I don't think I need to."

"No." His voice was quiet. "I don't expect you do."

His grip tightened on the blanket. Neither of them spoke. The diesel hum filled the space where words would have gone, and Raymond sat with the wool gathered in his hands and his face unhidden, and he was still Raymond — pressed uniform, polished shoes, the man who checked gauges and straightened things and knew the altitude without looking — and he was also what Hazel had come here to find.

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The engine car door opened. Cold corridor air moved across the warmth and Hazel felt it on the backs of her hands.

Arthur came through first — shoulders, then his knees negotiating the steel threshold with the careful deliberation they'd earned. Bernie behind him, notebook pressed to his chest, spectacles catching the overhead light.

Arthur stopped two steps inside. He registered the room — instrument panels, pipes, the industrial smell — with one look. Then his eyes found Raymond on the stool. The blanket gathered in both fists. The face.

Whatever Arthur had been carrying through the corridor — the frame theory, the three federal parallels, the conviction that manufactured evidence looks exactly like this — Hazel watched it leave him. His shoulders dropped a fraction. His jaw, set since he'd said "Not alone" an hour before, unclenched. He'd spent thirty-one years reading people across interview tables, and what Raymond's face held was not the bewilderment of an innocent man confronted with planted evidence. It was recognition. Quiet, exhausted, beyond pretense. Raymond had stopped performing anything at all.

"We seem to have come to the end of it," Arthur said. Flat. The voice that closed things.

Raymond met Arthur's eyes — a moment between two men who understood what was happening and what came after it.

Bernie stepped along the wall, away from the center. He opened his notebook and turned past the panel measurements, past the pressure comparisons, to a transcription of Raymond's maintenance schedule — copied in Bernie's precise hand from the clipboard on Raymond's desk.

"Panel 5," Bernie said. "'Routine.' Every forty-eight hours, same word, same notation, from Chicago to here." He looked at Raymond without accusation. "All in your handwriting, Raymond. Every entry."

Raymond looked at the notebook in Bernie's hands. Then at Arthur. Then back to Hazel.

"Yes," he said.

The word confirmed nothing a courtroom could use and everything this room required. Bernie closed the notebook. He took a pencil from his jacket pocket and wrote something small on the inside of the back cover — a date,

a time, a note no one had asked him to keep — then returned the pencil and held the notebook at his side.

Arthur moved forward. Not quickly. The pace of a man who'd crossed rooms like this before and knew that distance carried its own meaning. He stopped at a space that was neither conversational nor official.

"I'd like you to come with us, Raymond. The Head Steward's office. Until we reach San Francisco."

Raymond nodded. He looked at the blanket in his hands, then loosened his grip deliberately — finger by finger, as if each required its own decision. He refolded the wool, edges squared, and his hands trembled once during the folding. He set it on the stool beside him and stood.

He straightened his jacket. Adjusted his cap, which had not been crooked.

"The heating schedule will need monitoring," he said. "Every six hours. The generator's running at sixty percent and the rear Pullman loses climate control overnight if the draw isn't managed." He looked around the engine car — the dials, the panels, the steel walls he'd worked among for ten days — and his eyes stayed a moment on the pressure gauge he'd been checking when Hazel walked in. "The rotation chart is on my desk, top sheet. The Head Steward knows the protocol but he hasn't run it since Denver in 2019. He'll need reminding about the overnight balance."

"I'll see to it," Arthur said.

Raymond walked toward the door. He paused beside Hazel — close enough that she could see where a button on his jacket had been re sewn by hand, small stitches, neat and even, the work of someone who attended to things.

"Thank you for returning the blanket, Mrs. Finch."

He moved past her. Arthur fell into step behind and slightly to the left — the corridor position, covering without crowding. Bernie followed, notebook under his arm.

Hazel stood alone in the engine car. The instrument needles held their positions. The generator hummed at the pitch it had held for ten days, the machinery attending to its own steady work, indifferent to everything that

had happened in the room it powered. The stool sat empty. The blanket lay folded where Raymond had left it, edges precise. The narrow window showed mountains and sky and nothing else.

She picked it up. The wool was warm where his hands had been.

She walked back through the steel corridor, past Raymond's empty station where the chamomile tin sat on its shelf and the clipboard hung straight on its hook and the pencil lay parallel to the schedule board, and everything was in its place except the man who'd put it there.

## Chapter 37: The Forward-Facing Seat

The corridors were the same corridors. That shouldn't have surprised me, but it did — the same worn carpet, the same dull brass, the same three sconces dark between the dining car and the Pullman — as though the train hadn't noticed that anything had changed. The blanket was warm in my arms. I carried it the way you carry something you don't quite know what to do with yet, which is to say carefully, against your chest, like a casserole dish you're returning to a neighbour who has moved away.

I passed through Raymond's station without stopping. The chamomile tin sat on its shelf. The clipboard hung straight. The pencil lay parallel to the schedule board, and the electric kettle was cold, and the mug was clean on its hook. I had stood in that room only yesterday and drunk his mother's tea and told him it was lovely, and it had been lovely, and I kept walking.

The Head Steward's office was two doors past the galley on the port side. Arthur was outside it, standing with his back to the corridor wall and his arms crossed, and his knees were clearly bothering him because he'd shifted his weight to his left leg, the right one done for the morning but the rest of him not ready to sit down.

The door was closed. Whatever was happening on the other side of it was quiet.

"He's settled," Arthur said. Not a report, exactly. An answer to the question I hadn't asked.

"You don't need to stand here."

He looked at the door, then at me. His jaw worked once, the last bit of the Marshal letting go of the post. "No," he said. "I suppose I don't."

He matched my pace without being asked, and his right knee clicked on the second stride — it always does — and neither of us mentioned it because we'd stopped mentioning it somewhere around the second national park.

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Bernie was in the observation car. He was sitting in what had become his chair since Chicago — the one nearest the curved window on the left side, where the morning light was best for reading and where, if you leaned

forward, you could see the track ahead curving into the mountains. His spectacles were pushed up on his forehead. His notebook was on the table in front of him, closed. His pencil was in his jacket pocket. He was looking out the window at the Rockies, which were doing what the Rockies had been doing for ten days — being enormous, being white, being entirely unconcerned with us — and he didn't turn when we came in, although he said, "There's tea in the carafe. It's not hot."

"It hasn't been hot since Tuesday," I said, which was true and which was also the first thing I'd said in twenty minutes that wasn't about Raymond Delk.

I set the blanket on the seat beside me. It stayed where I put it, folded, the edges still squared from Raymond's hands in the engine car. Arthur lowered himself into his chair with the controlled descent that meant both knees were protesting, and I poured three cups of tea from the thermal carafe, and it was lukewarm and slightly stewed, and nobody complained because we'd been drinking lukewarm stewed tea for six days and complaining about it had lost its novelty somewhere around the fourth day.

The biscuit tin was on the table where I'd left it that morning, next to Arthur's reading glasses case, which had been sitting there since yesterday and which I hadn't cleared because I'd had other things on my mind and Arthur never clears anything himself, a trait he shares with Frank and with most men I've known, although Frank at least had the decency to look sheepish about it. I opened the tin. Three biscuits — Julian had given me what was left from a tin he'd unearthed in the galley. The lemon zest had faded days ago, but shortbread is forgiving.

Arthur took one. Bernie took one without looking away from the window. I took the last one and closed the empty tin and put it back on the table, because an empty tin is still a tin and it would need washing before I could use it again, assuming Julian would let me back in his galley, which was not guaranteed given how I'd left the butter situation last time.

"Bernie," Arthur said.

Bernie turned from the window. His spectacles slid down from his forehead to his nose, which happened often enough that I suspected he kept them up there specifically so they'd be available for the journey down.

“I was calculating the snowpack,” Bernie said. “On that ridge. The northeast face.”

“Of course you were,” Arthur said.

“Fourteen inches, give or take. Based on the shadow depth and the angle of accumulation relative to the prevailing wind, which has been northwest for—”

“Bernie.”

“Yes.”

“We don’t need to know about the snowpack.”

Bernie considered this. “No,” he said. “I suppose we don’t.” He picked up his biscuit and bit into it, and I watched him chew with the thoughtful expression he gives to everything he puts in his mouth, as though the shortbread might have data in it. “Although if anyone’s interested, the melt rate at this altitude suggests the tracks should be clear within—”

“Nobody’s interested,” Arthur said, but his mouth did the thing it does, the almost-smile that he has never once admitted to, and Bernie saw it and I saw it and the three of us sat there for a moment with our lukewarm tea and our last biscuits and the mountains filling every window, and it was the first time in ten days that the observation car felt like a place where people sat instead of a place where people worked.

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“The Head Steward went through his cabin this morning,” Arthur said. “Inventory, for the handover. Skye’s SD card was at the bottom of a drawer, wrapped in a service cloth. Never read — there’s no laptop in that cabin, no reader. He took it because she’d been filming the Pullman corridor, and he couldn’t know what her camera had caught. It goes back to her today.”

I thought of Skye filming the storm that wasn’t the storm, and said nothing.

“I walked the steward station too,” Arthur went on. “Miller heard Vance ring the intercom, near the end. The board in that station lights a bulb the size of a pea, and in the hour before a Welcome Dinner every hand on this train

is in the dining car laying silver. It rang to an empty room. No sabotage. Just a train doing what trains do at dinner time.”

“The sawtooth,” Bernie said, to the window. We waited. “The reading at dinner. I had the sign inverted. I treated it as the air being taken away, and it was the air coming back — he’d already opened the circuit by the time we felt our ears pop. The murder never showed on my tracker at all.” He pushed his spectacles up his nose. “The instrument only ever recorded him putting it right.”

Nobody said anything to that, because there was nothing to say to it.

“He’ll need a lawyer,” Arthur said, after a while. He said it to his tea, not to us, and his voice was flat and practical. “A good one. Federal jurisdiction, possibly state — depends on where exactly the train was when it happened. The altitude puts us in Colorado, but the charter agreement may complicate venue.”

“Arthur,” I said.

He stopped.

“Not today.”

He looked at me. Then he nodded, once, and drank his tea, and that was the end of it. The law would sort out what the law sorted out. We had done our part, which was the noticing, and the rest belonged to people with offices and filing cabinets and the authority to do something about it, and I was seventy-two years old and sitting in a train in the Rocky Mountains and I did not need to think about federal jurisdiction on the clearest afternoon we’d had in a week.

Bernie was looking at the mountains again. Not calculating — just looking. His notebook stayed closed. I’d seen him write something in the back of it an hour ago, in the engine car, and I didn’t ask what it was because Bernie’s records were Bernie’s, and some things people put down on paper are for themselves and not for sharing, and I’d spent enough years as a school secretary to know that.

The light moved. It had been moving all morning — the slow rotation of the sun across a sky that had been white for six days and was now, for the



second day running, a blue so clean it looked artificial, as though someone had painted it overnight while we weren't watching. The shadow of the ridgeline had pulled back from the western windows and the observation car was bright in a way it hadn't been since before the storm, and the brass fittings, dull as they were, caught the light and threw small gold shapes onto the mahogany that I hadn't seen in days.

Frank would have liked this light. He would have said something about it — probably the wrong thing, probably something about lumens or exposure settings, because Frank had spent two years taking photography classes at the community college and had retained just enough vocabulary to be annoying about natural light without ever actually taking a good photograph. But he would have liked it.

"That peak," Bernie said, pointing. "The one with the cornice. Do either of you know what that is?"

"A mountain," Arthur said.

"It's Mount Jasper. Thirteen thousand, two hundred and eleven feet. Or thirteen thousand, two hundred and fourteen, depending on which survey you trust, and I personally trust the 1987 USGS because the 2004 revision used satellite data that I have questions about."

"You have questions about everything," I said.

"That's not a criticism, is it?"

"No, dear. It's a description."

Bernie smiled. It was the smile he has when he's been caught being himself and doesn't mind — the one that reminds me why Arthur has kept him as a friend for fifty years and why Linda, for all that she left him, never stopped calling on his birthday. He is a difficult man in the way that good men are often difficult: not because they don't care, but because caring looks different on them than it does on everyone else, and you have to be paying attention to see it.

The observation car was quiet. The generator hummed beneath us, the same steady pitch, the machinery doing its work below the floor and behind the walls and never asking to be thanked for it. Outside, the mountains

hadn't moved. Arthur's reading glasses case sat on the table where it had been sitting since yesterday. The biscuit tin was empty. The tea had gone cold. The blanket was on the seat beside me, folded, and I left it there.

We sat together for a long time without talking. Outside, the snow caught the light and gave it back, and the Rockies did not move, and the train did not move, and the three of us did not move, and for the first time in ten days that was enough.

## Chapter 38: The Descent

Julian heard the change before he felt it. A shift in the generator's pitch — lower, steadier, the diesel finding a gear it hadn't used in six days. He was standing at the narrow window above the secondary sink, where the light was best and the galley smelled of the bread he'd baked that morning with the last of the flour. His phone sat on the counter beside the cutting board. No messages. No signal for three days, and before that the single period he'd been waiting for had never come.

Through the window, the mountains were white and still and indifferent to his problems. Somewhere behind them, under snow, a forest service road led to a maintenance turnout where a man with a truck had been meant to meet him nine days ago. The crates sat in the cargo hold on the lowest shelf, labeled in his own handwriting, and they would ride with him all the way to San Francisco, and what happened after that was a question he could not answer from a galley that was running out of butter.

He wiped down the counter that was already clean.

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Skye's laptop was open on the fold-down desk. The cursor blinked at the top of an empty document — the third empty document she'd opened that morning. The first two she'd deleted after typing a sentence each, neither of which had been the right sentence, and she hadn't found the right one yet.

Three years. Forty thousand followers built from nothing, eight months of performing a person she'd invented, and the man she'd come to expose was dead, and the man who'd killed him was sitting in the Head Steward's office with the door closed. She'd expected to find a villain. She'd found a man whose brother gardened tomatoes in Cheyenne and who made chamomile tea from a tin his mother had used.

Her spiral notebooks were stacked on the berth behind her, colored tabs marking three years of research — corporate filings, bridge inspection reports, settlement documents, her father's name on a list. She picked up her reading glasses and put them down again. The cursor blinked.

Outside, the mountains had been the same view for nearly a week. Then they weren't.

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Miller and Elena were in the observation car, in the chairs nearest the rear window where the afternoon light came in low and warm. Elena was knitting — something small, a child's hat in soft gray wool, the needles working without hurry. Her knitting bag sat on the floor beside her, lighter than it had been when she boarded in Chicago, the stolen bottles gone, the secret told, the bag holding only yarn and needles and a paperback she'd been reading since Tuesday.

Miller sat beside her with his hands resting on his knees. His collar was unbuttoned. His jacket hung open. He was watching Elena's hands move without watching the pattern emerge, and neither of them was talking, and neither of them needed to.

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The Head Steward's office was quiet. The door stayed closed.

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The shudder came at 2:47 in the afternoon. It started somewhere forward — a deep mechanical groan, then the brakes releasing, then a lurch that ran through every car like a current through wire. Julian's hand shot out and caught a copper pan before it swung free of the overhead rack. Skye's laptop slid two inches across the desk. In the observation car, Elena's needles stopped. Miller straightened. The thermal carafe on the trio's table shifted against Arthur's glasses case, and Hazel put her hand on it without thinking.

Then movement. Not fast — a crawl at first, the wheels finding the rail again after six days of stillness, the sound of steel on steel returning to a train that had forgotten it was supposed to travel. Snow cracked and fell from the undercarriage. The windows, crusted white on the windward side, began to clear in long streaks as the motion pulled the frost loose.

The landscape moved. After a week of the same white ridge, the same frozen pines, the same sky — it moved. Slowly, then with gathering sureness, the mountains began to slide past the windows, and the observation car filled with the old gentle rocking that had been absent so long it felt new.

Bernie, sitting at his usual chair by the curved glass, leaned forward. His spectacles were on his nose. His notebook lay untouched on the table behind him. He watched the first new ridge appear around the bend — granite and snow and a single bare aspen catching the light — and he didn't calculate anything. He just watched.

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The descent took two days — the rest of the Rockies, then desert, then the Sierras. The train found its rhythm — slow through the high passes where the plows had been, faster on the western grades where the snow thinned and the pines gave way to brown grass and scrub oak. The altitude dropped and the air changed, thickening, warming, the thin bite of ten thousand feet softening into something the lungs didn't have to work for.

Staff reappeared in pressed uniforms. Silver replaced stainless in the dining car. The observation car's brass fittings, dull for a week, caught late afternoon light and held it. The train remembered what it was.

Mountains became foothills. Foothills became valley. The sun tracked west ahead of them, pulling the light down through the Central Valley in long gold sheets, and the windows that had shown nothing but white and gray now held California — brown hills, dry grass, the distant suggestion of water.

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The platform at Emeryville was quiet. Two uniformed officers stood near the far end, by a bench and a transit map, not at attention but present. A third waited by a dark sedan parked beyond the platform railing. No lights. No urgency. Procedure.

Arthur walked Raymond out through the forward car. The Head Steward followed a step behind, gray temples, careful hands, the man who had vouched for Raymond without hesitation and who had not been wrong about his character, only about what his character had decided to do. Hazel and Bernie came after them, Hazel in her cardigan and sensible shoes, Bernie with his notebook under his arm, and the five of them moved through the corridors in a quiet line that the other passengers watched.

Julian stood in the galley doorway as they passed. He held a dishcloth in both hands and said nothing. Skye watched from her cabin window as they stepped onto the platform — five figures in the late light, one of them in a conductor's uniform with his cap on straight.

Raymond walked steadily. He'd straightened his jacket before leaving the office, adjusted his cap, checked the buttons — the small preparations of a man who had always believed that how you presented yourself mattered, even now, even for this. The platform concrete was clean and sun-warmed, and the air smelled of diesel and eucalyptus and the bay somewhere behind the buildings.

Arthur stopped six paces from the officers. Raymond stopped beside him. The Head Steward stood to the side, his face holding something he hadn't found words for yet.

Hazel stepped forward.

She didn't say anything. She put her arms around Raymond and held him — not briefly, not for show, but the way she had held people in hospital corridors and on school office doorsteps and in living rooms where the hardest thing had already happened and the only thing left was to let someone know they were not alone in the room where it had happened.

Raymond's hands came up slowly. He put his arms around her and held on, and his chin dropped to her shoulder, and he closed his eyes. His fingers pressed into the wool of her cardigan — thirty years of carrying something, and someone had finally stood close enough to feel the weight of it.

Then he let go. He straightened. He touched his cap once — habit, not adjustment — and turned toward the officers. Arthur nodded to the nearest uniform and said something too low for the platform to hear, and Raymond walked forward, and they received him without ceremony, and the sedan's doors opened and closed, and that was how it ended.

Hazel and Bernie turned back toward the train. Arthur stayed on the platform for another minute, watching the sedan pull away. Then he followed them inside, favoring his right leg on the step, and the train began to empty.

Passengers collected luggage from cabins that had been home for ten days. Porters reappeared. The observation car lost its people one by one — the chairs that had held readers and worriers and Bernie with his snowpack estimates, vacated, the tables cleared, the thermal carafe removed by a steward who wiped the surface and moved on. The brass caught the last of the California light through windows that no one was sitting beside anymore.

The train settled into its berth. The generator wound down, and the hum that had lived beneath everything for ten days faded, and the silence it left behind was not empty but finished, the quiet of a machine that had done what it was built to do and was resting now, and the platform outside was warm and still.

## Chapter 39: The Observation Car

The observation car was quiet in a way it hadn't been since Chicago. Not the quiet of people choosing not to talk — we'd had plenty of that, Bernie and Arthur and I, sitting with our tea and our separate thoughts while the mountains filled the windows and the investigation filled everything else. This was the quiet of a room that had been left. The thermal carafe was gone. The steward had wiped down the tables and moved on, and the chairs sat empty in two neat rows, and the brass fittings along the window frames caught the late California light and held it, which was what they'd been built to do and which they did better without people in the way.

I was sitting in Hazel's chair. That's what Bernie had started calling it around Day 4, which I'd told him was presumptuous and which I'd also never corrected, because it was my chair, and we both knew it, and correcting Bernie when he's right only encourages him to be right more often.

My suitcase was packed and standing by the corridor door. Arthur had carried it down from my cabin twenty minutes ago without being asked, which is the sort of thing Arthur does — not kindness, exactly, but logistics. He and Bernie were somewhere forward, sorting out the porter situation or the taxi situation or whatever situation men sort out on platforms when they need something to do with their hands. They'd come for me when it was time. They always do.

I had my notebook open on the table. I'd been writing in it — not much, just a few lines about the platform, about Raymond walking steadily between the officers, about the eucalyptus smell in the air and the way the concrete had been warm under my shoes after ten days of cold steel floors. I wanted to put it down while it was still close. You lose things if you wait. Frank used to say that about photographs — the light changes, the face changes, and then you're remembering a memory instead of the thing itself — and he was right about that, even if most of his photographs came out blurry.

The timetable was in the front pocket of my suitcase. I got up and unzipped the pocket and took it out and brought it back to my chair, which required more getting up and sitting down than I would have liked, but the observation car was empty and nobody was counting.



It was a single sheet, printed from a railway website, folded into quarters. Frank's handwriting was on it: *Window seat — LEFT side for Rockies* in the top margin, underlined twice, the note I'd been carrying in my head since Chicago. And, in the blue ballpoint he kept in the kitchen drawer, two practical notes — next to the Carrow Tunnel, *10,000+ ft — bring gum for ears?*; next to Emeryville, *cab to Fisherman's Wharf, ask about senior discount*. That was Frank. The man planned a dream trip across the Rocky Mountains and his two practical notes were about chewing gum and saving four dollars on a taxi.

I'd found it in the hall table drawer three weeks after he died, underneath the phone book and a takeout menu from the Chinese place that had closed two years earlier. He'd never mentioned it. He'd printed it out and folded it up and put it in a drawer and never said a word, which was either because he'd forgotten about it or because he'd known, somehow, that the trip wasn't going to happen for him and he hadn't wanted to make it into something sad. With Frank it could have been either. He forgot where he put his reading glasses at least once a day, but he also knew things about himself that he kept quiet about, and I'd learned over forty-one years not to ask which was which because the answer was usually both.

I refolded the timetable along its creases and put it back inside the notebook. The creases were soft now. They'd go on getting softer.

Outside the windows the light was doing something I hadn't seen in ten days — coming in low and warm and golden instead of flat and white — California light in the late afternoon when there's nothing between the sun and the ground but air and the smell of dry grass. The mountains were behind us. I couldn't see them anymore from this angle, and I didn't turn around to look, because I'd looked at them long enough and they'd looked at me long enough and we'd both made our assessments.

The blanket was on the seat beside me, where it had been since yesterday. Folded, edges squared, Raymond's hands still in the creases. I left it there. Someone would find it on the next trip, and it would keep them warm without explaining itself, which is all a blanket needs to do.

I closed the notebook. The brass clasp on my pen clicked shut — a small, clean sound in an empty car — and I put the pen in my cardigan pocket, where it settled next to a biscuit crumb and a tissue I'd been carrying since Tuesday and had forgotten about, which is the kind of pocket Frank would have called “an archaeological dig” and which I called “perfectly functional, thank you.”

The observation car held the light a moment longer. The curved windows, the polished wood, the empty chairs in their rows. It was a beautiful room. It had been a beautiful room when we'd boarded in Chicago, and it had been a beautiful room during the storm, and it was a beautiful room now, and none of what had happened inside it had changed that.

“Hazel.”

Arthur was in the doorway. He'd put his jacket on — the good one, the one he wears when he's going to be seen by people who aren't us — and his hair was combed, and he was leaning slightly to the left, which meant his right knee had given up for the day and the left one was covering for it.

“There's a taxi,” he said. “If you're ready.”

“She's ready,” Bernie said, appearing behind Arthur's shoulder with his notebook under his arm and his spectacles on his nose and his collar buttoned wrong, the left side one hole too high, which I would fix in the taxi because telling him now would only delay things. “The platform temperature is sixty-eight degrees, which I mention only because it's the first time in ten days the ambient air has been above fifty, and I thought someone might appreciate that.”

“Nobody appreciates that, Bernie,” Arthur said.

“Hazel appreciates it.”

“I do, dear,” I said, and I stood up, and I left the notebook on the table for a moment while I checked my cardigan pockets — pen, tissue, crumb, nothing else — and then I picked up the notebook and walked to the door where my suitcase was waiting and my friends were waiting and California was waiting outside, sixty-eight degrees and golden.

Arthur took the suitcase. I let him. Bernie held the corridor door and said, “After you,” with the small bow he does, the one his ex-wife Linda once described as “Continental” and which is actually just Bernie being Bernie, which is the same thing, when you think about it.

We walked through the corridor and out through the vestibule and down the metal steps to the platform, Arthur’s right knee clicking on the second step the way it always does, Bernie counting the steps because Bernie counts everything, and me between them in my cardigan and my sensible shoes, carrying a notebook full of ten days and a timetable with Frank’s handwriting on it and nothing else I couldn’t set down.

The platform was warm. The air smelled of diesel and dry grass and something else — salt, maybe, or the bay, or just California being California after ten days of mountain cold. The train sat behind us, brass and mahogany and glass, quiet now, resting. Ahead of us a taxi idled at the curb with its windows down.

We walked toward it, the three of us, and the sun was in front of us, and the afternoon was long, and we did not look back.

